

Story Creator



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Hello!

Welcome authors! I know we don't have a lot of time to waste. We wanna be writing, not reading, so let's not beat around the books. You love story. I love story. We love story. Match made in literary heaven. But we both think there should be an easier way to develop stories. A more streamlined method for putting ideas down on paper, be it digital or otherwise. There are lots of guide books out there that are fantastic. Lots of advice from the best writers, old, new, and upcoming. But they were too haughty, too stuffy, too specific, or just too hard to read for my taste. Plus, I wanted everything I learned in one place. So I put all that research together, along with my own ideas, to make a **workflow** that helps writers conceptualize, develop, and execute our ideas faster and better. That's what this is. A guide book to help you focus on what is important. A map to avoid writer's block, multiple first drafts, and endless editing. If you're a beginner, cool, let's learn some magic. If you're an expert, let's streamline your spell casting. Join me, writing wizard, and let's all Build Better Stories. Welcome to Story Creator.

(Cue epic Theme Music)

The Method

May The Force Be With You

(End Theme Music)

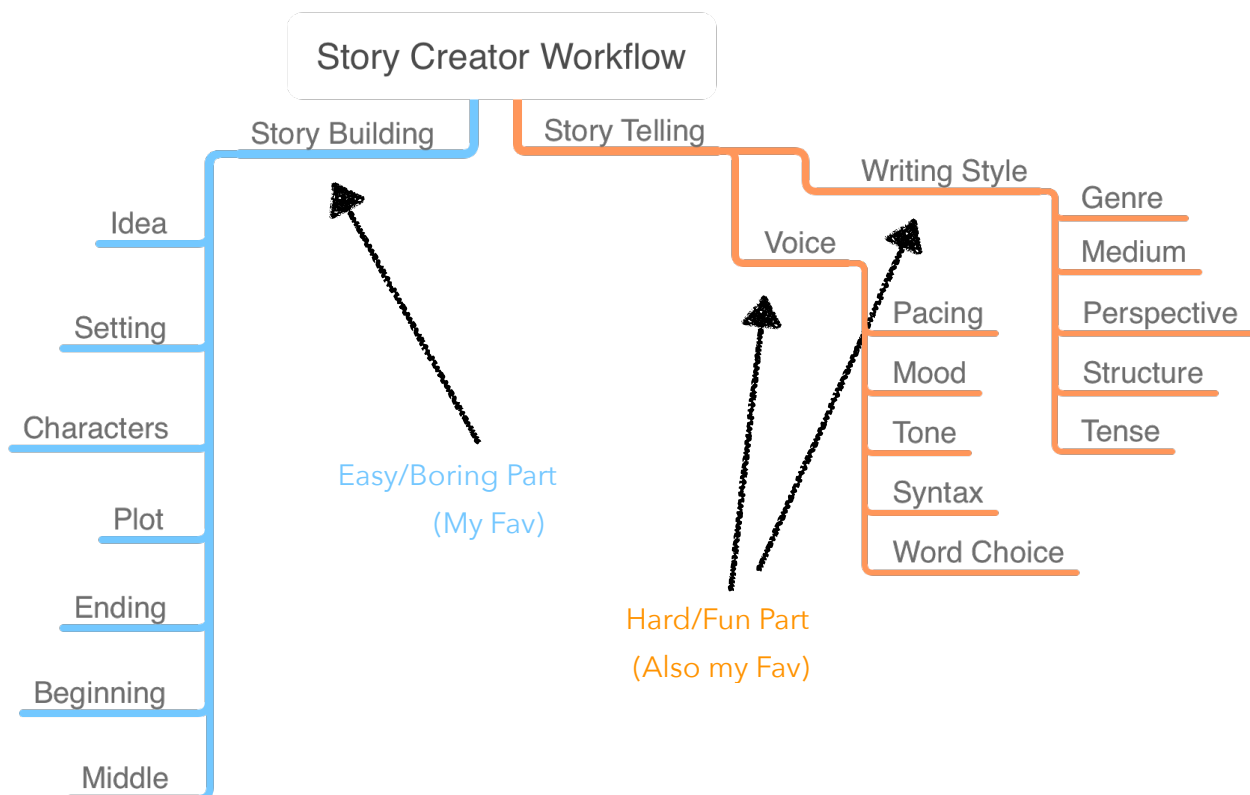
Let's get straight to it!

The Story Creator Method is the macro to micro approach to story development.

Pretty simple, really. Think of big things first, then the little things. Why? Cause that's how things are done in the world. You need a plot of land before you can build a house. You need a canvas before you can paint. Since we are dealing with thoughts and concepts, we need that metaphorical canvas. Then we can decide what we want to paint, with what types of paint and yada yada yada.

The great thing about this macro to micro way of thinking is that it organizes all the chaotic creativity in your imaginative brain. A story isn't an endless sandbox like WOW or GTA. (Those be video games with no end, you non-nerds) It's a specific series of events happening in a specific location with specific people over a specific period of time. We can't think of it as nebulous. It isn't.

Let's get graphic



So you wanna write something? Well, the first thing you gotta know is that there are two parts to writing a story. **How it's built and how it's told.** After much deliberation, a team of scientists came up with the terms "Story Building", and "Story Telling". Money well spent. What we want to do as writers is to tell a compelling story, right? (I hear you, avant-garde hippy expressionist. Feelings and emotions yada yada, but the point is the same.) You can't tell a good story unless you know what the H-E-Double-Hockey-Sticks the story is. So we shall start from the very beginning: **Story Building**. From there, we will explore the vastly more technical and intricate world of **storytelling**. (It's as scary as it sounds.) Don't feel pressured to fit into any boxes while you absorb this. The goal is for you to write your own stories in your own style using your own voice. You will hopefully come out the other side with a workflow of deliberate creative thinking.

Oh, and there's a super important part of story creator that deals with the 7-Essential Story Elements. But you won't jump into that pool of goodness until later. Just know that's coming, and it's glorious! Are you ready for the main event? Are...are you sure? Wanna grab a snack? Notebook? Okeyday! Set a course to Method System. Engage!

Story Building

Bonjour, mon amis! Let us, in highly attractive French accents, discuss story building. Writers often will begin with an idea and will simply start writing with only a vague sense of what needs to happen. You've done a bunch of research, watched all the videos, talked to all the people, gone to all the places, and now have all this useful chaos inside your head. Now what? Knowing where you're going and the distinctive complexities of your story help you not only to create a better first draft, they let you discover more about your idea than you had previously thought.

Some people start writing scenes and piece the scenes together. Some people use notecards or stickies, or napkins to jot ideas down. They end up with a jumble of thoughts that have to be deciphered before they can be utilized. It's like we as writers think of a code, then spend a whole bunch of time trying to crack it. Let's fix that.

Story Building Work Flow

1. Idea
2. Setting
3. Characters
4. Plot
 - Intention
 - Obstacle
 - Stakes
 - Timeframe
5. The ending
6. The beginning
7. The middle

But why this order, you ask! Give me a reason, you say! Fine! I will! Creating your story in this order lets you zoom in on what your story really is. The **idea** is the largest, most broad part of the story. It's often a silly little brain tickle but sometimes it's a big fancy theme. **A theme is a central idea, concept, or philosophy that is explored in a story.** A step below your idea is your **setting**, aka, your world. Knowing the where and when gives you a backdrop which will support your idea and color everything else. After your setting is

established then the **characters** have a place to grow. The world you have created has already begun to influence who and what your characters are, and since they drive your plot along you need to develop them after the setting but before the plot. You might be writing because of the idea, but the audience is partaking in your journey because of the characters. Once you have the people in your story you need the adventure they will embark upon. Your **plot** consists of the **Intention, Obstacle, Stakes, and Timeframe**. Your characters need an intention, aka *super objective*, something that they *have* to do. What will make their story compelling is the obstacle that is in their way and the stakes that they face if they win or lose including the timeframe they are dealing with. Once you know what your characters are trying to do, what's stopping them, and why they must do it, then you need to know how it ends. Now all you have to do is connect the dots by filling the story in with scenes. Voilà! Rocket science!

Pssst...Remember  that this is the easy part...

Spoilers incoming!!!!

EXAMPLE: Toy Story

Idea: What if toys had lives of their own when we aren't watching?

Setting: Andy's suburban bedroom in the mid 90's.

Characters: Woody the Cowboy, Buzz Lightyear the Space Man, and Andy the kid.

PLOT INTENTION: Woody wants to be Andy's favorite toy.

PLOT OBSTACLE: Woody is jealous of Andy's new toy, Buzz, and they both get lost.

PLOT STAKES: If Woody and Buzz don't work together then they could be lost forever!

PLOT TIMEFRAME: Woody has only two days until Andy moves away into a new house.

ENDING: Woody and Buzz learn to work together, make it home safely and both become Andy's favorite toys.

EXAMPLE: Enders Game

Idea: What if child geniuses had to save humanity from an alien invasion.

Setting: Battle school, in orbit around earth in the near future.

Characters: Ender Wiggin, Valentine/Peter Wiggin, The Battle School teachers and students.

PLOT INTENTION: Ender (6) must learn to save humanity from the alien invasion in battle school.

PLOT OBSTACLE: Ender is the target of malicious students and manipulative teachers.

PLOT STAKES: If Ender fails, then humanity will be eradicated by the buggers.

PLOT TIMEFRAME: He has until the invasion fleet arrives which is in 5 years.

ENDING: Ender is tricked into leading a human invasion fleet to destroy the alien home world committing the largest xenocide ever.

EXAMPLE: **Saving Private Ryan**

Idea: What if US soldiers were sent to rescue a paratrooper whose brothers were killed in action.

Setting: France during WW2 after D-Day

Characters: Captain Miller, his squad, and Private Ryan

PLOT INTENTION: Captain Miller and his squad must find Private Ryan somewhere behind enemy lines and get him home.

PLOT OBSTACLE: All the Nazis. And a War. And they've no idea where he is.

PLOT STAKES: If they fail, they all could die, including Ryan, and Ryan's mother will have lost all her four sons.

PLOT TIMEFRAME: They have to find Private Ryan before the Nazis kill him.

ENDING: The squad finds Ryan and sacrifices their lives to get him home.

Let's go deeper.

Idea

Let There Be Thought!

Why start with an idea and not a plot or a character? The answer is... those can be ideas. An IDEA is anything. It's the spark that can become a story and it doesn't matter what that spark is. The important thing about an idea or a concept is that whatever it is, it plants a seed. If you can't imagine anything about an idea, or it doesn't excite you in any way, then find another. But if the idea ignites something within you and makes you think, then it's a good idea. The development and execution of the idea is what will make the idea grow into something great.

It begins with a **what if** statement.

IDEA EXAMPLES:

- What if toys had a life of their own- **Toy story, Small Soldiers, Winnie the Pooh**
- What if super hero's had normal lives- **Hancock, The Incredibles, Kick-Ass**
- What if dinosaurs where alive- **Jurassic Park, King Kong, Journey to the Center of the Earth**
- What if dogs could talk- **Dr. Dolittle, Homeward Bound, All Dogs go to Heaven**
- What if a guy fell in love with a girl- **The Big Sick, Love Actually, Wall-E**
- What if magic was real- **Harry Potter, The Dresden Files, The Lord of the Rings**
- What if we lived on Mars- **Mission to Mars, Stranger in a Strange Land, Ilium**
- What if we could go back in time- **About Time, Interstellar, The Time Machine**

The possibilities are literally endless and can range from silly to serious. Any concept can fit into any genre, any idea can become any type of story, and all that matters is that it means something to you. Coming up with an idea can come in a variety of forms. If uninspired, then talk to others, watch film or T.V, or go on a vacation. Find something you are passionate about, for good or bad, and start there.

Let's say you have an idea for a character. A witch who feeds off of giggles. That idea came to me while I tickled my son and pretended to be a witch who collects giggles. Don't judge me. I was sleepy. Anywho... there's my idea.

Idea: What if there was a story about a giggle witch?

IN SUMMATION

What is your *spark*? What is the reason for you leaving the great before and embarking on the journey into your new life? By phrasing it with a what if, you take something small and make it large. The end result might be something different, but this is how you get to your masterpiece. Your what if can be super specific like a character, or it can be bigger. A theme. Something like *What if there was a story about how in the face of innocence a corrupted soul can find their way back to the light*. There you have a story about the deeper meaning of redemption. Sexy. Ideas come from life and the world around you. Don't judge the source and don't make this a big huge massive time suck. Whatever you come up with, make sure it's something that interests you. That's really the major criteria here. Have an interesting thought, and let's build from there.

Homework

Come up with some ideas and write them down. Start each one with a what if statement. The ideas can be as simple as "What if there was a story about a boy falling in love with a girl" or as complex as "What if there was a story exploring the moral and ethical philosophy of Emmanuel Kant. The setting could be a Heaven type of place where people go once they die. And it could star Ted Danson and Anna from Frozen!" Remember, the idea doesn't need to be fleshed out yet, that's what the rest of this is for. And if you got a bunch of ideas, write them all down! Ready, set, go!

Setting

From Chaos To Order

Where are you right now? In a room? On a computer? Are you on a pirate ship perchance? Setting is the background color that helps your picture stand out. This is the world that your story takes place in. It influences everything. E.V.E.R.Y.T.H.I.N.G! Even if it's "Here and Now" setting matters because "Here and Now" are still very specific places in space and time. Setting dictates culture. Think about that. What people do, wear, sound like, act like, all are dependent upon the when and where. If you know your setting, then you will understand your story's culture.

Here are 4 basic questions you should think about for your story:

When?

This is the time period that the story takes place in. A story set in the past or future is going to change the technology, dialect, history, everything. This is the first part of culture that you need to develop. Your 'when' can be simple like the date, but it can also be a little deeper. Think about if there are any major events that are taking place. Is this during a pandemic, a war, a revolution? Whatever event is going on will add depth to your setting, even if the story doesn't focus on it. The event taking place can be huge, like war, or small like in the middle of a busy week. The when can dictate the urgency in which the story begins.

Imagine this. What if there was a love story taking place present day with an interracial couple. Black dude falls in love with a white dude. Lovely! Now imagine the same story set in the 1800's. Well, my goodness is that going to be a touch more dramatic. Time is very important.

Where?

This is the main location or locations of the story. Obviously you need to know where your story takes place. Where, similar to when, helps define culture. A middle class boy in London is much different than a middle class hobbit in the Shire. Where can be as specific as *"The cupboard underneath the stairs of the Dursley's at 4 Privet drive, London, England"* or more broad like *Middle Earth*. The more specific the better because that will force you to really think about the people in your story. And as you develop your where, write down other

places your character may go. Building yourself a map of the locations you want to explore in your story can help you keep track of where and what your characters are doing.

Imagine a love story with two men of different races, set in San Francisco, present day. That story easily can be about LGBTQ+ culture or how two men find love. San Francisco openly celebrates gay men, so writing a simple love story is easy with this where.

Now replace San Francisco with Jackson, Mississippi. As of 2023 there isn't a thriving LGBTQ+ community, and in the south two guys wouldn't have an easy time being in an open relationship. Especially if one was white and the other black. Mississippi culture is very different than North Cali culture. Homophobia and racism are both prevalent in the south, so even if the story isn't about that, it would definitely be a part of the characters lives.

What makes this setting unique?

Each location should be unique in some way. The more generic a setting the more generic the background of your story will be. That dulls a story, makes the audience less interested. Nobody wants that. But if you give the setting something unique, then that's another little color your get to add. Something like an interesting bit of history, an important landmark, or something super personal to one of the characters like a family home. Whatever this unique thing is it will give us an anchor to remember the setting.

Example: This is the apartment where a famous actor was murdered.

Example: This city is known for its corrupt politicians.

Example: This town is famous for its celebrities.

Example: This house is always creaking.

Example: This country has never seen war.

Why this place and not another?

This is the reason for the necessity of the setting. Ask yourself, why? What is so important about the setting you choose. Does it set a character up as a villain? A hero? A thief? Does your setting mean greater adversity or set them for a harder fall? Starting a character in a place that they hate or love is compelling, as it either reminds them where they want to get back to, or stay away from at all costs. You need to know *why* you are choosing your locations. If they don't have a meaning, then it won't matter. **Make it matter.**

If we apply what we just learned to our giggle witch story we might end up with something like this.

When: 1930's

Where: Chicago

What makes this setting unique: Chicago was a growing metropolitan city famous for Italian gangsters.

Why this place and not another: Chicago is the busiest city in the midwest and close to the great lakes. There are mobsters everywhere, and enough diversity that there are lots of options for cool characters. It's a great hub for an adventure both in the city and outside in the wilds. It's also in a swamp which slowly sank the city a few times. That could be useful for adventures!

IN SUMMATION

Setting is all about the feel of your story. It affects the audience on a deeper level that they are often unaware of, but they can't help but talk about later. You don't have to tell them everything, but you should know it yourself. If you nail your setting everything else will come to life. The best thing about knowing your setting before most everything else is that it can help you discover who the characters really are. It's harder to have the character guide you to the setting. Not impossible, just harder. Knowing your setting will drastically alter how you think of everything else so it's best to know it early. It will lead you to more interesting things.

Homework

So you've written down an idea. Or maybe a bunch. Choose the one that is at the front of your brain and build the setting. Let each section influence the next. Don't get caught up in having the perfect setting yet, we just want the creative juices to flow.

Characters

Who are you?

Characters! Whoohoo! The paint in our proverbial painting! These are the vessels in which your story wraps itself around. Characters are the people, places, or things that live in your story and influence the narrative. Yes, places and things can be characters. Think Wilson in *Castaway*. We are going to focus on people as characters in this book, but regardless of the type of characters you want in your story they need to have thought out **character arcs**. A character arc is a personal journey that a character takes within a story. We will talk more about those later. Let's talk about the fundamentals.

There are four basic characters

- **Protagonists**
- **Secondary Characters (aka Deuteragonists)**
- **Tertiary Characters**
- **Antagonists**

When creating each character they each should be developed fully, so don't skimp on their details. Always, always, **always** make them feel real. They can be ridiculous, or crazy or whathaveyou, but they can't just be plot devices. A plot device is a character, item, location, or event that is used solely to advance the plot. Characters for sure can, and should, advance the plot. But if that is their only function then, for an audience, it feels predictable and cheap. Let's avoid that, my friends, and make every character, no matter how small, a full person.

Character Perspective

It's common for writers to center their story around common archetypical characters. A story about two kingdoms fighting, for example, typically follows the royal family or the most fearsome fighters, and most definitely the evil conqueror. Writing from these common perspectives can make an audience member feel as if they've heard the story before, even if they haven't. And even if your take on an

archetype is brand new, the similarities may give away major plot points before you intended. The perspective may be too familiar.

Writing from uncommon perspectives can give your story a unique feeling. If you want to tell the story about two rival kingdoms, what if you wrote it from the perspective of a squire who can't fight, but works with a famous knight. Or a courtesan who is having a romantic affair with the noble prince's servant. Or the mother of a king a la Lady Stark in *Game of Thrones*. By changing the perspective you can get the same story across, but with a different lens, making the archetypes feel both similar, and unique. Remember this when you start building your characters.

Protagonist:

Your main character. We follow this storyline the closest. The main plot is directly influenced by and is centered around the protagonist. An **active protagonist** is one in which the decisions and actions they take are entirely up to them and come from an internal moral compass. A **passive protagonist** is one in which the decisions and actions they take are entirely forced upon them and come from an external source. Now, I don't want to force you into a box, but active protagonists are more interesting because their decisions matter more. Passive characters, in general, don't earn a lot of sympathy from audiences. We want as much sympathy as we can squeeze out of them. Passivity is death. Especially for our most important characters.

For our giggle witch story let's have the protagonist be Yemina O'Hara, our giggle witch.

Why Them?

As you are making your protagonist ask yourself, "Why should this person be my main character?" The answer can't be because their name is in the title. Boohiss. The protagonist should be **the most compelling character in your story**. If your protagonist is not as interesting as someone else, then that someone else should be your lead. And if that's the case, make the switch. Don't be afraid. You can still tell the same story. And remember we are just building right now. If you build everyone well, then swapping protagonists is easy peasy.

Secondary Character:

The secondary character, or deuteragonist, is the second most important character or characters that assist in the protagonist's story. This is the "almost" protagonist. Main character adjacent. They monopolize the B plot of a story and have major influence on the protagonist. They must relate to the protagonist in some form or fashion on either a spiritual, physical, or mental level, otherwise they will feel superfluous. Same faith, same disabilities, same ideologies, same family, etc. For ensemble based stories, you may have multiple deuteragonists like in *Lord of the Rings*.

Our secondary character shall be our giggle witches "adopted" son Gentleman O'Hara.

Tertiary Characters:

Your ensemble characters. A tertiary character is one that affects your main plot the least, but still has significant impact to the protagonist and the story itself. Tertiary characters can provide comedic relief, a unique perspective of the main characters, and/or major and minor plot points to the main story. They can also be used to support the theme of the story. Theme based tertiary characters represent something to the protagonist which reinforces decisions the main character needs to make. Whether they serve as breaks from the action or major plot devices, tertiary characters should be built out like secondary characters.

You may not know who all your tertiary characters are when you start writing. They tend to appear as the need for them arises. If they do pop up in your first draft, take a moment to fill them out so they don't serve only a single function. Wrap them in reality, darling, to give them importance and substance.

Let's give our protagonist some sisters that help/hinder our protagonist on her quest. Yara and Yellow O'Hara.

Antagonist:

The person place or thing that is at odds with the Protagonist. The antagonist is the main source of conflict in your story. There are two types of antagonist. Tangible and intangible. Tangible antagonists are people, and in that case they should be developed like a

Protagonist. **Intangible antagonists** are things like governments, social systems, insecurities, natural disasters, diseases, things like that. That's some pretty complex stuff which we will explore later. Intangible antagonists still have complexity but may not have some of the same aspects of a person. For now let's deal with people.

Note: The goal of the antagonist should be in CLEAR AND DIRECT CONFLICT to the protagonist's goal. It should challenge the protagonist in a personal way.

This one seems easy for our giggle witch story. We need a witch hunter. Long Eye Joe is his name!

IN SUMMATION

Stories work best when every character has a specific reason for being a part of the story. If you have characters that don't add anything important then they can bog down your story and weaken it. Don't be afraid of cutting out characters or combining them into one, especially if they are currently only plot devices. A brutal term for that is to KILL YOUR DARLINGS! I prefer the less brutal and more sci-fi oriented AGGLUTINATE ALL ACQUAINTANCES. (I had to find a cool word that meant "To stick together". You're welcome.) Not only will it streamline your story, combining characters can make them more dynamic and interesting. If you can cut a character out and it doesn't affect the main plot, then they need to go. Exterminate!

And I want you to double remember that right now we are still assembling all our tools. We don't even have a plot yet. As you build your characters if you think your protagonist would be a better antagonist and your tertiary character would make for a better secondary character, then do it. Do you boo. Do you.

Basic Character Traits

So we talked about the types of characters, now let's talk about what they are made of. Having multifaceted characters makes your story deeper even if you don't fully explore everything about them. Just knowing who they are and why they are the way they are can help you write them and make your story feel personal and important.

You can also use any of these traits to help you shape what your story is going to be about. You can focus on one, three or a bunch of them to make your story as layered as you want. But even if you don't, simply knowing the most important parts of your people will make them feel organic.

Here are keystone features you should develop in order to create compelling characters.

Who

Basic details. If your character was born today what would be on their birth certificate? Name, Sex, Age, Race, Profession. Each detail is important in knowing who someone is.

Yemina O'Hara, Female, 156, Black, Giggle Witch/CEO of a Doula empire.

Strength

What are they best at? This can be anything from actual physical strength to emotional, spiritual, or intellectual strength. Knowing the strength of a character gives you the choice of how to use their strength. Do they know about it already? Are they learning about it? The strength will be useful in getting them in and out of trouble.

Yemina is a cunning wordsmith.

Strength Reason

Why do they have this strength? This strength is going to help them out or hinder them during the story so give them the reason for their strength.

Yemina had to learn how to talk her way out of trouble growing up in the confederate south for the past hundred and fifty years.

Weakness

What are they worst at? What is the character flaw that hinders them most? Like the strength, this can be anything from actual physical weakness to emotional, spiritual, or intellectual weakness.

Yemina's ego and ambition will be her downfall.

Weakness Reason

Why do they have this weakness? Reasons are important. This character flaw is going to be the thing they need to recognize and overcome in order to succeed, so give a strong personal reason for why they have it.

Yemina's gained a lot of power and is now a touch full of herself.

Inner Conflict

What are they internally struggling with? Characters all have something that they are worried about, dealing with, or fighting against inside of themselves. It is a conflict that is either spiritual, mental, or emotional that will be tested throughout the story. Kinda like normal people, interestingly enough.

Yemina feels like despite her power she's still a third class citizen.

Inner Conflict Reason

Why are they struggling? What are the reasons that the characters are having an internal conflict? What in their past, present, or future causes them to worry now?

No matter how much social power Yemina gains, she is still mistreated by everyone, especially wealthy white men.

Established Norm

Before the plot begins, what is the character doing? This is important because it helps define who the person was before the story begins so we can discover who they become after the climax. This is what would continuously be happening to the characters and the world around the characters if nothing extraordinary happened.

Yemina is building the largest doula/midwife company in the world.

Goal

Also known as the objective, this is the thing that the character wants most in life before the plot begins. It has to be PERSONAL. This goal will help establish what drives the character which will help us to understand them.

Yemina wants to be accepted by the elite of the elite.

Goal Reason

Why do they want this thing? A goal without a reason is a bad plot device. A goal with a reason gives the audience a desire to care about your main character. Whatever reason you choose for your characters goal will establish whether or not the audience has sympathy for them. The more the merrier.

Yemina feels that if the elite love her then she will finally feel respected, something she's never felt.

What makes them Dynamic?

What makes this character unique? A dynamic character is one that has a unique trait that is often in opposition of another unique trait. If they want to be a good guy, then growing up with thieves will help make them much more interesting. Juxtaposition, hypocrisy, and/or dilemma are great tools in creating a dynamic character.

She's a dangerously ruthless woman with a soft spot for children.

Concerning secondary characters, tertiary characters, and antagonists

For these folks build them just like protagonists. You might end up liking one of them so much they become your protagonist. If that is the case, then you'll be glad you built them out. Better to have it and not need it, than not have it and need it. For non protagonists we are just gonna add a few things to link them all together.

Significance?

What makes this character important to the protagonist? Every character in the story needs a purpose. They need to serve the plot and the character arc of the protagonist in a way that is vital.

Gentleman O'Hara: He is a loving, good natured adopted son that embodies everything Yemina wants to be. Happy, powerful, and confident.

Yara & Yellow O'Hara: They are the sisters to Yemina and push her to be even more ruthlessly ambitious than she already is.

Similarity?

What makes this character similar to the protagonist? Secondary, tertiary and antagonist characters must have something in common with the protagonist. It helps make their relationships make sense. It can be a character trait, goal, inner conflict, etc. Having a similarity adds depth and potential drama to the story.

Gentleman O'Hara: Yemina and Gentleman both feel like they aren't strong enough to do the things they want to do.

Yara & Yellow O'Hara: The sisters all feel like their lives would be better if the elite respected them more.

Let's put this into practice with our giggle witch story.

	Protagonist	Secondary	Tertiary	Antagonist
Who	Yemina O'Hara, Female, 156, Black, Giggle Witch/Doula	Gentleman O'Hara, Male, 18, Black, Sorcerer/Entrepreneur	Yara & Yellow O'Hara, Females, 154 & 150, Black, Giggle Witches/Businessladies	Long Eye Joe, Male, 45, Apache Native American, Witch Hunter/Mercenary
Strength	Cunning wordsmith	Optimistic	Ruthless	Intuitive
Strength Reason	Had to learn how to talk her way out of trouble growing up in the confederate south.	He was raised to be joyful and proud and never knew true hardship.	They saw that the only way to survive as both black women and witches was to never give up and gain power by any means necessary.	He has spent his life learning how people, especially magic folk, work.
Weakness	Ego and Ambition	Naivety	Selfishness	He tries too hard to fit in.
Weakness Reason	She's gained a lot of power and is a touch full of herself.	He was a raised in a mansion in the woods by his mothers and never dealt with strangers.	They spent so much time trying to survive they can forget to care about anyone else.	His family was apart of the "Civilized Five Tribes" who tried to acclimate to a white lifestyle.
Inner Conflict	She feels like despite her power, she's still a second class citizen.	He wants to help people, but he doesn't know how.	They feel like their opinions don't matter and that they have no real power.	He is ashamed that he wants to know more about his people and their traditions.
Inner Conflict Reason	No matter how much social power she gains, she is still mistreated by everyone, especially rich white men.	He's never helped strangers before. It's the only thing he doesn't have confidence in.	They grew up in a world where they were always disrespected and each don't have as much magic as their oldest sister.	He was taught to abandon the old ways, but his great grandfather was a famous war chief who secretly taught him how to "Be Apache"

Established Norm	She is building the largest doula/ midwife company in the world.	He was adopted and raised to be a great man by witches. He has just turned 18 and is ready to leave the nest for the first time.	They are running the largest doula/ midwife company in the world.	He is hunting witches in the Midwest for money.
Goal	She wants to be accepted by the elite of the elite.	He wants to find a way to help and be of service to people.	They want to dominate the elite class.	He wants to be accepted by white people.
Goal Reason	She feels if the elite love her then she will finally feel respected.	He feels like helping people was what he was born for.	They want people to listen to what they have to say for a change.	No matter where he goes he stands out which makes him feel horrible.
What makes them Dynamic	She's a dangerously ruthless woman with a soft spot for children.	He's a kind hearted young man eager to serve humanity who grew up secluded learning magic from three giggle witches and has never helped another person in his life.	They are ruthless and selfish, but when it comes to their adopted son Gentleman, they are selfless and loving. They can be evil, yet they run a business for women's health.	He is both trying to erase his traditions and learn more about them.
Significance	N/A	Gentleman is the "Son" of Yemina and is the most important person in her life. He embodies everything Yemina wants to be herself.	They are the sisters to Yemina and push her to be even more ambitious than she already is.	He has been hunting the giggle witches for twenty years.
Similarity	N/A	They both feel like they aren't strong enough to do the things they want to do.	The sisters all feel like their lives would be better if the elite respected them more.	He like Yemina, wants to be accepted by the people around them.

IN SUMMATION

There is a ton of information there. The beauty of finding out all these character traits is that it will inspire a multitude of stories to write. This could be a fantastic story about how

the giggle witches came to power. Or what Gentleman does once he leaves the nest. Matter of fact we could make him the protagonist if we want! If you want to switch protagonists it's an easy thing to do. YOUR story, you noble author you, can focus on developing the intricacies of any and all the character traits you want. You have so many great directions you can take your story, now. You simply have to choose!

Bonus!!! Motifs

Motifs are distinct patterns that reoccur throughout your story. They can be phrases, symbols, or descriptions that you use over and over to give your audience clues and/or to help certain things stand out. You can heighten your theme/idea by using motifs. Motifs can help tie together your "message" and what you want the audience to take away from the story. Motifs can also help the audience distinguish your different settings and characters by giving them an easily recognizable "Thing".

Motifs and settings? Crazy idea. But how? Why? Well, let me tell you. If you have a story set in a few cities and each city has a unique motif, then the audience can easily recognize where they are. Imagine if one city smelled like roses and one smelled like booboo. Each time a character comments on the smell of a city you would know exactly where you are.

As for characters the more characters you create, the easier it is to forget whose who, even if the voices are unique and the stories are polar opposites. Giving characters "Funny Hats" to quote Neil Gaimen, or **Character Motifs** can easily help distinguish who's who. A limp, a constant brag, an unsightly itch, a strange voice. Anything can set a character apart from another, and calling back to a "funny hat" can make it that much more relatable, interesting, and recognizable. If you have a character who says a particular phrase over and over "Do you trust me?" Then even if they are in disguise we can recognize them with a strategically placed bit of dialogue. Motif can be a whole new world!

One beautiful thing about motifs are their ability to clue your audience into things. If you want to lead your audience on an adventure where by the end they put the pieces together, motifs can be the pieces. Then you get people Sherlocking your story, saying things like "I knew it was him cause he has a limp and smells like jam and the other person asked him about that smell and if his leg hurt. I knew it! Haha! Awesome!" Motifs are awesome. You might not find inspiration for motifs in your rough draft, but in your reread, find them and scatter them where you see fit. This is the way.

Homework

1. Create characters! For now, just do one of each, unless you feel inspired to do more. Again, let each section influence the next. Draw from life, from movies, from anywhere. If you have an idea already for a plot, then design your characters around that. If not, then just make people you wish you could meet, or that you hate, or whatever. Whatever you do, keep your idea and setting in mind as you build. Let everything you've done so far be a result of what you've done before. Have fun!

2. Give your character a funny hat. If it ends up being used as more than just an identifier then bravo!

Character and Story Arcs

I See Great Conflict In You

A character arc is a personal journey that the character takes within a story. The protagonists character arc is intrinsically tied to the main story arc, one influencing the other. It is a personal journey that defines their personality. What makes them so important is that we as *people* are following the journey of the *people*. *People* are all unique. People are interesting. They have different motives, different personalities, different profiles. The human element is what hooks us as audience members. How do characters change, that's the question. The plot is what keeps the story progressing, but it's the character arcs that keep us glued to the plot. The more tied to the plot the character arcs are the more compelling the story will feel.

Think of a detective story about a murder. The story of the murder is the plot, and it's the driving force. But it's the cops, the suspects, the witnesses and their stories that make the case intriguing.

There are four types of character arcs. They each follow the same structure of beginning, middle, and end.

1. Growth Arc
2. The Change Arc
3. The Fall Arc
4. The Flat Arc

The Growth Arc

The Growth Arc is a character arc in which the character begins their journey as a dark person, is challenged, and becomes a better person.

You see this arc when a character believes in doing something that is a detriment to themselves and/or others. That path ultimately fails and they are forced to do something to the betterment of themselves and/or others in order to succeed.

Example:

LaSonia spends her days believing that violence is how you earn respect. By then end of the story she understands that love is how you earn respect.

Our character believes in something bad. We know this. But she... maybe she does, maybe she doesn't. Either way she does violent things cause she feels like she needs to. When we first see her we can smell the corruption and rot on her. But as the story develops, she grows as a person. She finds new core values she didn't know she had. It's why they call it a growth arc. She grows.

The Change Arc

The Change Arc is a character arc in which the character begins their journey as one type of person, is challenged, and becomes a different type of person. You see this arc with characters who believe in something that ultimately hinders them. They discover that there is a different way to live that is ultimately better for them.

Example:

LaSonia spends her days believing that telling people what they want to hear is how you earn respect. By then end of the story she understands that telling people the truth is how you earn respect.

The change arc doesn't mean they become a better person. Just different. The character believed something that actually makes sense. It ain't bad, just not enough. She doesn't become a better person by the end of the story, just different. Her beliefs could both be negative if you wanted. As long as they change.

The Fall Arc

The Fall Arc is a character arc in which the character begins their journey as one type of person, is challenged, and becomes a darker person. You see this arc with characters who believe in something good but they learn that that good thing doesn't work as well as something bad.

Example:

LaSonia spends her days believing that being kind is how you earn respect. By then end of the story she understands that fear is how you earn respect.

Our character was a good person and believed in good things. But the pains of life wore her down and now she now believes in something bad. This is a common arc for villains, but it can happen to anybody.

The Flat Arc

The Flat Arc is a character arc in which the character begins their journey as one type of person, is challenged, and stays the same. You see this arc with characters who believe in something so much that nothing changes them.

Example:

LaSonia spends her days believing that love is how you earn respect. By then end of the story she understands that love truly is how you earn respect.

Our character believes the same thing in the beginning that she did in the end. This doesn't mean she can't be challenged. It's best if she is so you see them fighting to maintain who they are. A protagonist with a flat arc is best when surrounded by characters with either change, fall, or growth arcs. A protagonist with a flat arc is typically the catalyst for change in others.

IN SUMMATION

Characters are challenged throughout a story either physically, mentally, spiritually, or emotionally. The more complex a character, the more of those 4 human elements are affected. How they respond to those challenges define what type of arc they have. With the flat arc it is important that the character is extremely interesting from the set up since they will not change throughout the story. With the other arcs, the change on their journey will help make them interesting. Still make them interesting, but be aware that they can morph into something unique. Have an idea in mind what kind of story you want to tell with your characters. What themes do you want to explore and which arc do you think is the best way to explore it? Characters are the most important aspect of your story and watching them change or change others will keep the audience engaged. Remember to tie your character arcs into your plot so that there is a deeper meaning to everything that happens. You do that by **making a plot point a catalyst for character development.**

Homework

For each of your characters, choose a character arc. That's pretty simple. It's also pretty important. Using your character traits as inspiration figure out where you want your character to start and where you want them to end. It can sound something like "In the beginning my Protagonist believes he is defined by his weakness. By the end he defines himself by his strength." Or it can be "In the beginning Billy believed violence is the answer, but by the end he found kindness is the answer." It's your arc, do what you think is most interesting.

Plot

What Had Happened Was...

Ohhhh buddy, here is where things start to happen! **Plot, aka the Story Arc, are the major events in a story that concern the Intention, Obstacle, Stakes and Timeframe.** Let's break that down a bit.

Plot propels your story into a direction. It gives importance, purpose, and urgency to your story. The stronger the plot, the more interested people are in consuming the whole story. Great plots can make us watch dozens of episodes of T.V shows that are poorly done. Great plots can have us standing in line to buy the 5th book of a badly written series. A great plot can change the way a person thinks about life.

Plot is...well... very very important.

While you're developing your story, a powerful way to keep the audience engaged and compelled is to weave your character arcs into your story arc. What that means is **in order for the plot to progress, the characters must change.** The more connected the characters development is to the plot the stronger the whole story will be. Many stories die on the strength of their characters, regardless of plot. Link them, and forever be rewarded.

The four parts of plot are the intention of the characters, the obstacle that is in their way, the stakes they are facing if they win or lose, and the timeframe they have to accomplish their mission. You have to know those four parts before you start writing. Without knowing the four parts of plot it becomes difficult for the story to have cohesive meaning and thus hard for you to know what your doing. Everything can get jumbled, confusing, and just a little icky.

Think of plot like a race. Before the race happens there isn't plot, it's just people doing life. But as soon as the runner hits the track and the gun goes off, boom, the plot begins. The intention is to finish first. The obstacle is the other runners. The stakes are victory or defeat. The time frame is 3. 2. 1.

Let's talk about the four parts of plot.

Intention

Also known as the super objective, the Intention is the motivating factor for the plot. This will be the main focus of your protagonists story and therefore should be life and death either internally or externally. Without the intention, there is no reason for the story. In each scene the protagonists actions should aid them in getting closer to achieving that

intention. The intention is the driving force of the story and can change midway through if you have a large enough story, but most often it doesn't.

Sometimes things can seem to alter the intention's specific goals, but the overarching objective remains the same. Like if the intention is to build a house and midway through the story the hero does it but a mob wants to burn it down! Ahhh!! The intention might seem to switch, but the overall point is that the dude wanted a house.

The Intention supersedes all character goals in level of importance. This doesn't mean that they still don't pursue their regular goals, only that they don't take priority unless it directly affects the plot. This dichotomy pulls the focus of the characters, creating more conflict both internally and externally for them. The intention does not need to be the same as the goal in the beginning. That's important. They can be different things. Layers. Yum! Like a cake!

Giggle Witch Intention: Find the Well of Ascension which holds vast enough power to turn Yemina into a god.

Obstacle

The obstacle serves as the major source of conflict for the plot. The obstacle brings internal and external conflict to the story which forces the characters to grow. This is what is standing in the protagonists way. It can be either internal or external, but regardless it must be deeply personal to the protagonist. In order for the obstacle to be an obstacle there must be an UNAVOIDABLE reason why. If the solution to the obstacle is a "just do that" thing then it will never feel like a true obstacle. It doesn't need to be complicated. In fact it's usually best if it's theoretically simple, just dang hard to realistically do. Make it a big brick wall with spikes covered in flaming oil. The characters just got to get to the other side. Simple...

Giggle Witch Obstacle: The witch hunter, who is trying to kill the giggle witches and any who possess magic, is on her trail!

Stakes

The stakes are what give the story tension. The stakes bring a sense of danger by giving the character repercussions for their actions. Stakes are the major consequences that befall the protagonist if the journey to achieve their intention is a success or a failure. Without

stakes there is no sense of importance and the story feels inconsequential. Stakes give the audience a reason to care and root for success.

Giggle Witch Stakes: If the O'Hara's don't find the Well then they could lose their magic/power and be killed by the witch hunters. If they do find the Well then they could gain the power/respect they seek.

Timeframe

The timeframe is how much time the characters have until they can no longer achieve their intention. This is the ticking time bomb, the lit fuse, the impending doom. Timeframe is what gives urgency to your story and forces your characters to act **now**. The more time a character has the less urgent the story will feel. The less time a character has, the more they are forced to take chances. *Timeframe dictates the pace of your story.*

Giggle Witch Timeframe: They have until the next full moon, when the Well is finally open, which is in seven days.

Lets add a plot to the Giggle Witch Story

PLOT	
Intention	Find the Well of Ascension which holds vast enough power to turn her into a god.
Obstacle	The witch hunter, who is trying to kill the giggle witches and any who possess magic, is on her trail!
Stakes	If the O'Hara's don't find the Well then they could lose their magic/power and be killed by the witch hunters. If they do find the Well then they could gain the power/respect they seek.
Time Frame	They have until the next full moon, when the Well is finally open, which is in seven days.

Woah. Crazy. Well, now I know what the story is about. Knowing this I know exactly where I need to point the ship. I can also start to see certain scenes that are necessary. I need a scene where someone discovers the "Well of Ascension". I need a scene where the witch hunter gets in their way. I need a scene to establish the stakes and timeframe. I'll probably also need a scene where the characters succeed or fail. The story is writing itself and we haven't written a thing!...Well... except the idea, setting, characters, and plot. But you know what I mean. Knowing what the plot is before you start writing is HUGE!!!!!! Do yourself a favor and give yo'self a direction mothersucker! Follow your instincts and see what happens.

Subplots

What in the holy verse are subplots? **Subplots are secondary plots that run parallel to and support the main plot.** This is a great way to link your character arcs into the story arc. They can also change the pacing of a story to feel faster or slower. Subplots might be the hardest/best way, in all actuality, to add simple complexity to any story. Spending time with your secondary and tertiary characters, learning about them and their own stories can add a lot to your main story. While you have your main plot chugging along, all the characters that come in and out of it have lives of their own. Use those lives, those stories, to add meaning and intricacy to the overall story. It's super important to link them to the plot so intrinsically that you can't remove them without ruining everything. There are three basic plots in any given story. A, B, and C.

A Plot: The A plot is the sequence of major events that takes precedence over all other plots and mainly concerns the actions of the protagonist and the antagonist.

B Plot: The B plot is the sequence of events that directly effect and inform the A plot and mainly concern the actions of the Secondary Character and/or the protagonist.

C Plot: The C plot is the sequence of events that indirectly effect and inform the A plot and mainly concerns the tertiary characters and/or the protagonist.

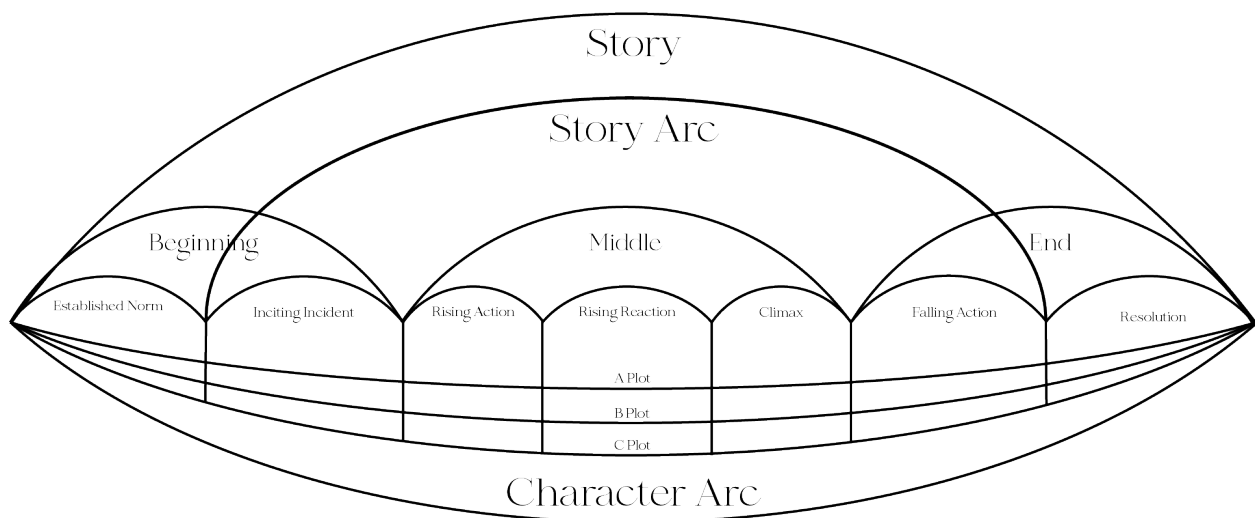
Stories are not limited to just the A, B, and C plot, but most often are. With larger stories following multiple groups of people that don't always interact with each other you may have many more subplots. Most of the time they can be lumped together to serve a single story arc. You may also have multiple A plots if you have multiple Protagonists that

share equal story time or importance. The same is true for B and C plots if you have multiple characters who are equal in importance. Each plot is a story in its own right and have beginnings, middles, and ends. Think them through and you will be rewarded with richness and complexity.

Plots and Subplots			
Story Arc	Beginning	Middle	End
A plot	Your protagonists journey		
B plot	Your secondary characters Journey in relation to your protagonist		
C plot	Your tertiary characters journey in relation to your protagonist		

Now we're cooking with gunpowder! If you treat you B and C plot like you would the A plot then you will have three simple stories weaving in and out of each other. That by itself is enough to add that deeper flavor that you might be looking for.

Look at this diagram. You see on the top the full story. Below that is the story arc, aka the plot. It starts during the Inciting Incident and ends at the Falling Action. Then there is the beginning, middle, and end with each of the story elements beneath that. That is the bulk of your story.



Now look at the character arcs. The A plot is your main character plot and it takes precedence over the others. But all three intersect with all the story elements and the story arc itself. Just develop those stories, making them integral to each other and you've got enough complexity to rival a DNA strand.

Bonus Feature!

If you are writing a series and you want to tie the "episodes" all together, there are a few easy ways to do this.

1. Stagger the introduction of the character arcs and don't resolve the B and/or C plot in the first story.
2. Introduce the Established Norm from your second story mid way through the first.
3. Introduce multiple Inciting Incidents in your first story, but only resolve one.

Staggering character arcs and story arcs are a great way to force readers into the next project of yours. Resolving the main conflict in the first story, but not the secondary and tertiary conflicts makes the audience go "Well gosh darn it, guess I'm gonna have to check out the sequel! What a cliff hanger! Whoowee!"

IN SUMMATION

With the Story Creator Method you are given all the tools for you to construct your fantastic story. That is the science. How you use that is the art. Like a chef with pots, pans, stoves, ovens, spoons, forks, and knives, you need your everyday tools to get the job done right. But how you mix things together, how you flavor everything, how you present your dish is all up to you, and that's where the joy of writing is. Spend time showing the audience how much character development you've done. Develop your B and C plots fully. So many ways to be creative, my friend! Choose your adventure. I recommend trying all of them. But do you boo. Just make it make sense and give reasons for everything.

Homework

1. Build a plot. Like what's been said before, keep everything else you've already done in mind. Especially your protagonist. They are going to be doing the heavy lifting, so design your plot around them.

2. Assign your A, B and C plots. Your protagonist is the A plot, which will be the main plot you already did. The B plot will revolve around your secondary character or antagonist. Your C plot is all about your tertiary character. They can also all revolve around different parts of the protagonist's life.

How To Begin

How does it end? Start here. Do this, please. Don't discover it later on. You can discover other things, don't with this one. When beginning to write a story, start with an idea of how the story ends. Once the ending is known it's easy enough to start the story on the other end of the spectrum. The ending is often the make it or break it portion of a story. Good set up followed by a mediocre ending can make the whole story fall into obscurity. Know your ending, then you know where to begin.

Now what really is an ending? An ending is comprised of your **climax, Falling Action, and resolution**. Basically the big thing the happens, the fallout of that big thing, and the life after. We will explain more about those words in bold later, worry not. For now, let's just pick an ending for our giggle witch story based on the plot we already constructed.

After searching the midwest for seven days the O'Hara's find the Well of Ascension and use its power to bestow magic to all the minorities of Chicago.

Dope. We have an ending. I know what happens now. Because I already know my characters I can let them find the reasons why and how it ends this way. But knowing this will guide you and keep you from writing yourself into a deep dark hole from whence no escape is possible.

And remember, in the prewriting phase everything is fluid. Really think about what you want your story to be about so you don't waste time figuring it out 200 pages in and four months later. If you know where you are trying to go and you get inspired to go into a different direction, sweet, do it. Just remember what experience you want you audience to have, and who your characters are and you should be fine. For now, come up with an ending. And once you know the end...

The Beginning: Exposition

...you know where to begin! The story starts in the opposite place that it ends. Easy peasy. So let's dive in! **The beginning of a story is the Exposition phase, where the most critical information is given to the audience.** The exposition phase is where you introduce the setting and the characters.

First, the audience needs to understand the world and how it works so they can get a feel of where and when the story takes place. This is where you show us the when and where. That will ground US, the audience. We want to feel the landscape, smell the air, taste the... whatever you need to taste. The point is we need to know where and when we are, and we need to know quickly otherwise we will get lost.

You also need to let the audience know **who the characters are and why we should be interested in their journey.** This is where showing their strengths, weaknesses, inner conflicts, goals, and established norms are super handy. Characters are the reason we read or watch or listen to stories, so introduce them and make sure we understand them. Good guys, bad guys, we need to understand them if they are gonna make any sense.

Lastly we also need to set up the plot by introducing the crisis. That's when the adventure begins. Show the audience the characters new intention, the unavoidable obstacle, the serious stakes, and the ticking timeframe. That's a lot for the beginning, but without it, no one is going to know what's happening. The better we understand the setting and the characters the more we will be hooked when the plot begins.

For future reference, the beginning is built from the **Established Norm** and **Inciting Incident.** The life before the storm, and then the storm. Those are two of the 7-Essential Story Elements.

Okay, enough talk, let's build a beginning for our Giggle Witch story. It doesn't have to be perfect, just a starting point. Everything is still fluid, baby.

The O'Hara sisters have been collecting magic for decades, trying to find the secret to ultimate power. But being black women in America can be hard, so they use their magic to disguise themselves as white women. This keeps them safe throughout the brutal dark ages known as American Slavery. To both help their people and themselves they slowly build a massive midwife company. Why

midwife? Because they found a steady source of magic in harvesting giggles from babies. As America and their ambition grows, they decide to experiment to find a stronger magical source. They adopt a baby boy and raise him to be the perfect man. Yes, they harvest his giggles, but what they want is to one day harvest his growing magical power which seems to be greater than their own. However, on Gentleman's first day in the big city he discovers the location to a secret source of untapped magic. The fabled Well of Ascension. He tells his greedy mothers about the Well and they realize this is a huge chance to gain enough power that they could reveal themselves as black witches and no one would be able to stop them from becoming god-like rulers! But the Witch Hunters also know about the Well. Now the O'Hara's are in a race to find the Well before it dries up for a thousand years. The O'Hara's must be careful because a dangerous hunter, Long Eye Joe, is after them, and their son.

Well would you look at that. Not half bad. But what's really important to remember is that I'm just getting ideas out of my head and onto the page. Before this exercise all I had was the basic idea "Giggle Witch", now that has spawned a much more complex adventure that feels a little like the movie version of Neil Gaimen's *Stardust*. Everything in that example synopsis I can use as reference when I get to the real writing. And if I get lost, I can always come back to this to see what my beginning is supposed to be.

One thing of great significance to point out is the beginning should ask the audience a question. How? In this example the question is **"How will the O'Hara's find the Well of Ascension?"** For your beginning you want your audience to be asking how. "How will this end", or "How will they survive?" Or something like that. Whatever the question you are asking your audience, make it simple. The complexity will come within the characters and their circumstances. That's the fun part!

Homework

1. Write a simple ending. Base it entirely off your plot. Did the protagonist win or lose? Or did they kinda sorta win? Either have a clean cut ending, or a messy one, either one. I, personally, like working in shades of color, but Disney is doing quite well in the simple endings department.
2. Once you got your main plot ending, do the same for your subplots. Write your beginning! Just a paragraph or two. Steal from the ending and put your characters on the opposite side of the plot. You know where they end up, so put them somewhere else. Remember your plot, characters, setting, and idea. Let all that influence you.
3. Write the beginning of your B and C plot, just like you are doing for your A plot. Make sure the B and C plot vitally influence the A plot.

The Middle: Conflict

This is the bulk of the story in which the conflict rises both internally and externally for the characters. This is where the situations get a little complicated and where the main characters are challenged the most. During the conflict, the audience needs to understand what steps are being taken for the characters to achieve their goals and intentions and what the consequences of those actions are.

This is also where you explore all those character traits further, especially the reasons. All their strengths and weakness can help you craft how your characters get in and out of danger. That inner conflict can grow and grow and grow. That's what the people want to see. The plot will always be the hook, but the characters growth will be the real thing.

The Giggle Witches send Gentleman to find clues as to where the Well is while they work on distracting the witch hunters. Gentleman must circumnavigate the criminal world in Chicago, and then the wilds of the midwest as he's pursued by Long Eye. Yemina must leave her sanctuary to save her son while the other two giggle witches gather enough babies for a spell that will give them the power to channel the Well.

Again, these are just ideas plopping out of my face and onto the page. I may not know the how's, but by connecting the dots between the beginning and end, they will come. The middle of the story is the bulk of the story, but it is usually the "simplest." How do my characters get from point A, to B. Then B to C. Then so on and so forth. Just follow your characters and let them guide you.

Homework

1. This seems fairly obvious. Just keep going! Write a few sentences or paragraphs on the middle. It should be fairly easy. You know where to go from here. Just follow the signs.
2. Oh and do the same for your Sub Plots. Makes sense right?

The End: CONCLUSION

Do you know what's crazy? You already know this part. You already wrote this down, so now you can just build it out. **The end is the finale of the story.** The climax happens and the consequences are established. This is where the protagonist succeeds or fails and their character arc concludes. The **resolution** establishes the new Established Norm that is a direct result of the climax. The end contains the fulfillment or rejection of the characters original goals. The theme of the story is either revealed or reinforced within the last few scenes to give a sense of purposeful completion to the story. Just like the beginning, the ending can sometimes be a little dense depending on how in-depth you went with your character development. For the most part though all the hard stuff is over and you just gotta answer whatever questions still need answering.

The O'Hara's have to fight the Witch Hunters at the Well in a battle beneath Chicago! Just as the full moon rises the sisters all turn on each other, wanting the power for themselves. But that changes when Gentleman is badly wounded by Long Eye. The sisters let go of their egos and channel the power into their son to save him. Gentleman, after having seen the oppressed people in the midwest on his adventure, redirects the power to give them all a taste of magic. Long Eye gives up trying to satisfy a belief he doesn't have. The sisters all give up on their dreams of pleasing the elite and focus on their families for a change. Gentleman and Long Eye go out to help the communities they saw along their journey. The sisters stop pretending to be white, and continue to run their business despite the white ridicule they now receive.

IN SUMMATION

So, there you have the first part of the Story Creator Method. The story building work flow is designed to inspire each following section. Your idea influences your

setting, which influences your characters, which influence your plot. This macro to micro process will help distill down all your thoughts and help you build a better story faster. It will also help you become a more critical audience member. In the next chapter we are going to explore the enchanted seas of the 7-Essential Story Elements. They will help you develop your beginning, middle, and end. Avast, ye scalywags.

7-Essential Story Elements

Once Upon A Time

Your beginning, middle, and end are the pure broad basics of story. But what exactly is in a beginning? Or middle? I'm sure you've heard of plot points by now. Just in case: **Plot points are individual facts that have significance to your plot.** What that really means is when something happens that directly affects the direction of a story, you have a plot point. Your beginning, middle, and end are constructed of major and minor plot points. A **Major Plot Point** is a significant event within a plot that alters the direction of the Story. A **Minor Plot Point** is an event within a plot that significantly informs a major plot point. It doesn't alter the direction of the story like a major plot point, rather it gives us vital information that justifies a major plot point.

For a major plot point example let's say you have a boy meets girl story. You know they want to get together by the end, so they aren't together in the beginning. A major plot point in that story would be something like dude meets ladyface. Another major plot point would be dude leaves to go live in Africa. Each of those moments change how the direction of the story goes. He HAS to meet her. Fact. Meeting her changes his life somehow and he is forced to explore that. Fact. For some reason he HAS to leave for Africa. Another fact! That's important because he is abandoning her, which could ruin both their lives, but he feels he has to do it. Selfish, but still a fact. Those are crucial moments to the story.

A minor plot point example would be learning that dude is a missionary. It doesn't alter the direction of the story UNTIL the major plot point pops up and he is called to leave the States.

To reiterate, a plot point is a fact, and it is also significant to the plot. If in our example the dude goes to a club and gets drunk, that might not be significant. That's just a scene. Or if when he goes to Africa and she comes with him and everything his hunky-dory, then you've just changed locations, not added a major or minor plot point. It's not a fact that he has to leave if nothing significant happens because of it. There needs to be a major shift in the immediate goals of the characters to really define a major or minor plot point. Significance really is the key here.

You can have as many plot points as you want in your story, but there are seven crucial ones that all storylines need in order to work. They are MAJOR PLOT POINTS! All caps, ya'll. We gettin serious.

After the development of the story using that macro to micro approach the next step in the Story Creator Method is the construction of your story elements. They become the

benchmarks that you aim for when you are building scenes and sequences. Knowing the 7-Essential Story Elements turns writing into a connect-the-dots. You look at where you are in your story, what the next element is, and you write to there. It allows plotters (people who like outlines) and free-writers (anarchists who demand freedom) the ability to do either. Plotters can make outlines connecting every element to each other in greater detail. Free-writers can just get to writing and glance up at their north star every once in a while. This is a really fun part of the Story Creator Method. Let's get into the elements now. The 7-Essential Story Elements are **Established Norm, Inciting Incident, Rising Action, Rising Reaction, Climax, Falling Action, and Resolution.** They are the bones of all stories. You need bones, otherwise you're all wibbly.

Established Norm

The Established Norm is the life of the characters before the Inciting Incident of a story. This is what the characters are doing day to day, dealing with day to day issues. During the Established Norm you find out who your characters are, why we like them, where they are, and what their "normal" goals are. We learn about their strengths, weaknesses, inner conflicts and all the other character traits we talked about earlier. The Established Norm occurs just before the plot beings.

Lamens

This is the intro stuff before the exciting bits happen.

Example - Batman

(Batman's Established Norm everyone should know by now if they grew up on earth.) Little rich kid in the sprawling and criminally rich city of Gotham is present when his parents are murdered, so he is raised by a sardonic butler in a creepy mansion infested with bats and located over a vast network of underground tunnels big enough for a large airport. Now he trains to fight criminals using his money and resources to be BATMAN!

Who - Bruce Wayne

Where - Gotham, the city filled with criminals

Why do we care - A little boy watched his family get murdered. We feel bad for him. And we don't like bad guys.

Goal - To rid the city of crime/vengeance for his family.

Why is it important?

A good Established Norm draws the audience in. It's the bait just waiting for the fish to get close enough. If you butcher the Established Norm no one will care what the rest of the story is about. They might stick around, true, but in the end people will say things like "it started real slow. I had no idea what was going on and who was doing what. What a lame Established Norm." (Where I come from everyone says that last part for sure.) A good Established Norm leaves an audience saying "It's such a great story. It's about this person from this place and all they want to do is this one thing which is really cool. I totes love it. Such a great Established Norm" (Again, that's how people talk where I'm from. Fight me on it.)

In short

The Established Norm is the introduction to your setting and characters. Give your audience everything they need to understand the world and people in it before your plot kicks in.

An Established Norm establishes:

1. Who the characters are
2. Where they are
3. What the characters want
4. Why they want what they want

Homework

Look at your beginning and separate out your Established Norm. See if it establishes everything you need it to. If it does, well done. If not, add what you need.

Inciting Incident

The Inciting Incident is the first major plot point that breaks the protagonist away from the Established Norm and introduces the Plot (Obstacle, Intention, Stakes, and Timeframe). The Inciting Incident changes the characters world then sets them on a deliberate path. They now have something they need to do, something in their way, an understanding of the consequences of success and failure, and a set time to achieve their intention. For stories that apply, this is where your Antagonist does something big.

Lamens

This is where something big happens.

Example: Batman

Everything is going well in Gotham until the joker kidnaps commissioner Gordon and his daughter. OH NO! He leaves a note for batman saying "The commish and his lovely offspring die unless you open Arkham Asylum. You have 24 hours batsy! MUAHAHA!!!" Now Batman has to save commissioner Gordon and his daughter (**Intention**) from the Joker (**Obstacle**) or he will have to open Arkham to keep the Joker from killing them both (**Stakes**) in less than 24hours (**Timeframe**).

Why is it important?

This is the beginning of the plot. Without the Inciting Incident you have a story about people doing things and nothing happens. A day in the life on a boring day. Hardly a compelling story. A good Inciting Incident rips people away from the Established Norm and makes the audience go "Dang! Now what?" A bad Inciting Incident takes people out of the moment and makes them say "Huh? What's happening?"

A good inciting incident also is personal for the characters. In our example with the Dark Knight, Gordon, Batmans only steadfast ally, is in jeopardy. That's huge for our hero. Plus his goal of ridding the city of crime is being tested. If he gives in to the demands of the Joker, the city will be filled with crazy criminals from Arkham. If he doesn't, then his only friend and his friends only daughter die. A great inciting incident asks the question "How will our hero succeed?"

In short

This is the start of your plot. The Inciting Incident is the event in the beginning that changes your story. It makes it about something else. Something bigger. Something important. Something interesting.

An Inciting Incident establishes:

1. Intention
2. Obstacle
3. Stakes
4. Timeframe
5. "How will our hero succeed?"

Homework

Look at your beginning and find your inciting incident. Make sure you establish your plot. And see if your question is clear and obvious. This is the beginning of something grand, so make sure it stands out.

Rising Action

The Rising Action is the series of events after the Inciting Incident that directly affect the characters and advance a plot. These are the actions that the characters take to achieve their new found intentions. This is where the characters are first trying to figure out what they are supposed to be doing and setting plans into motion.

Lamens

This is where people start doing things.

Example: Batman

Batman starts looking for clues leading him all across the city interrogating the Joker's known accomplices. He thinks that if he can find the joker before the deadline, he can save Gordon and his daughter without releasing the inmates of Arkham.

Why is it important?

After the Inciting Incident the audience is asking "What now?" This is that answer. This is where the meat of the story starts and you are either going to entice the people to follow or send them running for the nearest exit. This is where the strengths and weaknesses of all our characters are tested and the inner conflict grows.

In short

The Rising Action consists of every action the characters take after their world turns upside down. The first decisions they make are some mighty important decisions that weigh heavy on their hearts and minds.

A Rising Action establishes:

1. The first steps towards achieving the plots intention.
2. Characters Strengths
3. Characters Weaknesses
4. Growing inner conflict

Homework

Like before, separate out the Rising Action. Think of a couple of things the characters try in order to get closer to victory. This is going to set up some fascinating things in the future, but don't worry about that. Just jot down some cool things you wanna see, based off what you already know.

Rising Reaction

The Rising Reaction is the series of consequences following the Rising Action that directly affect the characters and heighten the conflict of a story. The characters are forced to adapt to new or intensified issues that are directly related to what they'd been previously trying.

Lamens

This is where people get in real trouble!

Example: Batman

After a violent investigation Batman discovers that the Joker is hiding in an abandoned amusement park that is laced with booby traps.

Why is it important?

Every action has an equal and opposite reaction. It's a law. Obey the law. For storytellers it's imperative that the characters' choices mean something, good or bad. Otherwise it's pointless. You've spent all this time filling your story with interesting events and ideas, and if those ideas don't have consequences then what's the point? Good Rising Reactions have audiences saying something like "This is crazy! How on earth are they going to fix it?! I need to know! TELL ME! NOOOOWWWW!!!!"

In short

The Rising Reaction is the amping up of the story leading us to some sort of glorious end! Inner conflict has reached a peak and the characters are either growing into their strengths, or succumbing to their weaknesses.

A Rising Reaction establishes:

1. The expected and unexpected consequences of the characters previous decisions and actions.
2. The characters evolving struggle with their strengths and/or weaknesses.
3. The height of the inner conflict.

Homework

Write down and the consequences of the character actions. Make sure they line up with the Rising Action. Whatever the characters were trying before, what are the fruits of those labors. Remember that regardless of success or failure, they haven't achieved their true intention yet.

Climax

The climax is the turning point in a story which changes the protagonists fate and/or intention for good or bad. This is the penultimate action every character must take or risk never getting what they want and need. This will decide the fate of the characters and everything they've been fighting for. The character will have to deploy everything they have to get what they've been fighting for.

Lamens

This is the mic drop.

Example - Batman

Batman does battle with the Joker! Bang! Wham! KAPOW!

Why is it important?

IT'S THE BEST PART OF THE WHOLE STORY! WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?! WHAT KINDA MONSTER ARE YOU?!

Excuse me. Sorry for yelling.

This is the final payoff. It's the whole reason for everything. This is...the most important thing ever. The character has to come into their full strength in order to have a chance at success. Their inner conflict needs to be resolved, or at least briefly conquered so they can focus. Their weakness has now been realized and, if they are to win, will no longer be a problem. If they fail, then it's their weakness and unresolved inner conflict to blame. The internal and external struggle of the characters are at the tipping point. Bad climaxes hurt the soul. Good ones change ya life.

In short

The climax is the moment we've all been waiting for.

A climax establishes:

1. The final action the characters take
2. The characters in their full strength or weakness

3. The inner conflict is resolved for a victory or further unraveled for defeat

Homework

You got this. Separate your climax out from the other story elements so you can see it clearly. Make sure it makes sense. Make sure you are being honest with your characters and you should be in a great shape.

Falling Action

The Falling Action is the conclusion of the conflict with the success or failure of the protagonist's intention. During the Falling Action we see the consequences of the climax. This is the result of all the actions the characters have taken throughout the story. This is the end of the plot. The intention has either been achieved or lost.

Lamens

Something big just happened, and now we wait to see what's left.

Example: Batman

Batman defeats the Joker, but not before the commissioner dies! Tragic! Oh, and the daughter is paralyzed cause the Joker sucks donkey duck.

Why is it important?

This is the wrap up of the story. It's the first time the audience gets to take a breath. It's the result of the whole entire plot. This is how the story arc ends. This answers the question you proposed in the beginning "How does the hero succeed?" Your audience has been wondering this whole time, so show them.

In short

The Falling Action is the place where you tie things up, at least things revolving around this stories plot.

A Falling Action establishes:

1. The consequence of the characters final actions.
2. The answer to the stories question.

Homework

Rinse and repeat ya'll. Isolate and explore. Did you answer the question? Are things clear? Write down your Falling Action, or find it in what you've written.

Resolution

The resolution is the establishment of the new norm. The plot is over and whoever has survived now has to live in this new world. Whether or not they achieved their intention, they have to live with the results. This is the establishment of that. Your characters have become different people, inside at possibly out.

Lamens

The end. And sorta the beginning.

Example: Batman

A broken Barbra joins a bitter Batman as Oracle, the tech lady who helps the Dark Knight stop villains like the Joker from hurting people, like her father. Oh, and both are severely traumatized and Batman is in hiding cause the Gotham PD are pissed that Batman let their boss die. Hilarious! What a knee slapper!

Why is it important?

This is the final goodbye. This is where you sign off, give the audiences their hearts back and send them on their way. We have been following the characters for a long time so we want to know what happens to them. A bad resolution leaves a bitter taste in peoples mouth due to all the vomiting. A good resolution makes the audience take a moment to think of everything they just went through. And if you want it to, the resolution is simply the Established Norm of the next story.

In short?

This is the final chance you have to change your viewers life.

A resolution establishes:

1. The new normal.
2. The completion of all Character Arcs

Homework

Separate your resolution and look at it. Does it feel right? Who are your characters now? Is this the ending that you wanted? Is this an ending that you love? Make sure, if not, fix it.

In summation

After building all the story elements you have the foundation of your story. It's really that simple. Kinda like theoretical physics or surgery. Easy stuff.

Established Norm -	<u>The Before</u> -	<i>Who should I care about? Why? Where are we?</i>
Inciting Incident -	<u>The Thing</u> -	<i>How will the characters succeed?</i>
Rising Action -	<u>The Decision</u> -	<i>What do we do first?</i>
Rising Reaction -	<u>The Consequences</u> -	<i>What do we do now?</i>
Climax -	<u>The Gamble</u> -	<i>Will this work?</i>
Falling Action -	<u>The Result</u> -	<i>Did we win?</i>
Resolution -	<u>The After</u> -	<i>What next?</i>

Homework

Read your story! Put the paragraphs or sentences in order and read it through. Does it inspire you? Does it bore you? Does the story as a whole seem like something you'd wanna see? If you like what you've done, then you are ready for some writing my friend. If you find yourself hesitating or confused, or disappointed, then look back at each thing you did. Is the setting working? Do your characters all seem strong? Is the plot interesting? Is the ending cool enough? Is the beginning clear and intriguing? Is the middle exciting? Do any rewriting here. This is the structure of your story, so get it right here and you will save yourself weeks of rewriting later. Weeks! I'm saving you time. Which is money. You are very very welcome.

Writing Exercise

Write a 7 sentence story with each sentence being one of 7-Essential Story Elements. The main goal of this exercise is to practice thinking about the individual story elements. The better you understand each story element and how it influences the other, the better your own stories will be.

STORY BUILDING SUMMATION

There it is. Story building. There is the workflow for creating your story. Begin with an idea. Set your setting. Create your characters. Plan your plot. Engineer your ending. Build your beginning. Make your middle. Done-zo. When you are developing your beginning, middle, and end, use the 7-Essential story elements to help you out. It's easier to know what Story Element is dragging your ship down, rather than trying to guess. Build each and every idea out like this and you will save yourself months of re-editing. For people who like to outline, here are your milestones to lace together. Those who like to just see what happens, just figure out how to connect the dots. Let the good times roll!

Storytelling

That Was Totally Wicked

How do I start my first draft!!!!??? AHHHHHH!!!!

Let's talk about storytelling. This is the 2nd part of the Story Creator Method and is the thing most people really really really want to get to. But you gotta do all the building stuff first. Jumping straight into storytelling without the story building part is like going swimming without knowing how. Sure you know to flap your arms and legs, but that ain't swimming. That's slowly drowning. I don't recommend that. So make sure you've built your story before you start this part of the journey.

Storytelling is essentially two main things. **Writing Style** and **Voice**. The expression of a story is the **Writing Style**. It is *The way you* want to **PRESENT** a story. Your Writing Style dictates how the audience views your work. Your **voice** is the unique personality inherent in your writing based upon the way you word things. Your voice is *how* you want to **TELL** your story. If you think of music you might get a good idea of what's going on here. Take Michael Jackson. His "writing style" is pop music. His "voice" is how **he specifically** does pop music. Lyrics, dancing, costumes, etc. So to reiterate, the voice is how the audience consumes your work, and the voice is how you do the work. Teehee! Jam on!

Warning!

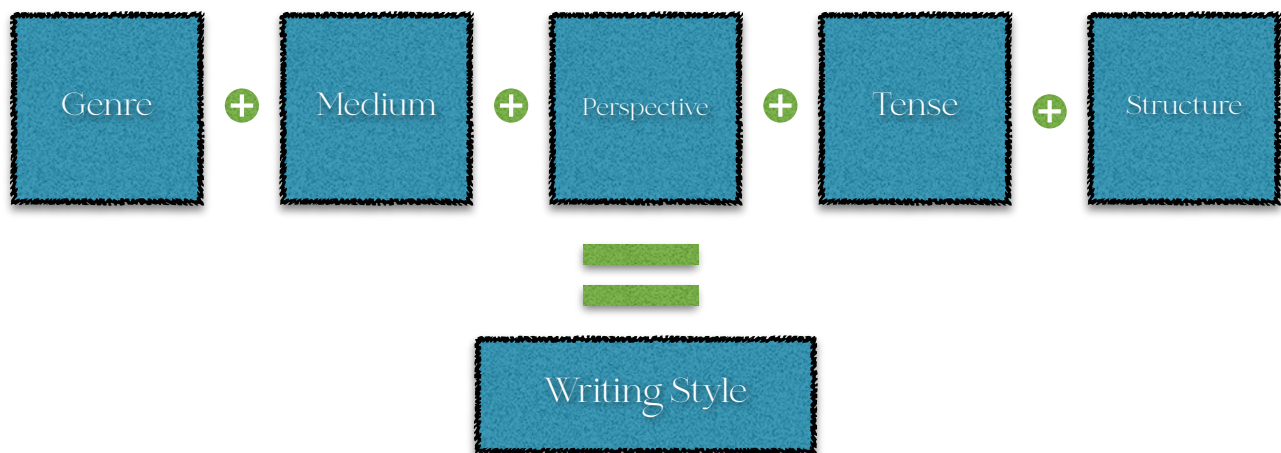
The goal for this section, and the book as a whole, is to **be amazing on purpose**. We need to understand the skills necessary to do it. Things are about to get a little dense. This is the part of being a writer that is often the hardest because it can feel like true "work". But there is so much art to be found here. We are choosing the types of brushes and paints now. Let's get to it.

Writing Style

How are you going to present your story? We need to figure out five important things. These things, these tools, will create the writing style that will make you rich and famous... or maybe just happy.

Your Writing Style is a combination of five parts

1. Genre
2. Medium
3. Perspective
4. Tense
5. Structure



Simple. Dats it. Just those things. Pssshhhhhh. We can do that. The way you combine each of these parts will dictate your writing style. Swapping out different parts can change the style of your writing in pretty significant ways. Take Romeo and Juliet. Totes my fav. It's a Romantic Tragedy (genre) + Play (Medium) + Third Person Omniscient (Perspective) + Present Tense (Tense) + 5-Acts (Structure). If we change the Genre to horror comedy that changes the writing style entirely. Or if the perspective becomes first person from Benvolio's POV, man is that different. Let's dig deeper.

Genre and Medium

After you have your story it's time to decide what genre and medium it belongs in. Depending on the size of your story, the complexity, and your own preferences, the genre and medium can be anything, although some genre and mediums may fit better than others. Using that macro to micro approach let us zero in on your writing style. Remember that this style is for this particular story. Your next story can be totally different.

Genre

Genre is a category of artistic composition characterized by similarities in form, style, or subject matter.

For narratives there are typically certain tropes, character types, and stylistic choices that help define the genre. But those genre elements change with society, so it's hard to guide people into whatever the current trend is. It's also dependent on what culture you are from and are writing for. That makes it hard to pinpoint which is just grrrrr.

There's also a lot of controversy surrounding how many types of genres there are in the literary community. Some say ten. Some say four. Some say dozens. And if you are talking about music then genre is something else entirely. That's a lot. That doesn't give us anywhere to start.

For our purposes of building a story we are going to think of **genre as an intentional overall experience designed for audiences.**

Remember that these are just a jumping off point so that you have a direction to go.

The 5 genres are comedy, drama, action, horror, and romance.

Comedy: is designed to make people experience joy. Comedy focuses on humorous people, dialogue, and/or situations to make people **laugh or feel good**.

Drama: is designed to make people experience deeper feelings like empathy. Drama focuses on emotionally difficult situations to make people **think**.

Action: is designed to make people feel thrilled. Action focuses on intense physical danger to make people feel a rush of **excitement**.

Horror: is designed to make people experience fear and anxiety. Horror focuses on intensely frightening people and/or creating situations to make people feel **stressed or tense**.

Romance: is designed to make people feel aroused and sentimental. Romance focuses on intimate relationships to make people feel **romantically stimulated**.

Important

The five genres as described don't have to be "pure", meaning that you can't have multiple experiences. **You can and should have moments of different experiences throughout your story.** The genre is the overall experience.

For example, if you have a comedy then you are trying to make people experience joy. You can have a dramatic moment so that the audience can feel empathy. The story is still overall a comedy. In fact, in my opinion, everything should have a moment of drama. But that's part of my own personal style.

Genre Examples:

These examples are good examples of stories that focus solely on the genre they are in.

Action: [John Wick, James Bond Films, The Martian, Die Hard, Avatar](#)

Drama: [Othello, The Help, Breaking Bad, The Godfather, Good Will Hunting](#)

Comedy: [Hitchhikers Guide to the Galaxy, Many Python and the Holy Grail, Toy Story, Singin' in the Rain, Modern Family](#)

Romance: [Titanic, Pride and Prejudice, Outlander, Twilight, The Notebook](#)

Horror: [The Shinning, Dracula, The Exorcist, Lovecraft Country, Halloween](#)

So **what experience do you want your audience to have?** Do you want them to laugh, cry, think, feel thrilled or afraid? These 5 genres have very different goals in mind. Start your storytelling process by picking one. That way you will know the overall experience your soon to be fans will have.

Another important thing to know is that genre, for us story creators, is deeply tied to the plot. Knowing that you are writing in a particular genre will help guide your choices not

only in the development of your plot, but also in dialogue, settings, descriptions, actions, and characters.

Sub-Genre

But what if the experience you want for your audience isn't as simple as "Joy" or "Thrilled"? What if you want the experience to be both? I like the way you're thinking. When you start combining genres then you are segueing into sub-genres. **Sub-Genres are additional genres that reflect the same overall trait as it's parent genre, but with it's own subtle difference.**

If you combine action and comedy you get... Action-Comedy! Crazy. In that case the audience should feel both thrilled and joyful by the end of your story. What if you want your audience weeping? Add Drama with Romance! You can do this with any of the genres, combining them to create a specific experience. The same is true if you push the boundaries of just a single genre. If you go real hard in the drama direction, you might hit tragedy. Go super hard into comedy and you might get Stand-Up. Go super duper hard into Romance and you might be jumping into erotica. Thriller, mystery, sci-fi, fantasy, are all sub-genres for our purposes, and each have a different set of feelings and emotions attached to them.

Sub-Genre Examples

These stories can all fit in the five major, but since they focus on more than one experience they find themselves in sub genres.

[Comedy-Romance-Drama: Love Actually](#)

[Action-Adventure-Drama-Romance-Fantasy: Game of Thrones](#)

[Action-Horror-Comedy: Supernatural](#)

[Action-Drama: The Dark Knight](#)

[Comedy-Horror: Get Out](#)

[Romance-Action: Mr. And Mrs Smith](#)

There are lot's of sub-genres, all based on stylistic elements. Fantasy has magic. Sci-Fi has some element of fancy technology. Musical has music. Detective has detectives. Those unique stylistic elements that define the sub-genre can be helpful to know. Keep that style in

mind when you are writing. You can always watch or read stories in that particular sub-genre to find inspiration in things like setting, characters, dialogue, and the overall style. If you come across something new, something exciting, find out what makes that sub-genre unique and now you've got another area to play in!

If you aren't concerned with what particular genre you are in, then **focus on the experience you want people to have**. The audience will come up with a genre all on their own without your help. But it's entirely dependent on the experience they have. So get fancy, or go simple, just be consistent and you'll be great.

Homework

Chose the genre you want to write in. If you already built out your story then you know what experience you want your audience to have. If not, then decide. If you want your audience to have a lot of experiences, then write those experiences down.

Medium

Medium is a particular form of artistic expression. In normal people terms, are you writing a book, movie, play, or something akin to one of those? The medium is how people are consuming your work. Watching, listening, or reading. Choosing what medium to tell your story in is your preference. Literally no wrong choices here. If a story is vast and complex, then a longer form of narrative might be ideal (TV or Novel). If the story is a medium length, not too long or short, then you have other options like movies, or plays. If the story is shorter, then you have options like poems, songs, dances, short films and novellas. What is most important is that you write your story in the medium that you are most comfortable with. (Or what your being paid to do. Either is fine.) And just because something is short or long doesn't mean it can't fit into different mediums. You can have 24 hour long episodes in a tv show that takes place in one day. You can also have a short 5 page story that takes the audience through generations. Pick your poison.

I wish there was more to this, but that's really it. There's so much blank space on this page, it's bothersome. But hey, maybe I'll make this an audio book and no one will know!

Except if I read this part out loud. Then...ah...dang it.

Homework

Pick your medium. This one should be fairly simple. Do what feels best for you and your story. That's it. What else do you need from this?

Perspective

A perspective is the lens through which an audience observes characters and events. This is going to be how the audience is taken through the journey you've laid out for them. You get to choose which seat in the badass four-wheeled monster vespa they are riding in. Do you want them to feel the story, or feel what the character feels, or just understand how complex an idea really is? How someone witnesses a story changes how involved their emotions are tied to it. Depending on what you want your audience to feel you will need a different perspective. I know it's gross to talk about feelings, but we gotta. Icky icky. Let's do it.

There are 3 basic perspectives, each able to convey different feelings when writing.

1. First Person
2. Second Person
3. Third Person
 - A. Objective
 - B. Omniscient
 - C. Limited

First Person Perspective

First person perspective is writing from the point-of-view of the author or main character. The main character narrates their story and uses first person pronouns such as "I" and "we." This perspective shows the inner feelings and thinkings of the individual.

Example: I walked down the street with my friends and I looked in the window of the store front. We couldn't go in, but I wanted to. They don't let people like us in fancy places like that.

If you want your audience to feel what the main character is feeling, then this is the perspective for you. You only know what the character knows, so the audience discovers the story at the same time the character does. It forces you to hang out with one voice, one set of opinions, one way of thinking. The audience is able to grasp all meaning based on this one person. You feel like you know them...intimately. Scandalous.

Second Person Perspective

Second person perspective is writing from one person to another. Second person perspective uses personal pronouns, like “you” and “your.” Someone is telling you the story that you are directly apart of.

Example: You walk down the street with your friends and you look in the window of the store front. You can't go in, but you want to. You know they don't let people like you in fancy places like that.

This is as personal as it gets. You become the character. You have these thoughts. You are being told what you feel and what you believe. It's a very intimate perspective. Great for making people feel like this is their journey. Super scandalous.

Third Person Perspective

The third person perspective uses “he,” “she,” “it” and “they” personal pronouns. There are three types of third person perspectives.

Third Person Objective – An impersonal narrator or neutral observer expresses the facts and details to the audience.

Example: Alija walked down the street with his friends and looked into the window of the store front. He couldn't go in because they didn't let people like him in fancy places like that.

This is a great perspective for telling people what is going on. It's very expository, good for dishing out all the necessary info for the scene without taking sides. This perspective is designed to make people feel like an observer. They see what is happening and understand it. Not very emotional, but highly effective in distributing information.

Third Person Omniscient – A narrator reports the facts, events, thoughts, and feelings of any or all the characters.

Example: Alija confidently walked down the street with his friends and looked in the window of the store front. He couldn't go in, but he desperately wanted to. His nervous friends were all thinking he was crazy for coming to this part of town. They all knew that no one here would let people like them in a fancy place like that.

If you want to know everything about everything, then this is the way to go. You can go in and out of everyone's minds, histories, everything. You are the great goddess who sees all that is, and was, and will be. This gives people the full picture. Literally everything can be expressed and that makes an audience feel as if they always know what's going on.

Third Person Limited - A narrator reports the facts, events, thoughts and feelings from a single character's perspective.

Example: Alija confidently walked down the street with his friends and looked in the window of the store front. He couldn't go in, but he desperately wanted to. He wondered if his friends were all thinking he was crazy for coming to this part of town. He figured they knew that no one here would let people like them in a fancy place like that.

This is the most personal of the third person perspectives. It's similar to third person omniscient in the sense that you get all the goods, but this time only from the subject of the scene. Unlike 3rd Person Objective, this narrator isn't impersonal. They have a vested interest in the character. It is very similar to First Person, however it isn't the character telling you things about themselves, it's the narrator.

Perspectives for Screenplays and Plays

For screenplays and plays it is possible to play with perspective in a similar way to novels and other long form narratives. Since you are working in a performative medium you must think outside the book.

First person could employ the use of voice over, like in old film-noirs or Neo-noirs like *Sin City*. The VO would say things like “I walked,” or “I felt”. Netflix’s *House of Cards*, is an example of a first person narrative. You could also follow a single person around and personify their feelings and emotions and thoughts. I’ve done this myself with a screenplay where both protagonists have their feelings talking to them during the worlds most awkward date. Very fascinating. Bo Burnhams *Inside* is another example of first person filmmaking. He literally tells you what is going on with him as he is trapped inside a small room. Brilliant!

For **second person** you could write the script where the camera is the audience. Characters talk to “you”. Documentaries do this when they are trying to teach you something. Interactive theatre where the audience is one of the characters, like Jon Braver’s *Delusion*, is a great example of a 2nd person play.

Third person is really easy to do for film and TV. For **Third Person objective** you simply have to have the camera view everything that happens, kinda like a normal movie. The camera views everyone objectively and we can jump around to wherever you want to go.

Third Person omniscient for film/tv is done typically with a narrator who knows what all people are feeling and thinking. A VO is common and is the easiest way to do this perspective. But again you can play with personified thoughts and emotions. Like in Pixar’s *Inside Out* where we follow the emotions of our tertiary character Riley.

Third Person Limited is done just like third person omniscient, only you follow just one or two people. You can use VO to explore their thoughts or feelings, or you can find some more creative way like text, or visuals that show what your character is feeling.

The great thing about screenplays and plays is you can use visuals and sound to convey the narrative. Push the boundaries you fearless rebels.

IN SUMMATION

When writing your story, the perspective can change, but it must do so deliberately. If the perspective changes erratically, the audience may become confused or disoriented. That being said, changing the perspective often is a great way to confuse and disorient your audience. It also allows you to see the story from different angles which can be very effective in not only conveying your plot, but building upon your setting and characters as well.

Regardless of what medium you are writing in, choose your perspective. **It should be in line with what experience you want your audience to have.** Choose wisely.

Exercise:

Write a scene in your natural perspective, whatever is most comfortable. Now rewrite the same scene in a different perspective. Keep doing it until you've done it in each one. Which one is most intriguing to you? Which one feels right? Which is hardest? Each story, each scene, each chapter can have a different perspective if you want. Practice writing in each. It'll give you more tools in your tool belt.

Homework

Pick your perspective. Keep in mind the experience you want your audience to have, what you think would be best for the story, and what you want to do. If you want multiple perspectives then choose them.

Tense

Are you nervous or just a little...tense!

No?

Anyone?

Because the title of this section...it's...tense.

(Clears throat)

Tense is the expression of time relative to the moment of the story. It is the wording that lets you know whether the perspective is from the past, present, or future. As easy as that sounds it's actually even more nuanced than just past, present, and future. (This is where things get real dense. Grab a shovel cause we going deep.) Simple, progressive, and perfect are three aspects on how to determine tense. And depending on what language you are writing in tense can have different rules. For this we shall stick with good old fashioned 'Merican. There are, for us, 12 types of tense in writing, and each one can change the style of writing in profound ways. There are two components of tense: Time and Aspect.

Time is obvious. Aspect has to do with the action that is taking place. Look at the picture below. It helps. A lot.

Time:

1. Past - [before now](#)
2. Present - [now](#)
3. Future - [after now](#)

Aspect:

1. Simple
2. Progressive - [ongoing action](#)
3. Perfective - [completed action](#)

	Past	Present	Future
Simple	wrote	writes	will write
Progressive	was writting	is writting	will be writting
Perfective	had written	has written	will have written
Progressive + Perfect	had been writting	have been writting	am going to write

Time we all get. Moving on.

Aspect is about the action of the writing. Is the action still happening, is it all done, or will it be done? When you are thinking of how you want your audience to experience your story think about the characters first. Did they already accomplish their intentions? **If the action is complete then the aspect you want is Perfective.** Are they currently accomplishing their intentions? **If the action is in progress then the aspect you want is Progressive.** Will they eventually accomplish their intention? **If the action is in progress of being completed then you want Perfect Progressive.** This dictates whether you write simple lines like *"He ran."* If he is still running, then you write *"he was running."* (Progressive) If he completed the run, then you get *"he had run"*. (Perfect) If he is running but will complete it then you get, *"he had been running."* (Perfect Progressive).

The simple aspect is slightly vague. It doesn't signify whether or not the action is in progress or completed. It's actually the easiest to use because of how vague it is, however it doesn't signify anything like the other two aspects.

There are 12 combinations of time and aspect.

1. Simple Past - I **wrote** yesterday.
 2. Past Progressive - I **was writing** yesterday.
 3. Past Perfect - I **had written** yesterday.
 4. Past Perfect Progressive - I **had been writing** yesterday.
-
5. Simple Present - I **write** every day.
 6. Present Progressive - I **am writing** today.
 7. Present Perfect - I **have written** today.
 8. Present Perfect Progressive - I **have been writing** today.
-
9. Simple Future - I **will write** tomorrow.
 10. Future Progressive - I **will be writing** tomorrow.
 11. Future Perfect - I **will have written** tomorrow.
 12. Future Perfect Progressive - I **am going to write** tomorrow.

That was... **intense!**

Oh come on, that one came out of nowhere! Just laugh, darn you!

Anyways, when you are deciding on your writing style consider what tense you are going to use. **Start by figuring out the time.** If your story is written in past tense, then your narrator has already experienced everything. They know the whole story and are choosing to give out information as they see fit. Present tense stories have the narrator experiencing the story at the same time as the audience. Future tense is similar to past tense in the sense that the narrator knows what will happen, even if they are experiencing it in real time, although it's more speculative since it's not happened yet. Basically they can predict the future.

After choosing the time, choose the aspect. Simple will probably feel most natural to commoners like us. Progressive makes things feel like they are currently being experienced. And Perfect makes things feel like they already happened. Perfect Progressive is a bit more posh and makes things sound like they are actively being completed.

Choosing the right tense for your story will be part of the style of your writing. Combining tense with perspective can give a story a very original feel all by itself. N.K Jemisin's *The Broken Earth Trilogy* is a unique fantasy novel partly written in Second Person Future Perfect Progressive! I mean come on, that's wicked cool.

Once you choose your tense you aren't bound to stay in that tense. Changing tense, like changing perspective, can work as long as it's a deliberate choice you are making and you are consistent with it. Be awesome on purpose!

Let's say you are writing in Present Progressive. That tells the reader that this story is happening now. As your characters are walking around, the Protagonist remembers something from the past. If you start writing in Past Perfect Progressive it tells the reader that you are now in the past watching something that already happened. You flip back to Present Progressive and the audience is with you in the moment again. You just did a flashback without needing to make a new chapter, write a new scene, or even tell the audience "7 Years Ago". Slick right?

Read all that stuff about tense again. It's a lot, but you'll get it. If it's all too scary then just write in simple past or simple present. Those are two of the most common in any case.

Homework

Pick your tense or tenses. Remember to keep in mind what experience you want your audience to have and what you feel comfortable with.

Story Structure

Story structure is a crucial part of storytelling. It's important to think about what kinda box you are putting your ideas into. Story structure is pretty varied depending on the culture and times you happen to be living in. But we conformists like to harken back to the days of Aristotle and the use of acts. So let us talk about them. But before that happens, understand that the most basic of ideas for story structure will always be BME. Beginning, middle, and end. As long as you got that then your good.

An act is a major section of a story that is used to create a story structure. There are two typical types of story structures: a **3-Act** structure and a **5-Act** structure. There is also a **7 Point Plot Structure** which can be implemented into the 3-Act and 5-Act structures; following the same order, but with more plot points. Or you can think of it as 7 acts. You choose.

Typically an act is signified by a major turn in events and direction of the story. Three act stories have two major plot points to mark the changing of the act, whereas a 5-act story has four. Depending on the medium the story is in and how complex the story is, different structures may be more useful.

And on top of all this talk about acts we have another element of story structure: **Linear and Nonlinear story telling.** Linear and Nonlinear storytelling is a part of the act structure but can drastically change your story. Those are luxury ideas, so they go at the end. Let us start with the absolute basics. Let's get our acts together.

3-ACT STRUCTURE

Ahhh. Can you smell that? Smells like ancient wisdom. Let's talk about acts. Act structure is a simple way to organize the BME of a story. The fewer the acts the more jam packed the story. The greater the number of acts, the more spread out the story is. The most common act structure is the 3-Act structure.

A 3-Act structure consists of the exposition act, the confrontation act and the conclusion act. In other words beginning, middle, and end. Most plays and movies are broken into three acts as it's easy to do. Stories that are more cut and dry work well in three act structures.

Act I - Exposition

1. The exposition act contains all the necessary backstory and set up. It focuses on making the audience understand the world that we are going to be spending time in, who the character's are, and what they want for themselves before everything changes. It also sets up the plot by introducing the intention, obstacle, stakes and timeframe for the characters. It starts with the norm, and ends when fecal matter hits the fan, as the cool kids say.

STORY ELEMENTS: Established Norm, Inciting Incident

Act II - Confrontation

2. The confrontation act contains the actions that the characters choose in order to get closer to achieving their intentions and goals. This is the bulk of the story as it contains the majority of the hardships of the journey, peaking with a moment where everything changes from "bad to worse". Characters make choices on what to do in the beginning of act two and deal with the consequences of those choices by the end of act two.

STORY ELEMENTS: Rising Action, Rising Reaction

Act III - Conclusion

3. The conclusion act contains the final action the characters take and the conclusion of the story. This act begins with the big bang, and ends with the dust settling down. It establishes a new norm and resolves any plot points that directly involve the main plot.

STORY ELEMENTS: Climax, Falling Action, Resolution

5-ACT STRUCTURE

A 5-act structure consists of the exposition act, the motivation act, the confrontation act, the climax act and the conclusion act. The 5-Act structure is great for more complex and lengthy stories. The subplots tend to be thicker, the main plot tends to be more complicated and three acts just won't do. You need more time in each of the story elements to really show the details, which spreads out the pacing and extends the plot. Each act ends in a dramatic shift in one form or another. You'll see the 3-Act structure trying to find it's way in there, but it's subtly different. The 5-Act structure is all about time.

Act I - Exposition

1. The exposition act contains all the necessary backstory and set up. It focuses on making the audience understand the world that we are going to be spending time in, who the character's are, and what they want for themselves before everything changes. The big difference between this Act-1 and a 3-Act Act-1 is there is no Inciting Incident. **This act is all about learning who the characters are and the world they inhabit.**

STORY ELEMENTS: Established Norm

Act II - Motivation

2. The motivation act contains the first rise in conflict and the Inciting Incident where the characters intentions, obstacles, stakes and timeframe are introduced. This act focuses on the moment of dramatic change that shifts the story away from the characters long term goals towards the characters more immediate intentions. This act will naturally be more tense as things start happening. The Inciting Incident has a chance to breathe and come along like a rolling tide. This act typically ends with the call to action where your "heroes" are forced into an unavoidable situation. **This act is all about setting up a strong and believable plot.**

STORY ELEMENT: Inciting Incident

Act III - Confrontation

3. The confrontation act contains the actions that the characters choose in order to get closer to achieving their intentions and goals. This is the bulk of the rising conflict and contains the majority of the hardships of the journey. At the end of this act is the beginning of the climax. But during this act characters are having ideas and are dealing with the repercussions of those ideas. This act is all about watching the characters struggle to achieve their intentions and goals.

STORY ELEMENTS: Rising Action, Rising Reaction

Act IV - Climax

4. The climax act contains the final action the characters must take. This is the make-it-or-brake-it act where the characters will either fail or succeed based on the decisions they made. This is the most tense act of all the acts. This is the hinge which will tip by the final line. The coup de grais. **This act is all about whether or not the characters win or lose.**

STORY ELEMENT: Climax

Act V - Conclusion

5. The conclusion act contains the final aftermath of the climax. The characters intentions have been accomplished or ruined. Their goals have been realized, or destroyed. The conclusion act establishes a new norm and resolves any plot points that directly involve the main plot. Everyone gets to breathe finally, as nothing else can happen. **This act is all about tying up loose ends.**

STORY ELEMENT: Falling Action, Resolution

For those of you visual learners, here are some handy dandy charts to help you see what's going on.

3 Act Structure			
ACT	ACT ONE	ACT TWO	ACT THREE
Name of Act	Exposition	Confrontation	Conclusion
Story Elements	Established Norm	Rising Action	Climax Ends
	Inciting Incident	Rising Reaction	Falling Action
		Climax Begins	Resolution

5 Act Structure					
ACT	ACT ONE	ACT TWO	ACT THREE	ACT FOUR	ACT FIVE
Name of Act	Exposition	Motivation	Confrontation	Climax	Conclusion
Story Elements	Established Norm	Inciting Incident	Rising Action	Climax	Falling Action
			Rising Reaction		Resolution

7-Point plot Structure

The 7-point plot structure is a method of creating minor plot points called **PINCH POINTS** in order to help motivate the main characters journey. A pinch point is a minor plot point where something significant happens, but not so much that it severely alters the outcome of a story. The pinch points happen during the second act in a 3-Act story and in act three and four in a 5-Act story. The midpoint of the story also becomes a minor plot point and separates the other two pinch points. The addition of the three minor plot points bring the total of plot points to seven. The kinda cool thing about this type of structure is that there are a lot of things happening.

Established Norm > Inciting Incident > Pinch Point 1 > Midpoint > Pinch Point 2 > Climax > Resolution

You can think of the 7-point plot structure as a 7-Act story, but you don't have to. It fits within 3-Act and 5-Act structures, adding extra twists that can be exciting for your audience. Everything is fast paced. Great for T.V, especially action and comedy. You can also think of it as simply having one act per essential story element. It accomplishes the same thing, only instead of smaller pinch points, you stick with the seven major plot points.

IN SUMMATION

Acts are fantastic ways to break up your story into bite sized chunks. When you are developing your story you don't have to power through the whole thing in one go. You can decide if you want your story to be easy to digest (3-Act), a longer journey (5-Act) or an action packed structure (7-Point). And you aren't limited to just acts. If you are writing the next great epic fantasy series then you might break your story into parts. Each part can be 3, 5, or 7-act based, depending on how much time you want your audience to spend in your story. Some stories need more, some less. Once you've developed your story, give a think on the structure you want it to fit into. If Act's aren't for you cause your story is so short, then no worries. Beginning middle and end. That's what all this talk about structure is about. How do you want to express your BME?

Homework

Pick your structure. This will help you section out your story so you can look at it in pieces.

Linear Vs NonLinear

Storytelling is the way in which a story is conveyed. That we know by now. If you build your story using the Story Creator Method then you have already built your story in a linear structure. That means you have each story element in order 1 through 7. But what if you like to live outside the box? Well, my little Aquarian friend, there is a way to do such a thing. Nonlinear storytelling is a story in which the plot elements are told out of order. It has everything a linear story has, but now it's all mixed up. Kinda like Yoda. Explore this idea we must!

Linear Storytelling

Linear storytelling watches the protagonists journey in the order in which it happens. It is the most common form of storytelling as it is easy for the audience to understand and progresses the plot in a logical fashion. You start from the beginning, progress through the middle, and finish with the end, just like in your outline. The audience is curious as to HOW the story ends and is learning things at the same pace as the protagonist.

Linear storytelling follows the structure of:

1. Established Norm
2. Inciting Incident
3. Rising Action
4. Rising Reaction
5. CLIMAX
6. Falling Action
7. RESOLUTION

Example: The intrepid space explorer Afro Galactice flew his advanced spaceship, the Cosmodome, through the Horse Head nebula, on his way to visit his mother. Suddenly, evil space pirates popped out from behind a large astroid and surrounded the Cosmodome. Unafraid to fight, Afro fired his plasma lasers and blasted his way out of the trap. The pirates chased Afro, demanding he surrender the plate of hot cookies they knew he'd bought on Nebulon 5. Just as the pirates were closing in, Afro pulled off the famous Omega maneuver and used the astroid to slingshot himself away. Unable to catch up to Afro the pirates slunk

back to their pirate lair to await future explorers. Afro makes it to his mothers space house safely where they enjoyed the best cookies in the galaxy.

The advantage it has over Non-Linear storytelling is the ease in which it is to read, witness, and write. Everything falls like dominoes and is presented in the same manner we experience life.

Non-Linear Storytelling

Non-Linear storytelling presents the protagonists journey out of linear order. It doesn't conform to any particular standard and is much more difficult to write and to comprehend. The rules of linear storytelling are abandoned in favor of freely expressing the story elements as the storyteller sees fit. That allows the writer to jump back and forth through time in order to achieve the emotional journey and plot revelations in a more targeted way. The audience has to keep up with the writer because they are not necessarily learning at the same rate as the protagonist. If linear story telling is building a model train track, then Non-linear storytelling is building a puzzle. The audience is curious as to both HOW and WHY the story ends that way.

Example: The intrepid space explorer Afro Galactice had somehow made it to his mothers space house after a most perilous journey. While traveling through the Horse Head Nebula earlier in the day inside the Cosmodome, evil space pirates had popped out from behind a large astroid and surrounded the advanced spaceship. Afro had been completely surprised as our intrepid hero had been trying to visit his mother to partake in the famous Nebulon 5 cookies for her birthday. The pirates chased Afro, demanding he surrender the plate of hot cookies they knew he had. It was possible that the pirates would have negotiated had Afro not fired his plasma lasers and blasted his way out as soon as he recognized the trap. But he had fired, unafraid of a fight, and just as the pirates were closing in Afro pulled off the famous Omega maneuver which used the astroid to slingshot himself away. Unable to catch up to Afro, the pirates had slunk back to their pirate lair to await future explorers leaving Afro alone so he could get home just in time for tea.

The benefits of Non-Linear storytelling is that it can make a simple story seem more complex. It can also reveal story elements in unique and unpredictable ways. It is also a great

way to hide information from the audience for them to discover later, making the story feel more mysterious. This is a bit more “out there” so let me give you another example.

Let's say you have a story about...oh I don't know... a giggle witch. Instead of starting the story with her birth, then going through life in the US in the late 1800's then adopting a son and learning about a source of great power yada yada yada... You can just start the story in medias res or *during the middle of action*. She's fighting a witch hunter. **(Rising Action)** You have no idea why. It's just bang, here it is. She escapes! Her son, Gentleman, asks what happened. She tells him to trust her and to go find this “Well of Ascension” so he does. He meets a man named Joe, who is also looking for the Well and they become friends. They talk about each others lives on their adventure which we see as flash backs. **(Established Norm)** As they reach the Well they wait for the Giggle Witch to arrive. When the Giggle Witch and her sisters arrive at the Well, Joe realizes that his new friend is part witch. Oh snap! Gentleman realizes that Joe is the witch hunter! Crazy! Bound by oaths from long ago a great battle Ensues! **(Rising Reaction)** During the battle the witches turn on each other to be the one to take control of the power. Long Eyed Joe accidentally mortally wounds Gentleman in the fight just as the giggle witch absorbs all the power. But seeing her son dying she heals him by giving him all the power **(Climax)**. Ripe with power Gentleman doesn't know what to do. His mother reveals to him how everything got started. **(Inciting Incident)** Now it's up to him to decide what to do. The witch hunter suggests to give the power away in exchange for his allegiance. Gentleman gifts his powers to the people of Chicago. **(Falling Action)** Now he and his family can live in peace as they've begun to atone for their egotistical errors and have found a new ally in the former witch hunter. **(Resolution)**

Non-Linear story telling isn't just rearranging a linear story. It's a way of hiding and revealing crucial plot points until they are even more effective. Flash backs are the most obvious way of making a story non-linear, but you can also mess with the timeline of a story using magic, time travel, memory loss, narration, having multiple characters intersecting at various points in their journeys, watching a single event from different points of view, you name it. You can find more twists and surprises potentially, and it forces the audience to catch up rather than just ride along. If your story needs that added surprise or mystery, or maybe you're just a rebel, non-linear could be the way to go!

Exercises

1. Write a seven sentence story with each sentence being a different story element. Once you're done, try rearranging the sentences to see how that affects your experience as a reader. If you want to expand on this exercise then write a short story with seven short chapters then try rearranging those. What that will do is show you the different experiences an audience has with linear and non-linear stories.
2. Write a short story with three main characters from the Protagonists POV. Now rewrite it from the Antagonists POV. And again from the Secondary Characters POV.
3. Write a simple short story from one POV, beginning to end. Now write another story from someone else's POV and have the stories intersect. Make sure the two stories NEED each other to work, meaning you need both for it to make sense.

IN SUMMATION

Choosing your writing style is the thing you must do before your finger touches your futuristic keyboard. You don't want to "discover" your writing style midway though. Imagine writing a book that you start out writing as a comedy told from the perspective of a single person in simple present tense and figure out midway through that you should be writing a *screenplay* that is an *action comedy* told from the perspective of both the *hero* and *villain* in *past progressive tense*. That's quite a change. Ain't nobody got time for a rewrite before the first draft is finished. Best believe that. Figure that mess out before your first draft is done.

Lastly, your writing style can change for each project you do. It's important to know what it is before hand so that you know how the entire piece will sound. You want to write in a style that interests you. Part of your writing experience will be figuring out what your writing style will be for each project you undertake. If you need inspiration, then read or watch other stories that are both similar and completely different than yours. Take style elements from things you love and try something new. Mix it up. Go crazy! The more you practice writing in different styles the more diverse your writing can become. Find your niche.

Now if you'll excuse me... I'm going to go crawl into a tiny ball underneath the table to cry a little. I mean... soon I will have crawled into a tiny ball underneath the table where I will have cried a little thinking of tense. Good luck ya'll.

Bonus Exercise:

Combine the five different style elements together and write a scene so you can see how it feels. Not long, just a paragraph or two. Then write that same scene changing one style

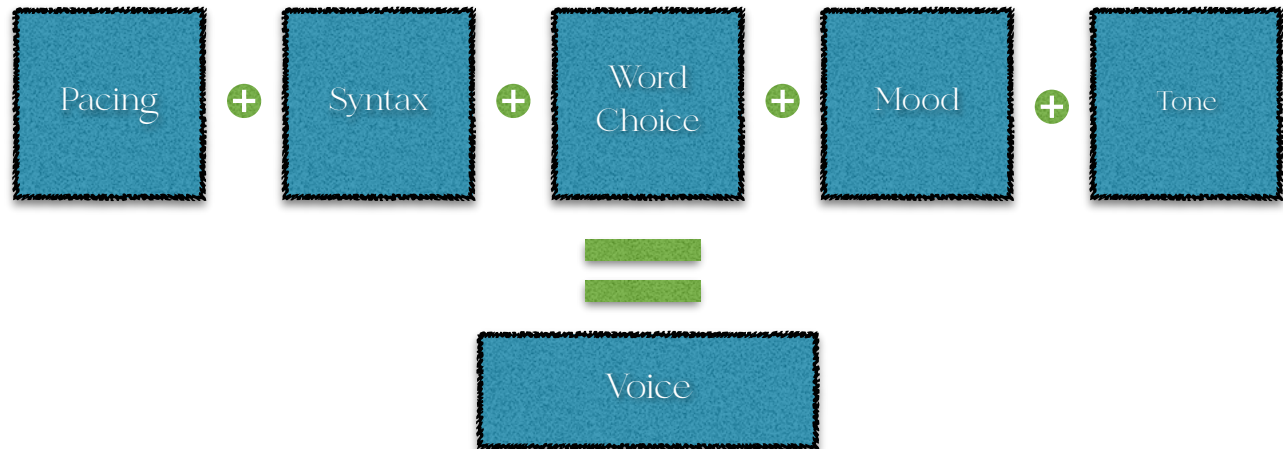
element. Keep changing a style element and keep rewriting that same scene. What this does is it lets you see how different a story can sound just by changing one style element. Once you find a combination that you like... I think you know what you need to do!

Homework

Pick your writing style. Technically you've already done this if you've been following along. If not, pick your style elements. Make sure you keep this handy cause this is going to guide you for the entirety of your process.

Voice

Your voice is a combination of **pacing, syntax, word choice, mood, and tone**. Those five parts create the calling card that lets people know that this is **your** piece. Your voice is what differentiates you from that dudette next to you. It's the answer to the question "What makes you unique?" **Developing your voice can make you an unquantifiably original writer**. So let's break down each part of voice, shall we?



Pacing

Pacing is the speed of the story based upon the sentence structure and word choice. Short, clipped sentences give a piece a quick pace. The same is true for punchy, short words. Longer, wordier sentences tend to slow the pace of any given story down. The greater amount of syllables a word residing within any particular sentence contains also assists in the deliberate moderation in which a reader or audience member is able to assimilate the contents of your story. In short, the more you have to read, the slower the pace.

QUICK PACED EXAMPLE:

Example: Jim busted into the room. He whipped his head left, then right. Furious, he raced back out in search of his lost bunny.

SLOW PACED EXAMPLE:

Example: Jim rushed as quickly as he could up to the room. This was his last vestige of hope and without it he had zero idea what he was going to do. He pushed open the door and swept his eyes left to right, scanning the room as thoroughly as a hardened detective. He felt a wave of hopelessness sweep over him as he failed to spot what he'd worked so hard to find. That despair began to bubble and boil, and before he knew it he was seething with a hatred so palpable he could taste blood in his mouth. He turned back around a swore to the devil himself that he would find his stolen rabbit, even if it meant the loss of everything else.

In the first example you get right to the point. Everything is punchy, fast, and gives you an urgent feel to the scene. The pacing is quick. Faster pacing pushes you through the scenes and moments and focuses more on the action. The second example is stretched out, slower, but more descriptive. You get to spend more time in the moment to explore the emotions and thoughts of the character. Slower pacing allows for more exploration of the intricacies of the details.

You want to think about the pacing of your story, especially while you're going into your second draft. Also your first draft, duh, but most definitely in your second draft. And remember to balance yourself. Not everything needs to be just slow or just fast. Giving a mixture of slow and quick paced wording can bring a dynamism to your writing. **Pacing can help you push feelings onto your audience.**

Balanced Example: Jim rushed into the room. He whipped his head left, then right. Nothing. It wasn't there. He felt a wave of hopelessness sweep over him. That despair began to bubble and boil, and before he knew it he was seething with a hatred so palpable he could taste blood in his mouth. He spat. Nothing else mattered any more. Come hell or high water, he was going to find his rabbit. He turned, slowly, knowing what he had to do. He took a breath, then ran out of the room.

In this example there is a mixture of quick pacing and slow. The action bits are fast. But once the emotions start to take hold we slow down so we can really feel it. As our protagonist prepares to head out on his mission, the pacing quickens again. That combination of accelerating and decelerating gives the audience a ride. The majority of your writing will be similar to this, balanced. But there will be ample times where you want things to just be quick, or just be slow. It all depends on the ride you want your audience to take. Sentence by sentence, scene by scene. Dan Brown, author of *The Davinci Code* has chapters that are less than a page. Crazy! Find your pace!

Syntax

Syntax is the arrangement of your sentences, the emphasis, pauses, and word order. Syntax is a beast. The arrangement of your sentences can help put people into the mindset of a character or the feel of the world. Characters with accents might pause in unique places or change the order of their words. Highly educated characters might be verbose while uneducated people might sound more direct, or vice versa. Writing your descriptions using the same syntax as the characters can help drop you into a setting without needing much description, which is useful when you are revisiting different locations within your story.

Conversely, having alternating syntaxes for the actions and dialogue can create unique familiarities within the writing. So when character A has a chapter, you know it before they even speak. Gets you right in the subconscious. Deep right?

Deep.

Example 1: Blood was...everywhere. Except the walls, oddly. The walls themselves were white, painted with roses befitting an elderly woman who adored flowers. The colors of the painted petals seemed dull in comparison to the bright gore on the floor. There, a body lay, unmistakably dead. Unmistakably... "Curious," the detective said. The younger man standing by the door flinched at the word. It can happen sometimes when you find yourself in these types of tableaux. This one... this was exceptionally vivid. "I find myself in awe of the spectacle around me. Come, officer Brown. I feel there is a sharp need for a drink".

In this example we get a sense of the familiarity with violence even before we understand that the character witnessing the bloody scene is a detective. The structure of the sentences varies between smooth and jagged. Having choppy sentences to start the scene shows the hesitation. As the sentences grow in length the audience is able to get a sense of what is happening in line with the characters. Because of the fluid nature of the dialogue we have a feeling that the detective is somewhat used to scenes like this and is highly educated. Yet there is another chopped sentence that helps to emphasize the uniqueness of the murder near the end. And the main thing to look at is when the information is given to the reader. This example starts with blood, moves to decor, then to the body and lastly the detective. It could have started very differently.

Example 2: "Curious," the detective said. The younger man standing by the door flinched at the word. It can happen sometimes when you find yourself in these types of tableaux. This one... this was exceptionally vivid. Blood was...everywhere. Except the walls,

oddly. The walls themselves were white, painted with roses befitting an elderly woman who adored flowers. The colors of the painted petals seemed dull in comparison to the bright gore on the floor. There, a body lay, unmistakably dead. Unmistakably... "I find myself in awe of the spectacle around me. Come, officer Brown. I feel there is a sharp need for a drink".

See what happened there? The order changed and the whole thing feels different now. We know right off the bat that this is a detective with experience along with a younger fellow with less. But because we know that immediately, it feels like even though there is a grizzly murder in front of them, the detective is used to it. In the first example it seemed extra disturbing, even for a seasoned veteran. If you know what you want the feel of each scene to be, then you can structure that accordingly. Ask yourself, "What do I want the audience to feel now?" That can help you **structure the order of your sentences**. Depending on what you like you can get subtly different results that in the long run will distinguish your voice.

While you are writing and revising you can look at your syntax and you can rearrange the structure to see if it fits what your going for. That can be especially helpful when you have all the information you want your audience to know already written, but the response you get in regards to the feeling doesn't match your intentions. Mix it up. Find what works.

Mood

Mood is the feel of your writing. It is similar to genre in the sense that it has a particular energy to it. But unlike genre which encompasses the whole piece, mood can change throughout the story with each scene. Each scene you write will have a particular feel. What does that mean? We've all seen an action movie, right? Action is the genre. We know there are going to be fighting/violence/chases/INTENSITY!!!! But each scene, and even each sequence, can stand out separate from the genre as a whole by changing the mood. There can be scenes where the mood is dark, or light, or comedic, or scary, etc. We're working with words here people. You express mood with words that live in a particular realm of feeling. You can see a mood best with the descriptions of a setting. Let's take a look-see.

Example 1: The hallway is dark, empty, and dry. What lies on the far side? Death, certainly, waits at the end of it.

Example 2: The hallway is bright, clean, and smelled like lemon. What mysteries lay at the end of it? Maybe this passing will be filled with glorious sound and light.

In the first example the mood is dark. It feels very gloomy and foreboding. In the second example the mood is brighter, even though it describes another hallway that leads to the "undiscovered country". #Shakespeare. If you want a dark mood, then you might write something like Example 1. If you want your audience to not be quite as scared then the mood in Example 2 will fit your palette. You want to choose words that feel right for the mood you're going for. **The point of mood is that with it you dictate how the audience experiences the piece emotionally.** Isn't that cool!!!?? You are the wizard behind the curtain.

Mood can be used strategically if thou so desires. Let's say you want to squeeze some tears from your audience in your Action-Comedy. You can prep the audience for the gut punch by having a scene where the mood is hopeful. Then you have a scene that seems victorious! Then... muhaahahaha, you have a scene where the mood is sad. And for dessert you end with a scene that is hopeless. Man... what a journey. **Mood helps dictate the emotions of audiences.**

Note

We are about to talk about Tone. Tone is simply how you convey your mood. If mood is the thing, tone is how you choose to do the thing. Serious mood done comedically. Dark mood done darkly. Romantic mood done scarily. Make sense? No? Well hold yer horses cowgirl!

Tone

Tone is the color of the writing. Yes, I said color. It's not an actual color, but it is though. Color for the brain! Tone can be aggressive, humorous, seductive etc... The idea behind tone is similar to mood in the sense that both are aimed at the feel of each scene in

the piece. Whereas mood is a general feel like dark, light, heavy, etc. tone is how you flavor the mood. Aggressive for example, can be a tone. Putting an aggressive tone in a love scene where the mood is erotic changes the feel of that scene a lot. The mood could be romantic, but now it's tinted with aggression which sounds kinda hot. *Cough* Conversely, putting a romantic tone on a fight scene can imply something different than the action you're seeing. *Mr. And Mrs. Smith* by Simon Kinberg is a good example of this. Are they trying to kill each other, or is it four-play? The mood is violent, but the tone is loving...could be intriguing.

Tone is a great tool for implying things. Does a character secretly hate another? If yes then maybe you should put a hostile tone to your dialogue. Does a character secretly love a character? Try using a loving tone in the descriptions. Tone, you silly goose, can color how everything is expressed, especially if the tone is juxtaposed with the action.

In this example the mood is violence. You get that from the words like swung, rage, and fired. But the tone changes in each one for different effects.

Example 1: George swung with all his tiny might and felt well moisturized knuckles connect with the intruders stubbly chin.

Example 2: George unleashed his rage and crashed his fist into the bastards face.

Example 3: George cocked his arm back, aimed, and fired a quick jab into his targets jaw.

Example 1 has a silly tone. It's a dude punching another dude in the face but the tone isn't super aggressive. Words like moisturized in an action scene are odd and make the audience cock their head to the side. The tone in Example 1 is aimed at making the scene feel goofy. Great for younger audiences and comedies as an example as to where you'd use it.

Example 2 has a brutal tone. Words like, unleashed, rage, and crashed tell us about the violence in the scene and the emotions around it. This is for more mature audiences who like brutality.

Example 3 has a very "professional" tone. It feels like this George dude is taking care of business. You get a sense that he's done this before.

How you describe a scene helps put the audience into the feeling of the scene. It gives us an idea of what kind of characters we are dealing with. So if genre is the whole thing, and mood is each scene, then tone lives in each individual line. That includes dialogue.

Example 1: George swung with all his tiny might and felt well moisturized knuckles connect with the intruders stubbly chin. "Take that you...you...poop head!"

Example 2: George unleashed his rage and crashed his fist into the bastards face. "Get up. You're not dead yet."

Example 3: George cocked his arm back, aimed, and fired a quick jab into his targets jaw. "Stay down!"

We got the same examples with dialogue that matches the tone. Let's switch that up.

Example 1: George swung with all his tiny might and felt well moisturized knuckles connect with the intruders stubbly chin. "Stay down!"

Example 2: George unleashed his rage and crashed his fist into the bastards face. "Take that you...you...poop head!"

Example 3: George cocked his arm back, aimed, and fired a quick jab into his targets jaw. "Get up. You're not dead yet."

All that changed was the dialogue in these examples. How do you feel about each example now? What kinda of character has Example 2 become? The dichotomy of a brutal tone in the action feels different than the silly poop head tone doesn't it? Sometimes that contrast is what you want, sometimes not. Pick your tone carefully to invoke the feelings you want to invoke. When you change it up, do so on purpose. Use it wisely. OR ELSE!!!!

Word Choice

Word choice is the choice of words for dialogue, actions, and descriptions.

"But, Mr. Authorface, how is this different than Syntax, Mood and Tone? Aren't those ways to write words?"

Yes. But we're talking about something slightly different. We are talking about things like, vulgarity, verboseness, alteration, repetition, colloquialisms... **Word choice is the style of the narration and the characters themselves.** Not just the feeling. The choice of words helps dictate what kind of audience you are writing for and what kind of characters you have. What types of words you use can alter absolutely everything. Which makes sense right? It's almost as if your words matter.

Word choice can be especially useful to show the change of a character. Someone who uses dark language near the beginning of the story may end up using brighter language to show their growth. The individual words can help you convey a type of character to your audience.

Let's look at an example of a single line of dialogue.

Example 1: I can't be bothered with the ridiculous nature of the accusation.

Example 2: I don't care what they say about me.

Example 3: Whatever. Screw off.

In each example the same sentiment is expressed, but the choice of words dictates very different characters. What words you choose, tell you a lot about what you want the audience to understand. A gangster who sounds like example 1 is a very different person than a gangster who sounds like example 3.

When you are deciding your word choice think of the type of audience you are going for. Are they young, old, fancy, hedonistic, a hybrid of a few types. Do they like cursing, or are they more wholesome? **Who is your audience?** If *you* are your audience, then what do you like to hear? Knowing your audience is super helpful in deciding what kind of words you wanna use. Once you know your audience you can then focus on how the characters sound. Messin with word choice, especially with actions and descriptions yo, can also mad-change the feel of things, fo real tho'. It can take something formal and relax the hell outta it. Or take

something that is quite informal and bring a heightened state of propriety to the overall mood. Think on't.

IN SUMMATION

Your voice is uniquely yours. Write, write more, and then read your writing to see what is already present there. Then you can lean into your strengths and develop your weaknesses. Does your mood and tone make it difficult for readers to get a sense of the feel of the piece? It's always a good idea to know what the heck your doing. By knowing what your voice already is you can change it, or develop it further. Adding skill with talent, that's what this is all about.

Exercise

Just like you did for writing style, combine all the voice elements and write a paragraph. Then change one element and write the paragraph again. Keep doing that until you've tried all the combinations. Which one resonates with you most? Least?

Homework

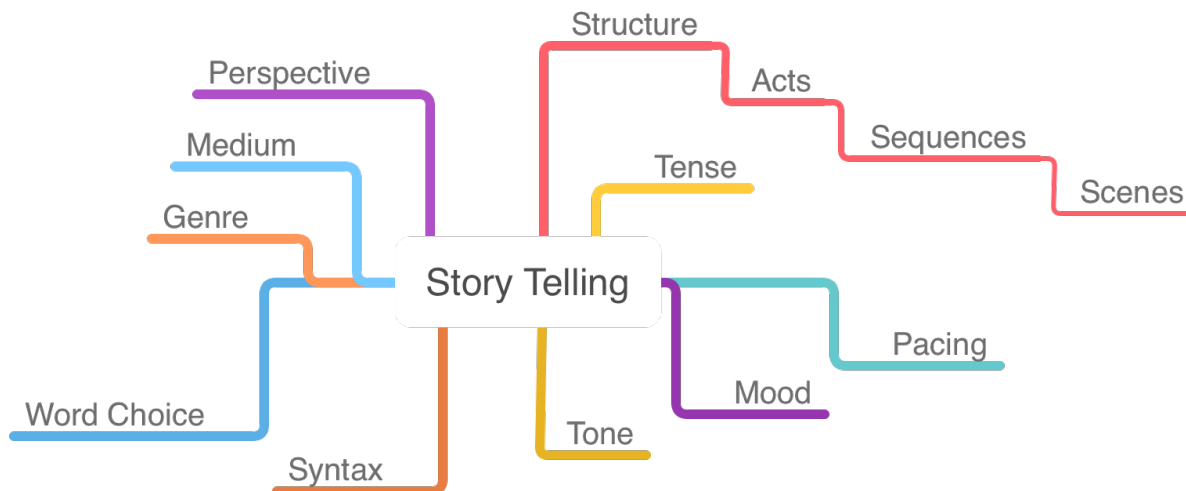
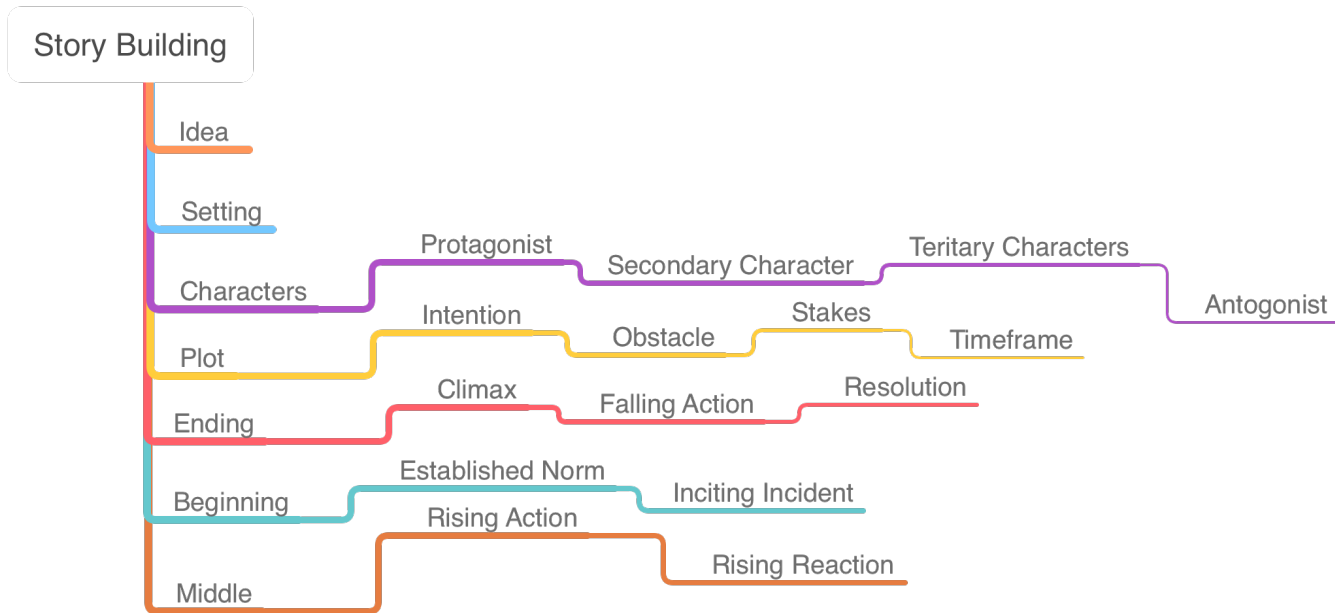
Pick your voice. Based on the story you want to write, choose the pacing, syntax, word choice, mood, and tone. Write a paragraph in that voice and see if you like it. Change what doesn't work, keep what does.

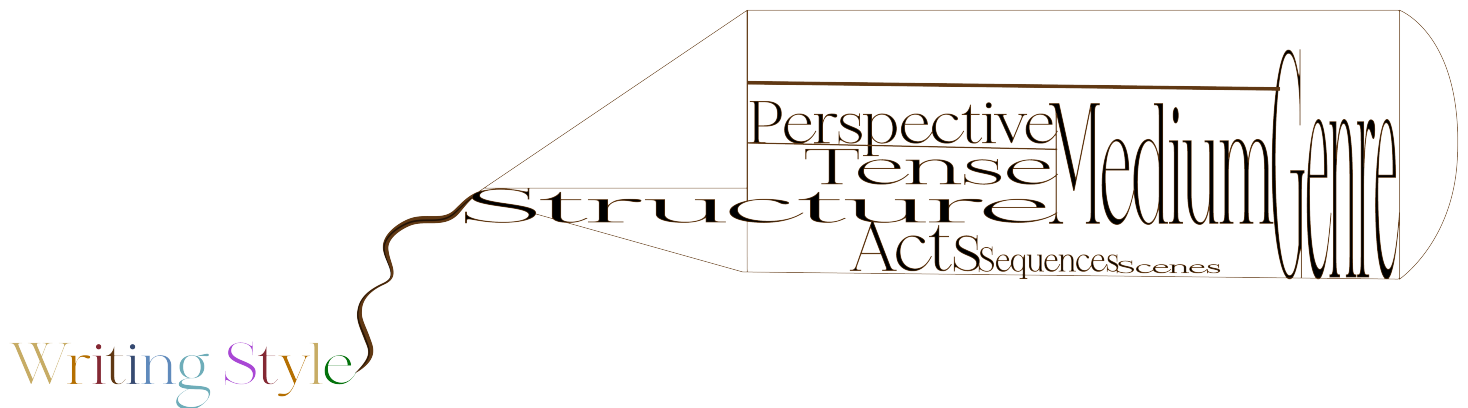
IN SUMMATION

If you think about your story and how you want to tell it from the widest possible lens first you can focus in on the details in an inspirational way. Instead of bouncing all around with random ideas that could or could not lead to somewhere, let's harness this workflow to make every idea count. One thing should lead to the next and the next and the next. Don't spin your wheels trying to organize your mind. The Story Creator Method, when done well, should help empty your mind of excess chaos and organize your thought process for you. Once you've built your story and you know how you want to tell it, all you gotta do is write. Ideally your drafting, revising, and editing steps will be far easier to handle with a fully fleshed out story and writing style. If you apply this method to each story, your concept phase will be far superior to what it once was. At least that's the big idea. Macro to Micro. The more you know and all that. Now go write something!

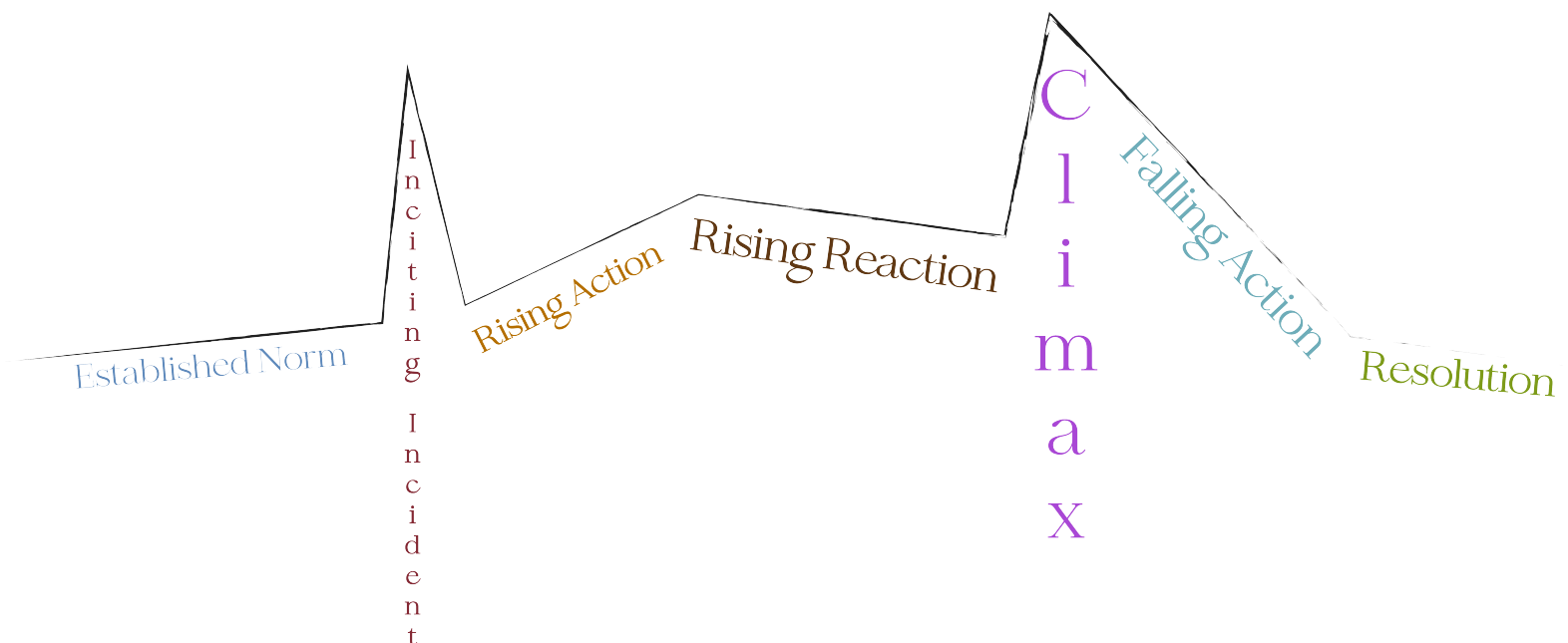
Lets get graphic

Maybe these help. Maybe they confuse you. Either way they make great tattoos.



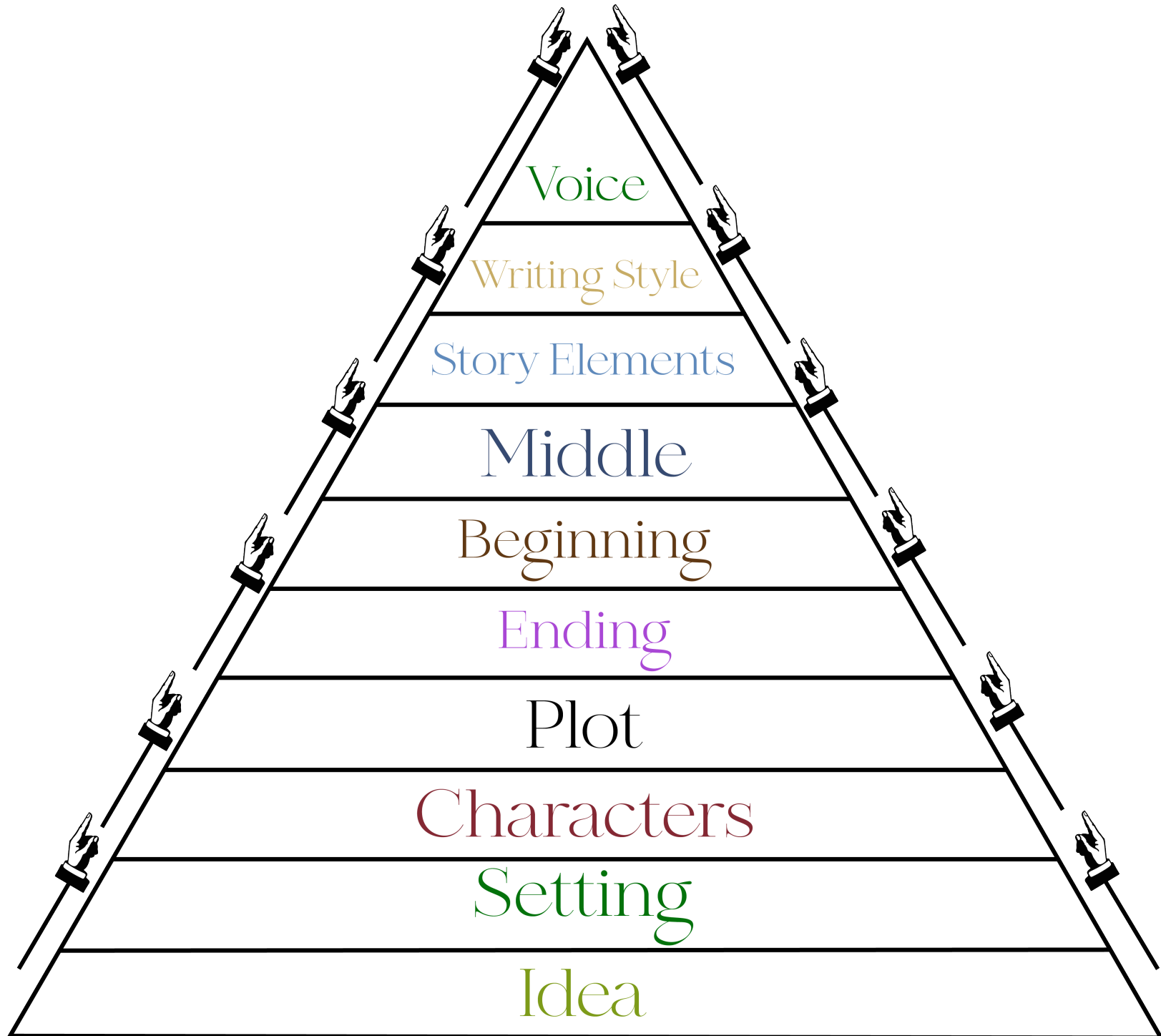


Story Creator Workflow



7-Essential Story Elements

Start Writing!!!



Start Thinking!!!

Story

A Plot

A sequence of intriguing events that uses Characters and Plot to recount a narratives beginning, middle, and end.

B Plot

The A plot is the sequence of major events that takes precedence over all other plots and mainly concerns the actions of the protagonist and the Antagonist.

C Plot

The B plot is the sequence of events that directly effect and inform the A plot and mainly concerns the actions of the deuteragonist and/or the protagonist.

The C plot is the sequence of events that indirectly effect and inform the A plot and mainly concerns the tertiary characters and/or the protagonist.

Story Arc

The plot of the story from the Inciting Incident to the falling action.

Middle

Beginning

The set up of the world, characters and plot.

End

The result of the characters journey.

Established Norm

The lifestyle of characters before the inciting incident of a story

Inciting Incident

The first major plot point that breaks the protagonist away from the Established Norm and introduces the Obstacle, Intention, Stakes and Timeline of a story.

Rising Action

The series of events and/or plot points after the inciting incident that directly affect the characters and advance the plot.

Rising Reaction

The consequences following the rising action that directly affect the characters and heighten the conflict of a story.

Climax

The turning point in the story which changes the protagonists fate and/or Intention.

Falling Action

The conclusion of the conflict with the success or failure of the Protagonist's intention.

Resolution

The establishment of the new norm.

Story

Ending

Plot

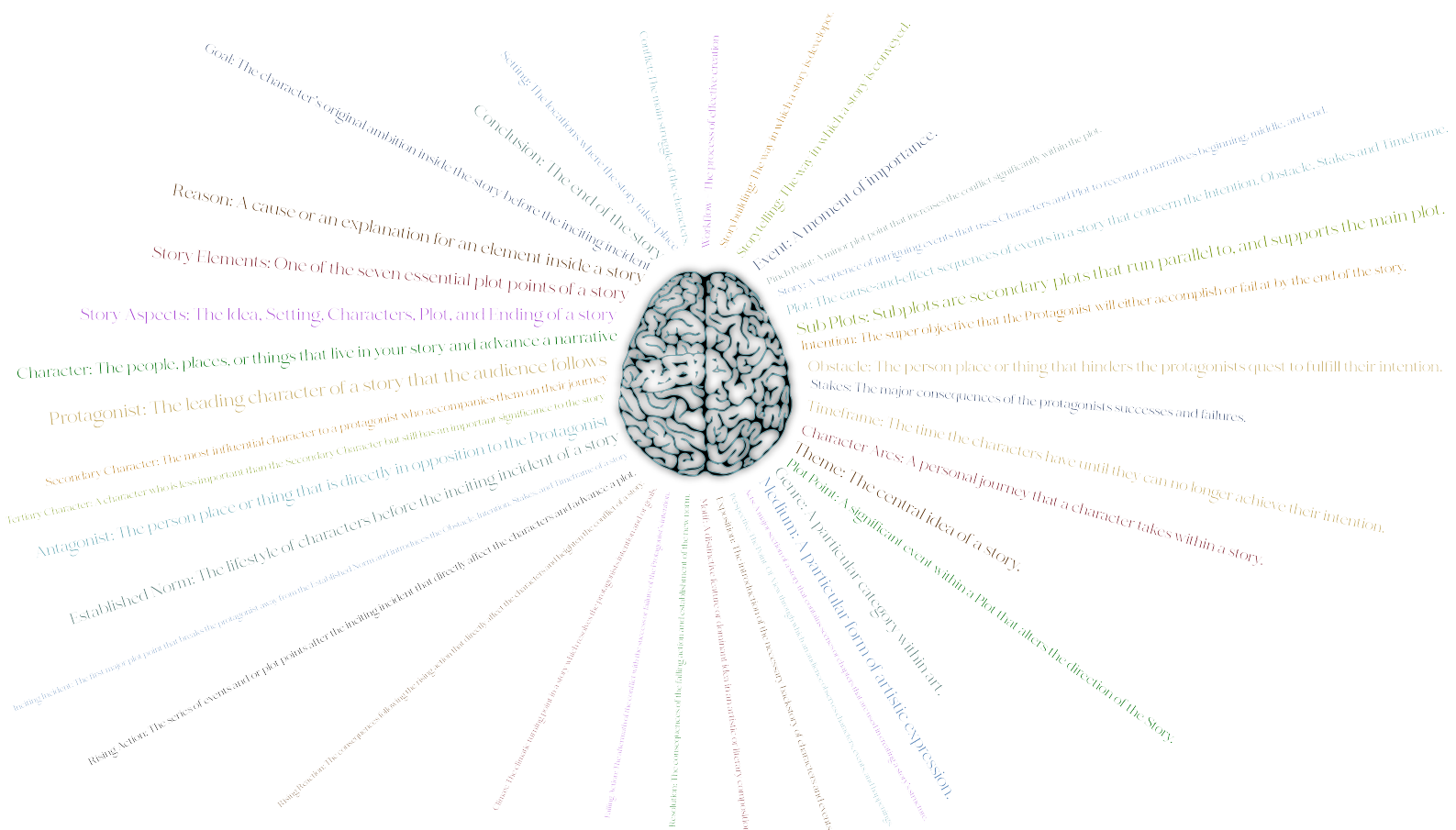
Characters

Setting

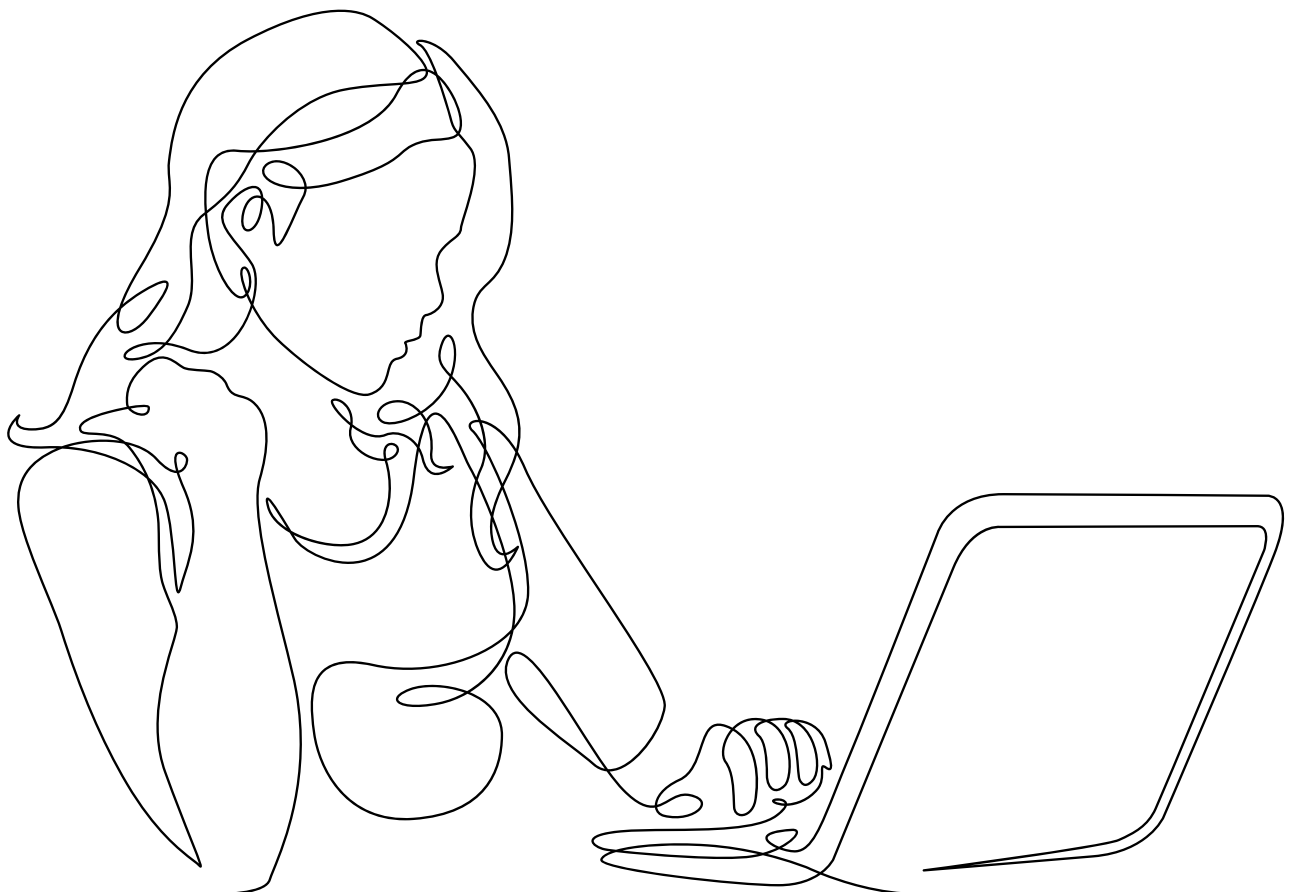
Idea

IN SUMMATION!

So that's story ya'll. That's how to build it, and how to tell it. What's next? You gotta do it. You need to dive in. The water's fine. If you love writing, and I mean really love writing, you will be doing this forever. Or, if you are here on a passing night-ship, then continue on with a new found respect for the intricacies of what is inside a story. It's all very simple, but it is a lot. Like a combustion engine, or a well timed yo-mamma joke. A story is like a Tardis, it's bigger on the inside. Remember your story elements and to give reason for everything and you'll be fine. The deeper you go, the more intrinsic this all becomes, the more fulfilling your life as a writer will be. So go forth, young Jedi's, you've graduated from starfleet academy and can now pilot your own Battlestar's. And be proud to call yourself a Story Creator!



Simply Complex



Writing Process

From Beginning To End

Have you ever wondered what the writing process is like? Well, worry no more! This section is going to be covering the basics in pretty cool detail. And it may just give you veterans out there a new way of thinking about your own process.

There are 4 steps to a writing process.

4. **Prewriting:** Prewriting consists of Concept Creation, Story Development, Research, and Outlines.

- The point of prewriting is to gain a thorough understanding of the story before you write it.

5. **Drafting:** Drafting is writing down the 1st draft of your story focusing on structure and the ideas you want to convey.

- The point of drafting is just to get the story out of your head and onto the page. It doesn't have to be perfect, but it is easier to revise a flawed story over a hypothetical one.

6. **Revising:** Revising is adjusting the writing of your 1st draft, focusing on clearing up any structural mistakes, plot holes, weak character arcs, and implementing your voice.

- The point of revising is to refine the story and perfect the voice so that it achieves the writers intention. Revising produces 2nd, 3rd, 4th etc...drafts of a story. This is where you typically will spend the most time and is where your voice starts to come to life.

7. **Editing:** Editing is checking for grammar, formatting, spelling, and punctuation after the story and all its elements are complete.

- The point of editing is to polish off your story so it will look and feel professional, resulting in a final draft.

Drafting

Get 'er done!

As the saying goes "Real writing is Rewriting". That being said, no one wants to be rewriting forever and ever. As much as the "Journey" is exciting and lovely, it's nice to actually be finished. Drafting is the journey. It's *setting the sail across the narrow sea*. But rather than wander aimlessly in an ocean of words it's important to focus your writing into three parts.

1. **First Draft**
2. **Second Draft**
3. **Third Draft**

First Draft

The first draft is the *Rough Draft*, and is exactly that, rough. The more you perfect your craft the closer the first draft will feel like a second or final draft. In any case, the first draft's goal is to establish the structure of the story. The main things you are looking for in a first draft are:

1. **Does the story make sense?**
2. **Is the plot compelling?**
3. **Is the structure solid?**

The first draft is the most important draft as it deals with the story as a whole. The story needs to be clear, convincing, and compelling. It should be if you went through the whole Story Creator process, which I hope you did. If somehow you read your story and find that big things aren't right, then here is where you work that out. If there are any major structural mistakes, you will want to fix them here before you start worrying about smaller things like dialogue, prose, and other detailed aspects of story. **You want to make sure your 7-Essential Story Elements are clear and strong.** That's super super super important. You also want your plot to be clear and sensical.

Everything will wrap around the story elements so you wanna get it right on the first try as much as you can. You are building the bones of your piece and nothing is more important than knowing you have a solid foundation. Otherwise you will flop about like a land bound squid and no one wants that. Too wiggly. Lck. All the details can be fixed later. Just get the first draft done. If you want, think of it like an extensive outline. Let it be ugly, we can slap some make-up on the pig later. Just focus on your plot, character arcs, and your 7-Essential Story elements. Make sure that everything makes sense.

Second Draft

The Second draft is the detailed draft. The “real writing”. The part that drives some folks mad! Or so the voices tell me. This is the reworking part in the writing process. This is where the muscles of your story will be fleshed out and draped over your skeleton, which is super sexy. You are focusing on making the story pretty now. This is where you get into the nitty gritty. Get here as fast as humanly possible. You know you’re ready for this draft when the plot is solid, the characters make sense, and the story as a whole makes sense. If all that is true, then you won’t have to make any big changes. The main things you are looking out for in a second draft are:

- 1. A clear and consistent Writing Style**
- 2. A clear and consistent Voice**
- 3. Strong dialogue and unique sounding characters**
- 4. A believable world with strong descriptions**
- 5. Clear and consistent Themes**

Since you have the foundation of your story solid, now you are working to create the style of the piece. You’ve already chosen a writing style and a voice, so go back and make sure it’s consistent. The 2nd draft is comprised of lots of deleting and adding things. You really want that writing style and voice to be solid, so here is where you do it.

The characters are the most important driving force for your narrative, so they need to be well developed. **Are their motivations clear? Are they consistent with their speech and actions? Does the audience know who they are?** If you have characters that are extraneous, you can combine them into singular characters or cut them all together. A good

test to see if your characters are working is to have someone read the story, then quiz them on the characters asking who a character is, what are they trying to do, and why.

Along with your characters, your world plays a huge part in your story. In the second draft you can **hone in on the details of the world to make it stand out and add to your story.** Even if the story isn't about a location, it has a say on the feel of the story and should be described in better detail in the second draft. Along with the world, you want to double check if your passage of time is clear. You can use the characters and the world to help you **clarify how much time is happening from beginning to end.** You will know by now if your plot is working, so give it any tune ups you need. This is where you can be artsy! Work on your prose, goodfellow! Give it some flair!

Warning!!!

DO NOT OVERWRITE! I REPEAT, DO NOT OVERWRITE! The second draft kills many a good writer. You can get stuck in the quagmire of details here. DON'T LET THAT HAPPEN! The goal is to be able to read your story all the way through without feeling like you should change something. That's like, duh, totes obvi. BUT, and this is a very big but, Badonkadonk kinda but, there comes a time and place where you have to be done. Get through a draft, and let others, WHO HAVE GOOD TASTE, tell you what they think. Don't ask your mother, she loves everything you do and she's always so proud of you. (Love you mom!) And don't ask that cutie at the coffee shop who is always smiling at you. Ask that friend who scares you. That judgey, opinionated friend who loves the same movies you do, but you two argue about the semantics anyway. You want the person who is reading your stuff to say something accidentally patronizing like "Wow, you wrote this?" Or "I never thought you could write something so good!" Or even worse "Honestly, I'm impressed."

Don't be that writer who writes one thing for ten years. Your next story will be better, so let's get to it. It doesn't have to be perfect, icky Virgos, it just needs to be done. Find the point to walk away from your second draft. You can do it. Just breathe. In...out...in...out... There you go. Let go. You're all done. Let's move on now.

Third Draft

The third draft is the *final draft*. This is the “editing” portion of writing. This is last time you should be going through your story to fix things. You’ve already made sure the bones are solid, and the muscles are strong, now it’s time to put the skin on! (To complete the anatomical metaphor.) This draft mainly deals with:

1. **Flow**
2. **Typos**
3. **Formatting**

Flow, in literary terms, is the ability to read without getting pulled out of the story. As you are reading your final draft take note of moments where you have to reread something, or your mind wanders off. We want people to not question anything in our stories, so make sure they are sucked down the river of intrigue. If you can get through large chunks without pause, then you’re on the right track. If not, see what the issue is and adjust. Be careful not to get fixated though. You’re at the finish line and art is never flawless.

Ugh...**typos!** If you are a master speller then you will have no typos of any kind whatsoever. I...well, let’s not talk about me. You want to look out for spelling mistakes and incorrect punctuation. An editor will do this for you if you have one, and sometimes if you marry the right person they can look out for those pesky details like which “to” you should use and how to spell “where” correctly.

The very last thing you need to worry about, is **formatting**. That is dependent upon the industry that you are writing for, and how artistic you are choosing to be. And if you are seeking to be published then the publisher will have guidelines for you to follow. And as you write more and more, you will probably format everything in your first draft. Formatting usually makes sense and is helpful, so you kinda start doing it naturally after a while.

IN SUMMATION

Whew. Thank the maker. That’s drafting, revision, and editing. Once you can read through your story without needing to adjust anything important you are done! Congrats! Time for the next project!

Workflow

Ahhh.... Welcome to workflow! **Workflow is the process of creating.** Workflow is all about focus. The best way to write, be it first, second or third draft, is to write consistently and for a sustained period of time. Five minutes here and there is something, so if that's all you have, then do your best, but the goal is to hoard all those five minute moments and to cash them in all at the same time. You want to get into a strong flow so that your ideas can stream easily from one thought to the next. That means that you have the time, space, and necessities. A writers workflow is how words get written.

Find The Perfect Setting

Every writer needs their space. For some it's a place of quite while for others its a place of chaos. The first step in getting into your work flow is finding your 'nook'. Is it the corner table in a coffee shop? The office at home? On the floor in your bedroom? A cabin in the mountains? Wherever it is, your nook needs to be a place that helps you focus, and keeps you inspired. I'm a coffee shop kinda creature.

In addition to finding that nook you may need accoutrements. Snacks, drinks, pillows, notebooks, etc. Whatever helps you to stay put and constantly writing, bring it with you. Bedeck your nook with necessities. I tend to make a little ritual, setting up my computer, ordering my drink, getting my notes out, getting my snacks ready. Makes me feel like a wizard.

Find The Perfect Sound

Once you have your nook you'll need your noise. Some writers can listen to lyrical music while they work, while others need only instrumental. Some need the ambient noise of a café, or the complete silence of midnight. Give me some low-fi and I'm in my groove. The goal is to find something the focuses you without being a distraction itself. That being said, eliminate those noisy distractions like phones, alarms, crying babies, etc. You don't want the noise of life vying for your attention, so leave it outside of your nook. The ding of a phone is a flow killer if I ever...hold on my wife is texting...AH!! SEE!?

Set Achievable Goals

Writing can be daunting. You are inventing worlds and intricate social interactions that are all multilayered and meaningful after all. You need to set yourself up for success by putting achievable goals in front of you. Of course the end game is the finished screenplay or book, but trying to eat the proverbial elephant in one go is always going to be too much. A goal you can set for yourself can be writing a certain number of pages or words per week, per day, or per session. If the idea of trying to hit a page number or word count is too big for you, then you need to try breaking down your tasks differently. Maybe you are just going to write a characters introduction. Or maybe a complete act. Or maybe all you will focus on is a description or a bit of dialogue. Breaking up what you have to do to finish your first draft into easy to swallow chunks can help you focus on what your are doing and will more easily put you into that writers flow. I like to get through a single scene. Whatever feels right to you, set the goal up and attack it. That can also help focus what you are doing for each writers session. Eat the elephant one bite at a time. Unless you're a vegan. Then eat that Beyond elephant.

Another great way to set yourself up for success is to have a time limit. Finishing is the end game here, so put a flag up to where the race should end. Is it one month, two, ten months out? And on a smaller scale is it only three hours day? Two? One? Obviously the more time you have the better, but it's the quality of writing time that matters most. Two distracted hours of writing is less effective than twenty minutes of focused writing. Set your limits, then abide by them. Or else...

And most importantly in regards to setting goals, reward yourself when you accomplish them. Take yourself to dinner, eat that forbidden fruit, give yourself a little trophy. Writing can be challenging at times, but things are less challenging when you're getting recognized for all your hard work. You better recognize yo' self, storyteller.

Workflow Advice

- **Find your 'writers corner'. Café, bookstore, library, in a nook, under the table...**
Find a place that is solely just for being focused and plant yourself there.
- **Remove distractions. Get rid of your all the things that vie for your attention (cell phones, friends, new born babies, spouses, etc.)**

- **Find your 'sound'. Music helps a lot of writers. Sometimes just wearing a pair of noise-canceling headphones is enough to keep your mind on task.**

- **Control your time. Dedicate X amount of time to writing your story. Once it's set, it is law, and you should always obey the law. Unless your baby needs you, then do what you gotta do.**

- **Don't stop. Once you start writing your story, keep going every day if you can. Momentum is how you get things done.**

- **Finish the first draft at all costs. Just do it.**

- **Follow your instincts. They are there for a reason, so listen to them.**

- **Have fun. Because life is better when you do.**

Writing Tools

Follow Me, I Know The Way

You have decided to strap yourself with great knowledge! Fantastic. But with great knowledge comes a plethora of options on how to use that knowledge, which some would say is a great responsibility. You understand the Story Creator Method. Noice. You understand the story elements. Dope. You understand the basics of drafting. Sweet. Let's talk about writing tools, shall we? These be things that are used to add flavor to your story.

When used correctly, or in this manner at least, you can add layers to your story. The goal isn't to confuse people. We simply want them following one step behind us, the storyteller. We want there to be so many simple and easy to follow arcs that they lose the ability to predict the ending. There is no need to make a crazy convoluted series of twists. Na' bruh, all you need is the simple story you already built, now in greater detail.

You can think of it like a murder mystery. The audience is the detective trying to unravel a seemingly complicated string of events. But in the end it's always pretty simple. This person was pissed at this person and killed them. The end. But because we don't want the audience to necessarily know all that in the beginning, there are some simple ways to aim their focus elsewhere. It's a balance of what information your audience is allowed to know, when they are allowed to discover it, and how you weave it between characters and plot.

What does all that malarkey mean? Let's explore.

1. Scenes
2. Sequences
3. Prose
4. Exposition
5. Foreshadowing
6. Conflict
7. Narrators

Scenes

Scenes are the connective tissue between story elements. They are small moments that when compiled with other scenes create **sequences**, which in turn create your **acts**. As you probably know, scenes contain descriptions, actions and dialogue. Let's be real, you know what a scene is, but it's important to remember what a scene is for. **Scenes tell the audience something.** They are moments for us to lay clues as to what is about to happen. Yes, they should be fun, or at least entertaining in some capacity, but most importantly they teach audiences something they didn't know.

There are a couple of things that scenes need in order to be more than filler.

- Direction aka plot development
- Character/world development

Direction

What dost thou mean, oh wisened one? What "direction" means is that scenes need to have a goal in mind; an end. When you start writing scenes, think about how it's supposed to end. Remember that scenes are links that go from plot point to plot point. If you've built your 7-Essential Story Elements then you know what each major plot point is. Direction is writing to the next plot point. You must develop something within the plot to keep the audience going. Without it, your scene literally can burn to ashes and no one will know or care. It doesn't have to be a massive development, and it doesn't even need to be "featured". It just needs to exist to justify the scene in general.

Example: Boy meets Girl

Scene 1: Jimbo is alone and watching Romantic movies with his Pomeranian, Zeus.

Scene 2: Jimbo is walking Zeus when he stumbles into Clara, a single woman having just been stood up on a date.

Scene 3: Jimbo goes to the book store.

Scene 4: Jimbo calls Clara to ask her out.

One of these scenes are not like the other. Can you guess? Scene 3 is superfluous. It has no obvious direction. Scene one introduces a lonely guy. Scene 2 introduces his love interest. Scene 4 has him trying to make a love connection. All plot related. Scene 3 is random. You could cut that out and still have a story. It is vital that each scene advance something. If it doesn't, see what you can add to make it important. Or merge it with another scene.

Along with this idea of direction is the scene arc. **A scene arc is the trajectory of a scene.** Where does it start and where does it end? Just like with the story as a whole, each scene needs a beginning, middle, and end. The beginning of a scene should introduce a problem or challenge of some sort. The middle is the characters trying different tactics to achieve something, and by the end they have either succeeded or failed. Having three parts to every scene helps with the direction of the scene. Scenes that go nowhere feel like filler and that can bog down your story. Boggy stories are ugghhh.

Character and World Development

Scenes that don't introduce something important or add to either the plot, setting, or characters often slow down your story and can lose audiences. **Scenes need characters that are either doing something, or preparing to do something that serves their goals and adds to their development.** That may feel like a lot to accomplish in every scene but it's not as difficult as you might think. Character development is vital for audiences because we naturally are interested in people. We want to see who they are, what they do, and why they do it. If you know some basics about your character, which you should, then you can have scenes that explore one or more of those traits. That way the audience gets to understand the characters more and more as the story goes on. The same can be true with the setting. If the setting is very important to your story then in each scene, or at least in any scene that is necessary, you can add to the world around the characters. Plot exclusive scenes are never as interesting as scenes that develop the plot *and* the character or world. Always develop something.

Scenes need to serve a function. Full stop. As you write, think about what this scene is going to show us or tell us. What do we learn more about a character? How are we setting up a vital plot point? What about the world are we going to develop? Scenes are all about plot,

characters, and setting. If your scene doesn't help you with at least plot and character then you are writing a killable scene. Don't do that! Be great! Remember we are writing on purpose, so give your scenes a purpose. Like, for real though. Even if your scene is funny or sexy, or action packed, develop something that ties into the rest of the piece. Earn the scene! DO IT!!!!

Sequences

Sequences are a collection of related scenes. "But aren't all my scenes related?" No, peasant! Even if they are in the same story that doesn't mean they have anything to do with one another. As you are writing, there will be themes, plot points, and character developments building in your story. One way to help the audience along in their emotional journey is to have scenes that are related to each other follow one another.

Why is this important? Well, my friend, having multiple scenes that share the same theme helps the audience feel all the feels. You can literally guide the emotions of the audience without them knowing. By having scenes that have a common theme linked together, you can cater your sequences to have a profound affect.

Like with everything, balance is the key. You don't want to overload your audience with far to obvious scenes. What I like best in a good story is discovering for myself what the author is trying to say. It tricks me into thinking rather than just passively observing. With everything, the more engaged you are as an observer the more of a memorable experience you will have. Being too blunt can bore folks.

Let's look at an example of a sequence that has a basic theme that is expressed bluntly.

Scene 1: Man is at his mothers side when she dies and he cries.

Scene 2: Man is at home crying. (See above for why)

Scene 3: Man meets a girl but can't talk because he's too busy crying.

What's the theme? Crying. How do we know? Cause that's what he does in each scene. Because of the blunt nature of the sequence of scenes the audience is beaten over the head with the basic feeling of sadness. Not my cup of tea, personally.

Let's look at the same scenario but with scenes that are more subtly crafted.

Scene 1: Man is at his mothers side when she dies and he barely holds it together.

Scene 2: Man is at home removing every picture in the house of his mom.

Scene 3: Man meets a girl but can't talk because she laughs like his mother used too.

Here we go! What's the theme? Loss. How do we know? Cause he seems to be trying to deal with his mother's death by erasing her from his life and avoiding anything that reminds him of her. He can cry in each scene, but with a subtle touch you can convey a deeper meaning to the three scenes. You don't need to over explain it later on with dialogue. You see what's happening. And what's cool is that the feeling an audience member will have won't feel blatant. Subtly my friend, is key. By looking at the sequence of scenes and deciding that "loss" was the deeper emotion I wanted to convey, there can be subtle changes to the individual scenes that make the whole sequence more compelling.

Let's look at a sequence of scenes without anything in common.

Scene 1: Lady is fired from her job.

Scene 2: Lady is dancing at a club.

Scene 3: Lady meets a dude and awkwardly flirts with him.

So what is the theme here? The first scene may or may not have anything to do with the second or third scene. There isn't quite enough. There isn't a strong enough direction. Those are cool individual scenes but there isn't any connected feeling to them. A lot of that has to do with the lack of descriptors, and that's partly the point. The little details inside the scenes can link them all together, or let them drift around like the last bits of soggy cereal in bowl of lukewarm milk. Gross. Let's add a theme of (spins wheel) rebelliousness to the scenes and see what we feel.

Scene 1: Lady is fired from her job because she **refuses** to work the way her boss wants.

Scene 2: **Instead** of looking for a new job she hits the dance club as an FU to corporate BS.

Scene 3: Lady meets a dude and decides **F-it**, she's going home with him cause she wants to.

So rebellion is the theme. Because of that we get a sense that she's used to doing things the "right way". This is a departure from what she normally does. This *feels* like something is about to happen.

By thinking of a collection of scenes as a sequence it can make you think of stronger ways to link them. Those connected themes build a bridge for your audience to traverse and in the end everyone is better for it. Your scenes need to have a point. Remember that. Sequences need to have a theme. Remember that as well. The sequence of scenes adds to the ebb and flow of the story. Taking people on an emotional journey is more than just having good and bad things happening. How you structure the order of scenes will affect how your sequences feel. How you structure your sequences will determine what kind of emotional journey your audience will ride. Take people on a simple, yet complex journey. That's how you structure your story to be deep. Deep is great. Let's be great, on purpose!

Prose

What is prose? The stuffy way to say it is "Prose is the written or spoken language in it's ordinary form without metrical structure". The cool fun way to say it is: Prose ain't poetry. When you are writing, you are either writing in prose or verse. Verse is writing that is arranged with a metrical rhythm, typically having a rhyme. Verse is patterned and prose isn't. Poems and song lyrics are verse. Most everything else is prose.

Now we have talked about this, kinda sorta, before. Prose is your VOICE!!!! If that section melted your brain, then this might be a bit easier to digest. There are a few ways to think about prose. You may hear about purple prose, or beautiful prose, or boring prose. I find that a bit limiting, and since you are reading this and I've planted subliminal messages throughout the book, you find those categories limiting as well. Let's think of prose as a

range. There are two sides, and as a writer you can oscillate between them. Let's call them **High Prose, and Low Prose.**

High Prose is as close to poetry as you can get. You explore emotions and descriptions using flowery language, metaphor, and or analogy. High prose is poetic.

Low Prose is as close to a text book as you can get. You explore everything using as direct language as possible. You use examples, rather than full on metaphor. Low prose is informational. (This book)

Let's look at examples of the two ends of the prose spectrum. The prompt is a man who has lost his bunny enters a room, doesn't see the rabbit, and leaves to find it.

High Pose Example:

As if in a dream, Jim ascended the wooden stairs that had held no significance until now. Now, the creaky wood, chipped paint, stained boards meant both hope and despair. He wasn't just returning home, but he was discovering the truth. Were his efforts in vein? Was this the time he would be relieved of the pain of loss? But as he opened the doors that once were the gateways to peace, he felt a looming dread build and grow like a sickness that begins in the belly but soon radiates outwards towards every molecule of space inside your waring body. His disconsolate eyes scanned his ransacked apartment, and his fears were not only confirmed, they were multiplied. The symbol of hope, love, and light; the last remnant of his euphoria, was gone. He had been violated. The rabbit in which he'd poured so much of his soul had been taken. The fear began to shift. Like ice in a campfire pot, the state of his emotions melted, then heated, then boiled. His heart began to burn and his fingers bubbled like crackling grease. There was an inferno so hot inside his essence it threatened to disintegrate the last vestige of sanity from this once calm and even man. Jim was not himself; not anymore. Jim

died in that moment. And soon, someone would do the same for their betrayal and thievery. There was a new significance to the wooden steps now. He turned, took heavy, dark strides back towards the stairs, and descended... forever.

That is an example of High Prose. The language is flowery. The descriptions are vivid, poetical and laced with many things. There are lots of feelings and imagery in high prose. The emotions are large, the scope is monstrous, and the everything is designed to make you feel all the feels.

Same prompt, low prose.

Low Pose Example:

Jim rushed up the stairs and busted into the ransacked room. He was terrified. He whipped his head left, then right. She was gone. Someone had stolen his precious rabbit. That...was the last straw. He knew what he needed to do. His fear turned to fury. He turned and raced out to find his lost bunny, and to punish the man who took her.

There is an example of Low Prose. The language is more direct. The descriptions are quick and contain mostly just information. You still feel things here, but the goal is to keep things going.

Why should you think about prose?

The reason I want you to think of prose as a range is because your prose can change throughout your story. And you can do it in a bunch of different ways. You can alter your prose for each character, or for each scene, or for major plot points, or different chapters. When you describe a new location, or a new person, you can signify the importance to your audience by how much high and low prose you choose. If the voice you've chosen is low prose, then you can heighten a moment with high prose. And vice versa.

Think about your important characters and places. Imagine you are writing in fairly low prose and you introduce a character using high prose. That juxtaposition will stand out and people will have a higher chance to remember them. And imagine you have a kiss in this low

prose story. If you write just the kiss in higher prose then the kiss stands out as super important.

One of my favorite stories does this exceptionally well. In *The First Law Series* By Joe Abercrombie, he has a character who is typically written in low prose. Logen is a blunt man. Simple, slow. He isn't eloquent. He's a warrior and is good at killing things. Most everything written in his chapters are Low Prose. But there is something special about him. When he is close to death, he changes. He becomes the Bloody-Nine, the most feared man in the north. When the Bloody-Nine takes over then the prose skyrockets. A fight scene with Logen is written using low prose, so Joe describes things as you kinda expect a fight scene to go. But when Logen turns into the Bloody-Nine, it becomes poetic. He stops telling you the facts, but instead he describes the experience of the fight. The contrast informs the reader what to feel, what is happening, and that makes the read more unique. Damn, Joe. Well bloody done.

Prose is apart of your writers voice. Your voice will have a natural resting place on the prose scale. As you write your first draft, be aware of it, but don't worry about it. If you write your first draft in Low Prose you will probably get through it quickly, which is great. Then in your second draft you can add the different levels of prose as you see fit. You can lower it or heighten it whenever and wherever, as long as it serves the experience you want your audience to have. The prose is up to you, my dear. Have fun.

Character Development

A big part of story is the characters and their journey. We know this. But depending on how long you want your story to be you can use character development in different ways. Let's say you're writing an epic fantasy series. To be epic, you need lots and lots of things happening. So, you might try writing chapters and scenes that only reveal a simple aspect of a character. You might spend twenty pages setting up the fact that your protagonist is a hothead. Cool. Neato. Chapters or scenes like that might exist outside of the main plot, but what they should do is give more context to plot points as we discover them. Your characters hotheadedness leads him to make a super rash decision which directly affects the plot. That chapter you wrote before now makes a lot of sense.

But let's say you want to tell the same story, but you don't want the epic epic-ness that a long series would offer. So, in the chapter that you discover your protagonist is a hothead, other more plot oriented things must happen as well.

Example 1: Sir Archie is at a fancy lunch when he is antagonized over the placement of the soup spoon. He challenges the butler to a duel by the end of the chapter.

Example 2: Sir Archie is at the kings coronation when he kills the butler for incorrectly placing his soup spoon. By the end of the chapter Sir Archie has instigated a civil war.

The first example could take multiple pages and have lots of banter and set up so that the climax of the scene is the challenge of the duel. The second example not only establishes the character, but also a plot point, the civil war. Both can be interesting, but depending on what you are going for, one will work better. **Character development affects pacing.** Do you want your audience to sit for long stretches of time learning all the nuances of the story? Do you want the audience to “get to the good stuff”? Think about how you want to divulge your characters traits in every single scene and that will help dictate the pacing of the story.

For **walk of life stories**, stories about a day-in-the-life of a particular character, they tend to be less plot driven. When the story is about a person going through their day, then what matters most are the developments and traits of that character and the folks around them. So as you write, you want each scene to develop the characters and the relationships. The plot becomes less relevant. HOWEVER... and this is a big however, it's **still important**. Chekov is a great example. A bunch of people talking about their sad lives for a few hours. However, they gotta do it before something happens. That something is the plot which keeps the characters going, but it ain't the main thing. Shakespeare on the other hand is more plot oriented. The development of the characters directly affects the plots progression. (For the record, I'm more of an R&J man over a Cherry Orchard bloke.) Walk-of-life stories can spend a little more time with the developing characters, especially if you want the audience to sit with them for a while. If you don't, then write scenes and chapters where multiple characters are developing at the same time. That speeds things up and gets you into the thick of things.

Regardless of the genre of your story, developing your characters in every scene is important. People will lose interest if everything is entirely plot based. Balance, young jedi, is the key to great writing.

Parallel Characters

This is a fascinating tool. Parallel Characters are characters that represent different aspects of your protagonist. They are used to help show the audience and the hero the theme that you are exploring. They can also help develop a complex character arc.

Let's say you have a character dealing with depression, Character A. If you put in another character, Character B, who is also dealing with depression, the protagonist can learn from interacting with character B. Let's say A goes on a bender and B starts fighting random people. You see that both characters are spiraling. But you get to explore it in different ways. A could join a support group to get better. B can find true love. You are exploring the same theme in two different ways, which allows you to easily go deeper into your theme than you could do with just one character. Sure you could have character A go on benders, start fighting people, join a support group, then find true love. But for some writers that's too much. Parallel characters allow you to spread out your ideas, build theme, and help you tell your story in a deeper way. You can write a compelling story without them, but why not try it. You might find something magical.

Two types of Conflict

Conflict is the meeting point between two opposing forces. It is the push and pull in your story that makes everything have meaning. And by conflict I don't necessarily mean plot, although that is a conflict. Your main plot will have a conflict or obstacle the characters are trying to surmount and a reason why it's difficult to overcome, so too will each scene you write. As it relates to characters there are internal and external conflicts. Internal conflicts being emotional or spiritual conflicts, and external conflicts being physical ones or issues brought upon by others. There are two other types of conflicts to think about.

- Situational conflicts
- Character generated conflicts

Situational conflicts are conflicts based on circumstances the characters find themselves in. This can be any external situation like natural disasters all the way to political schemes. The key to situational conflicts are that they are difficult situations the characters are forced into. If you want a character to prove who they are, then present them situational conflicts.

Example: Two sisters are working at the same law firm. Only one of them can make partner, and they both need the job to support their struggling families.

In that example the conflict is based on the situation. They both need the job, they both presumably love each other, but only one person can get it. The situation is what drives the conflict, not the characters themselves.

Character generated conflicts are conflicts based on choices the characters make.

This can be any choice that forces them into a difficult situation like choosing to hook up with an ex or deciding to live a life of crime. The key to character generated conflicts are that they are dictated by the actions the characters choose. If you want a character to learn from their mistakes then their should be plenty of character generated conflicts in their story.

Example: Two well-to-do brothers are working at the same fire department. One of them lied to the fire chief so he could get promoted instead of the other.

Here we have an example where the character is the source of conflict. The brother didn't have to lie, but he chose too, which will make for more issues later on.

Within a story there are possibilities to have both situational and character generated conflicts. Depending on the story you are trying to tell and how you want your characters to grow, a different type of conflict may be more beneficial than another. Stories about how people overcome obstacles are typically more situation based whereas stories about who people are contain more character based conflicts. For more complex stories, using both strategically can deepen the story as a whole.

Example: Two friends are working at the same university. A grant can be given to only one of them based on the review of the superintendent. One of the friends decides that he will sabotage his friend because his department is less funded than his friends.

In this example there are both situational and character driven conflict. The grant only being give to one of them is the situational conflict. The friend sabotaging the other is the character driven conflict. Mmmmm juicy.

Your characters are the most important part of a story. The conflicts that they are faced with help to define who they are, which is a huge draw for audiences. Think about which types of conflicts you want your characters to go through. As with most things, balance is a good idea. But... if you had to favor one over the other, situational is the way to go. It allows your characters to really think about their decisions and to make the best of situations. It can put people in difficult situations without resorting to bad decisions. That keeps them honest, which personally I really enjoy. But, do what feels best for your story. Always do that.

Writing Exposition

Writing exposition can be hard. You are typically doing it to provide context for why characters are doing what they are doing and/or you are foreshadowing something down the road. This is when writers sometimes just tell the audience what is going on. That can often be distracting and can lose you your audience. The point of exposition is not an info dump. The point of exposition is **to convey information that is critical to the story**. Semantics, but let's explore.

"Remember 12 years ago when you and I robbed that bank? My daughter had just been born. I got caught and went to jail. Now I'm here for revenge, so turn around so I can shoot you with my gun!"

That is "bad" exposition. It's a quick and dirty way of dumping info in a scene and it's hard for people to buy it. That's mainly because that's not how people speak. People tend to elude to things, or have a deeper subtext to what they are saying. And we often don't give concise context to what we are saying. We usually know something about the person we are talking to, and so we let them infer. Try to *show* exposition instead of telling.

"She's twelve! Do you understand? I missed out on my daughters life because of you. If I'd known you wanted to rob a bank I'd've shot you at graduation. Turn around."

That is “good” exposition. You understand that this person has been away for twelve years, was tricked into robbing a bank, got caught, and now wants revenge. None of that was overtly stated, rather implied. But more than just understanding the relevant info you *feel* the anger of the character. You get a painting of a missed opportunity that this person longs to rectify. You feel the fury that brought them to confront the person, an old college buddy it looks like, who got them locked up. And now there is a dark need to kill them to satisfy some thirst for vengeance. And even without mentioning a weapon, you know that they have one. Good exposition is able to convey much much more than info dumping.

Now that example was exposition through dialogue. The other type of good exposition harkens back to the old saying “Show, don’t tell.” You can let the environment and the actions of your characters tell you everything you need to know. Let’s take that example from above. How can you show all that with as minimal dialogue as possible.

INT. Mike’s Apartment - Night

Johnny (mid 30’s) steps into the shabby studio apartment. The only furniture is a small mattress on the floor next to a cheap folding dining table. Johnny spots pictures of a baby stuffed into a dirty torn open envelope.

CLOSE UP ON THE ENVELOPE: New Jersey Correctional Facility 2010.

Johnny picks up another ENVELOPE marked with the same address but the date says 2022. The pictures stuffed inside this envelope are of a twelve year old girl.

The last thing on the table is an old newspaper clipping. Johnny picks it up.

CLOSE UP ON NEWSPAPER CLIPPING: Princeton Valedictorian Micheal Maloney sentenced to 12 years for robbery of Union Bank. Accomplice gets away.

Johnny’s eyes go wide. A floor board CREEKS. Before he can turn the BARREL of a PISTOL presses against Johnny’s head. The hammer is pulled back with an audible CLICK. MIKE (Mid 30’s), looking haggard and furious, stands behind Johnny. Johnny knows he’s about to die. His eyes look around for some sort of escape, but he finds none. Terrified, he slowly turns around.

Mike slowly takes the pictures and the newspaper out of Johnny's hand.

JOHNNY
(Terrified)
I'm so...so sorry bro.

MIKE
(Cold)
You do care. Thanks. I've got spot all picked out for you. Let's go.
Mike leads Johnny outside.

This example is all visual. We learn all the same things but this time there is no "Telling". The only words we hear are character driven, not plot driven. Plus be showing us the newspaper clipping and envelopes we can discover a bunch of things. Passage of time, backstory, intention, obstacle, stakes, etc. We don't need the characters to say anything expository. Instead we can craft dialogue in the voice of our characters. That's way more cool. And it makes the dialogue seem natural. When you can, always show people things. You only say what the audience can already see if you are emphasizing it in a new light, or putting some character development on it. That way the audience doesn't feel like you are dumbing things down or being too repetitive.

As you write your first draft go ahead and write your bad exposition, especially in dialogue. Sometimes it's necessary to figure out what you are trying to say. But on the second draft see how you can hide it. Make it a part of character development. If the writing style you choose is exposition heavy like third person omniscient, by all means explain the parts you can't show. But think about how you can show certain elements. And remember the adage *actions often speak louder than words*. That by itself can fix a lot of bad exposition.

In Medias Res

In Medias Res means **into the middle of things**. It is a way of jumping right into the story without needing to do the traditional set up. Sometimes you don't want your story to have a whole act or sequence or even a scene dedicated to your established norm. You can weave your established norm, and any character traits, into your story in clever ways. It's a non-linear approach to the start of your story, even if you want a linear story.

Let's use Batman as an example since his is one of the more highly recognized Established Norms and it's been done to death. (I believe in beating dead horses. My

therapist tells me every day that I have a problem. Hypocrite.) Batman is a rich kid, blah blah, parents murdered, blah blah, raised by butler blah blah, fights crime, whoopdee doooo. How you tell people all that information is where the ART comes in. The simple way is to just show it all. Have scenes that show you absolutely everything. Another simple way is to have a narrator or character tell the audience. Both are perfectly valid, technically, but there are other ways.

Let's say you start his story on the hunt for the Riddler. Batman and Commissioner Gordon are discussing clues. You have an opportunity to drop some sweet EN as a plot point in the story. And by plot point I mean a significant fact within the plot. The clue that Gordon relays to Batman is something like:

"The murder weapon was found in an alley behind the old opera house".

"Not..." Batman falters. Gordon nods sadly.

"In almost the exact spot your parents were killed. I think the Riddler is trying to make this personal."

That bit of dialogue establishes that Batman is an orphan. It doesn't tell us everything, but it intrigues us to his backstory. You can wrap the EN into the plot so that the more we learn about our protagonist, the more we discover about the plot.

The Established Norm can also play out in flash backs, memories, dreams, confessions, all sorts of things. Once you know what it is, you get to choose how you want it conveyed. I want you to have the power to play, to create, to weave something intricate and deep. Or do something simple. If your audience likes to be told everything then just be straight with them. But if they like to discover things, then you can do that as well. You don't gotta make absolutely everything convoluted and tangled, but you can layer simple bits of the world before the Inciting Incident naturally, like a plot point disguised as a bit of character development. Little things like that help make stories simple and also complex. What?! Is that the name of this chapter? Crazy!!

Sometimes you don't want to start your story with your established norm. Maybe it's not that interesting, or you think no one will care. Or you just want to add some mystery to the story. Whatever the reason, the established norm is still important so you should know it and share it out. Weave your established norm throughout your plot. It lets us get straight to the action and get to know the characters better.

Foreshadowing

What is foreshadowing? **Foreshadowing is hinting at things to come in a story.**

Foreshadowing is a powerful powerful tool. In the wrong hands you can destroy a masterpiece. In the right hands you can create one. So how do you use this power correctly?

Subtly. (Mind blown).

Good foreshadowing is setting up elements in your story that you will call back to later. You might introduce a concept as a side note in a scene, then use that concept at a crucial moment later in the story. Bad foreshadowing is simply stating that a thing will be used later.

Good foreshadowing Example:

John looked around the study trying to find something to smash the spider his wife was screaming about. He found a stack of his dad's of magazines. Some on birds, a lot on fishing, and a few magazines on expensive safes. The later was odd and seemed out of place, so John grabbed it and rolled it up. His wife needed a hero.

In this example the foreshadowing is tossed into scene. The odd magazine is used to kill a spider and is noted, but not overtly so. When we find out the dad used to be a professional thief, then we can look back and go, "Explains the odd safe magazine in the dads study." Let's look at a bad example.

Bad foreshadowing Example:

John looked around his fathers study and saw a few magazines on expensive safes. It was odd that his father had magazines on safes. He was a noted fisherman and bird watcher. Magazines about safes and banks didn't seem right. John left the room, wondering what his dad would need with reading material like that.

Why is this bad foreshadowing? One because it's far to obvious. Two because nothing happens in the scene. It's simply a scene used to plant the idea that John's dad was a

professional thief. Scenes that serve only one purpose are less interesting than ones that serve multiple. When the reveal happens you want the audience to either say “Wow, crazy, but makes sense” or “I knew it! Haha!” That’s what the first example does. The second example makes us go “Yeah. That was pretty obvious.” See? Less enthused. We want to enthused. Be enthusing. Come on bud, be a smarty, don’t foreshadow super obvi!

There are many ways to foreshadow something. Introducing characters, concepts, items, histories, anything, into the fabric of the plot or character development gels the foreshadowing and hides it in plain sight. If you know how you want your story to end, then you can plant seeds everywhere, connecting the whole piece. It’s like when a comedian tells you a joke in the opening, then brings it back in the end. You don’t realize that the first joke is part of a larger joke later on, and when it hits you feel like everything is connected. That makes your story something people want to experience again and again.

Narrators

A narrator is the voice from which the story is told. Sometimes it is as blatant as a Morgan Freeman voice over. Other times it is an abstract lens from which you view the story like an omniscient being who you never meet but who is deciding to tell you this story anyways. Depending on what perspective you are writing in, the narrator can tell completely different stories, or at least have different viewpoints. Sometimes your protagonist is the narrator, or a tertiary character, or even you, the writer. Regardless there are two basic types of narrating styles you can use.

Reliable Narrators

Reliable narrators are voices that tell the truth, the whole truth, and nothing but the truth to your audience. These are voices that have all the facts either due to hindsight, hyper intelligence or omnipresence. Reliable narrators don’t give many opinions, unless they line up with the truth. They know what is going on and report it accurately. What’s great about reliable narrators is that they allow you to easily convey accurate information quickly.

Unreliable Narrators

Unreliable narrators deal in the business of opinions. They may sound like they know everything, but they don't. They are guessing based off the information they have. They are projectors, assumption makers, presumers and can tell the audience things based on how they feel. They can be great tools for leading the audience down the wrong path so you can surprise them later. Unreliable narrators make mistakes, are flat out wrong, or are somewhat correct in how they describe what is going on. First person, second person, and third person limited can easily use unreliable narrators. You believe me, don't you?

Muhahahahah!

Theme

Theme is the reoccurring concept that is woven throughout your story. It is what your story "is about". In your first draft having a theme in mind can guide you. While you are working on your second draft you want to be aware of the themes present in your work that you may or may not have intended on adding. Even if you didn't start out with a clear idea of a theme in mind, there is going to be a few that the audience will pick up on. Theme can sometimes feel like a moral, such as "it's better to be good than bad". Themes can also be more complex like "a father is the man who is there for you, not the one who isn't." You don't have to teach people anything unless you want to, but refining what your story is ultimately about will help you focus your story. Theme is subtextual and can't be avoided, so lean into it and make it serve your purpose. **The way theme is usually expressed is either directly or indirectly.**

Direct theme expression is obvious. It looks like "With great power comes great responsibility". Obviously that's what Spiderman is going to be about and the audience knows that cause Uncle Ben told us. You see a lot of direct theme in superhero movies, kid shows, self help books, things like that. When you are writing a direct theme you need a clear and obvious "statement of the theme". Uncle Ben's quote works great for that. Or you can

have a soldier standing on a hill of Nazis with the American flag waving behind him. Either way it's clear and obvious.

Indirect theme is more subtle. It's something like having multiple scenes where a character is looking sadly at random children. The theme there could be about "wanting a baby", or "the loss of family". But as the story progresses we start to realize that the theme is "potential" because that's what children represent to the protagonist. It isn't overtly stated. No one talks about the theme, they live it instead. If you've ever seen the movie Hancock, by Vince Gilligan and Vy Vincent Ngo, they explore the same theme present in Spiderman. But instead of Uncle Ben saying things, we see the Superhero Hancock constantly avoiding responsibility despite his great power. And he is punished whenever he does help. But by the end he can't help himself. He has to help people, even if it means losing everything he loves. Because... With great power comes...

Whether you prefer direct or indirect theme expression it is part of your voice. It shapes the direction of the story and is what your story is ultimately about. Figure it out, lean into it, and be rewarded with clarity.

Biased Advice

When you are developing your idea, start with theme. What is something you think people should know more about. Some theory you have, or love, or hate. Then once you have that theme, make your protagonist. They should either be the opposite of your theme, or be the embodiment of it. Whichever way you go, make your deuteragonist or antagonist the opposite of your hero. I find it more interesting to have your secondary character believe the opposite of the protagonist and to have the antagonist believe the same as your protagonist. That way the protagonist is basically fighting themselves until they realize the truth. Then they can switch gears, and express your theme in the climax. And each of your ensemble can represent a different aspect of your theme. That all serves multiple purposes. Imagine the theme is "strength is community". Your protagonist can believe that "strength is fighting alone when your back is against the wall". Your secondary character can believe in your theme. The antagonist also believes in your theme. But the tertiary characters all believe in a mix. What that does is it puts your protagonist at personal odds with their deuteragonist while they are at physical odds with the antagonist. And everywhere the protagonist goes they are conflicted with their own beliefs. You don't need to construct artificial conflict now. It's all inherent in the story. That's pretty dope. But hey, that's just me. As long as you are leaning into your theme then you do what works best for you.

In Summation

Writing is simple. Words on a page. The complexity in writing is simply adding each element one by one and committing to your decisions. It's a lot like life in that way. Living is easy. Eat, sleep, do things. But putting all those "things" together, as simple as they may be is the work. I want you to build each of your story elements, choose your storytelling style, then start writing. Your voice will come. Your skills will grow. Your talent will blossom. You are going to develop a critical eye as you write, which is great, and hopefully you won't feel forced into a box as you embark on your writers journey. The story creator method and all the tidbits are dancing in your brain. Just start big and narrow down. Hopefully you feel ready to tackle that screenplay, body slam that novel, and pulverize that play. Go watch great movies and spot the brilliance. Read your favorite stories and ask how would you make them better. The true secret to writing is writing. So keep at it. Enjoy it. Look at the marvelous story around you and see where the elements are. Pick up that pen, open that computer, put your thinking cap on and build something beautiful on purpose.

The Builders



Dig deeper

One does not simply walk into Mordor

If you are here, you are looking for something. You are dedicated, motivated, enthused. And I don't blame you. You've got wonderful ideas and you need to see them through. And you will. You just need to flesh things out a little more. Whether it's your world or your characters you want to know as much as you can. Are you over thinking it? No. You strive for excellence. Perfect. What follows are deeper prompts and ways of thinking about your characters and world. The point is simple, you want to build the crucial details about your story. Not what favorite music your characters listen to. Stuff like that may or may not be useful. We're looking for keystones. Things like the culture of your world. The history

World Building



Building A Complex World

We're Not In Kansas Anymore

Hold on a minute? What are you doing here? You want to build out your setting more? What are you? Some sorta perfectionist? Are you some sci-fi/fantasy geek trying build your own universe? NERD!!!

Setting is massively important as it affects everything else, right? Within sci-fi and fantasy you have people famous for world building. World building, as the name suggests, is the process of developing a detailed and plausible world. Think Lord of the Rings, Star Trek, and Battlestar Galactica. But world building isn't limited to those two genres. Crazy Rich Asians is set in modern day, but with people who live in a microcosm of our world where it's not enough to be a self made millionaire. There are traditions, societal norms, and places that most of humanity has no clue about, and it's all real. That "world" is heavily detailed and doesn't need robots or magic to make it unique. Not everyone has been where you have been, seen the things you have seen, or are even aware that those things exist. If you find yourself writing a story that requires a deeper understanding of a unique setting than just the basic when, where, what, and why, then you are world building. Congratulations!

There are three main elements to a world: **geography, society, and culture**. The geography portion includes basics like the name of the world, other major locations, terrain and wildlife. Society is more in line with how the people function as a community, so government, social systems, types of military etc. The culture section is about what makes these people unique by looking at things like art, how their education system works and what their architecture looks like. Together you get the three major aspects of a world. It's important to know everything you can about your world and just like building a story it's best to build it from the biggest idea to the smallest. Geography effects society and culture more so than society and culture effects geography. When you world build from macro to micro (Geography, Society, Culture) each new idea can inspire the next. So let's begin with geography and see where it takes us...nerd.

Geography

Hey Explorer! Let's get the ole map out and start plotting some landmarks. Knowing the geography of a world, especially in sci-fi and fantasy helps make a place feel real. Geography is the topographical view of your world. If you were an alien on a powerful spaceship, this would be what your scanners could pick up. Everything you could observe from afar without needing to speak to those odd looking bipeds.

The reason we start here is because the land shapes the people. Mountain folk are different than swamp folk. If you are from the jungles of Africa you probably aren't going to be inventing snow shoes any time soon. And the homes from the dry desert will look nothing like the homes in wetlands. There is a reason why people from different parts of the planet have such vastly different cultures. The main reason is the land they are from. So let's build that out first. Here are 13 things to build out for the geography of your world. And keep in mind this is to serve your story... just reminding you. Kay. Here we go.

Warning!!!

You don't have to go into every single detail. This isn't supposed to be an almanac, just a reference tool. So don't kill yourself over the perfect whatever. Just choose things and follow the logic train. Copy that?

Name

This is the name of the entire world, or universe. Whatever the name is will have some sort of meaning behind it, even if it's just location based. The name may also be in the language of the people who lived there before or currently live there now. The naming of your world can be based off of gods, heroes, resources, cardinal directions, etc. Whatever you choose, make sure you enjoy it.

Country

This is the name of the country or land where the majority or major events occur. This could also be where your main character is from. If the character is nomadic then this is the area they tend to travel through the most. You can also create a list of major countries that are prevalent in your story.

State/Province

This is the state or more local area of the major location, or a location of a major event. The idea, if you haven't caught on already, is to narrow in on where your story will be taking place. Oh, and if you are doing a piece that is super localized, like a story about mice in a big house, then extrapolate accordingly. Nerd face.

Capital/Major City

The major city or seat of government. Even if very little to no time is spent here it is good to know it. Why you ask? Cause that's where the "Man" lives. You should know where big brother is located. Or this is simply a well known city that acts like a main hub for people.

Resources

This is the main resource of the major location. This is what the location has to offer or is known for. Resources can be anything. Culture can be a resource. People, money, minerals, food, music. What a place is known for will shape the people in it and around it. It will draw other societies to each other. It will be the cause for disputes, jealousy's, and wars. It will also dictate what the people mostly do. Hollywood is rich with actors. Montana is rich in cheap open land. The people and their lives in either place will be vastly different simply because of the resources around them.

Major Locations

These are other important locations in the world your building. This is more important when you have characters from different places or your characters are traveling around. Nondescript places can make your world feel cheap, so think of anywhere you want the story to go. Other major locations are like secondary, tertiary, and antagonist characters. Make them feel real!

Major Location Resources

These are the main resources of the other major locations. Again, what a place is known for shapes the people in and around it. Places known for farming have different communities than places known for gambling. And if you have story about farmers going to war with gamblers you'll be glad you wrote this down.

Climate

This is the weather patterns of a location. Even if it is not a major element to a story it will effect life, society and culture. And in like every way. People develop different body types based on the climate. Don't see many pasty white Nigerians do you? People who grow up in snowy places have vastly different lives than people who grow up on sandy beaches. And not only does climate change the genetic make-up of your people and the culture therein, but it's also the ambiance. Climate can easily set the mood, earthling. "Twas a dark and stormy night" paints a different picture than "Twas a muggy and humid night". Think on your climate people, tis important.

- The most common climates are:
- **Tropical:** Hot and Humid.
- **Arid:** Hot and Dry.
- **Mediterranean:** Hot dry summers with cooler wetter winters.
- **Temperate:** Mild sumers and winters.
- **Continental:** Long cold winters with short hot summers.
- **Polar:** Extreme cold.
- **Artificial:** Man made weather.
- **Nuclear Winter:** A period of abnormal cold and darkness with smoke and dust.
- **Uninhabitable:** Unsuitable for living.

Terrain

Here is a big one. Like mount Olympus big. The major topography of a location dictates culture. Terrain will affect travel in your world. It will also affect clothing, architecture and other cultural elements. People who live in flat lands might farm a lot. They also might be nomadic. You don't see many nomadic cultures in the mountains. People living by rivers and oceans tend to fish and build lots of boats. People in the plains... less so. Terrain is super important ya'll. And living in the valley like totes makes me a hella different person than, like, not living in the valley. Whatevs.

According to geologists there are roughly 12 types of terrain.

Plateau - an area of relatively level high ground.

Mountain - a large natural elevation of the earth's surface rising abruptly from the surrounding level.

Plain - a large area of flat land with few trees.

Valley - a low area of land between hills or mountains.

Tundra - a vast, flat, treeless Arctic region.

Oasis - a fertile spot in a desert, where water is found.

Grassland - a large open area of country covered in grass

Desert - a dry, barren area of land, that is characteristically desolate, waterless, and without vegetation.

Swamp/marsh/bog - an area of low-lying, uncultivated ground where water collects

Forest - a large area covered chiefly with trees and undergrowth.

Hilly - a naturally raised area of land, not as high or craggy as a mountain.

Artificial - land that is man made

Wildlife

Food! Or pets. Or dangers! Wildlife are the major animal life of a location. These are the different types of creatures that will be present in the world as cuddly pets, scary predators, delicious livestock, and general fauna of the world. A place dominated by geckos will be different than a place with lots of bats... Or maybe that place is just Hawaii. Either way, knowing whether or not your characters should be concerned with wild dinosaurs or the occasional pigeon is good to know.

Flora

More food! Flora is the major plant life of a location. The different types of vegetation that will be present in the world. Even if the world is barren, there may be a bush or type of algae that has some sort of natural resource that can be used in your story.

Magic

This is simply if magic is Rare, Common, or non-existent in your world. This can also be a description of what the magic is and how it works. There is a whole section later on about magic and how to build it properly, so don't worry about it too much right now. Unless you're some kinda nerd. You nerd.

tech

This is the type of technological advancement the location has in your world. I'd recommend being basic. Build it out, of course, but if your story isn't about technology then stick with the basics. Think along the lines of:

- Hyper Advanced
- Advanced
- Modern
- Era Specific
- Industrial
- Medieval
- Ancient
- Primitive
- Various
- None.

This can also be a description of what the tech is and how it works. Like magic there is a whole way of thinking about how to build technology later in the book. So keep reading, you beautiful nerd you.

IN SUMMATION

All these elements comprise your geography. This is the macro side of world building, and it's where you should start. Unless you already have an idea then start there and come back to this. In either case, make sure you are taking good notes here, you strange humanoid creature!

Society

The society is the type of civilization your world has created. It's how the major populations run themselves and what they are composed of. These would be the major topics of discussion amongst us alien historians. "These people are a zealous lot who are ruled by a unit of elders. Fascinating, Gargoul, isn't it?" "Yes, but not as fascinating as this military state lead by pacifist matriarchs. Aren't they intriguing, Glob Glob?" The societal elements will more directly affect the stories you will be creating, not just the people. Think hard about these bits, cause they be important!

Government

The type of governing body or authority that the location is ruled by. This can also be applied to any other surrounding locations to your story. This is great to know for any story that deals with politics or war.

Unitary State- Power is held by a central government.

Federation - Power is held by self-governing unitary states under a central federal government.

Confederation - Power is held by a union of sovereign states for a common action.

Anarchy - Power is held by no governing body.

Democracy - Power is held by elected officials.

Oligarchy - Power is held by a small privileged group of people.

Autocracy - Power is held by one person.

Empire - Power is held over multiple nations by a central ruler/government.

Theocracy - Power is held by a person or group serving a higher power.

Chieftdom - Power is held by legitimate senior members of a people.

Often you will see combined types of governments. Something like a Democratic Autocracy means the people elect a single ruler. A Theocratic Chieftdom means there is a religious ruler who is a legitimate senior of a population. Combine as you see fit, my lord.

Social System

A social system is the type of social structure a society employs. This takes into account the types of social policy's and common practices including hierarchal structure and distribution of resources. It's similar to a government, but not quite. America, the country in

my origin story, was founded as a Democratic (Government) Republic (Social System). It morphed into a thinly veiled Capitalistic (Social System) Oligarchy (Government). The social system dictates what a society finds important.

Monarchy - Sovereign power under a monarch.

Republic - Power through public election.

Tribalism - Power under a chief for small complex societies.

Feudalism - Power through land ownership.

Colonialism - Power through subjugation of a native group by an external political group.

Capitalism - A system in which private owners own the means of production for profit.

Socialism - A system in which workers own the means of production.

Communism - A socialist system in which society owns the means of production for use, rather than profit.

Totalitarianism - A system in which all land and resources are controlled by a government.

Just like with governments, you can splice social systems together. Tribal Feudalism means there is a society that is run by a chief whose power is the land they own. 'Merica is a capitalist republic, meaning private owners who own the means of production to earn profit elect their rulers.

Social Class

This is the social hierarchy. This is getting pretty deep. This is how power or authority is recognized. Patriarchy, power is held by men. Matriarchy, power is held by women. Geriarchy, power is held by old people. How power is distributed influences different types of social issues and conflicts characters may face. It also might change the norms that you are used to which could add unique situations for your story. If your world gives power to the weakest, then how does that actually work? What in our lives changes when you change the status of our social class. Oh yeah, getting deep.

Beliefs

This is the primary religious, faith based, or spiritual systems that a population or major character believes in. Beliefs influence language, art, and culture as a whole. I feel like I

shouldn't need to explain this one too much. Religion, folks. Kinda a big deal. Know how it works for your peeps.

Military

The type of military or fighting force can be crucial to many stories. Societies that have big militaries have a different world view than societies with small militaries. The size and type of a military can also dictate how much global conflict can be in a story.

Races

The demographics of racial nationalities is vastly important to think about. People come from different places around the world, meaning we all have differences. Every society, that we know of, is comprised of different types of people. Knowing the dynamics of your racial makeup can influence the history of your world and current state of affairs.

Languages

What language do your people speak? The common languages of your world are important to know because not everyone speaks the same language... unless they do. If they do then there is a history behind why. Give a name to your mother tongue!

Food Supply

How a nation feeds itself is very telling of the wealth of that nation. If a country scarce in food but rich in gold, then they have to import their food making them a nation dependent upon trade. Places rich in food may be more self contained. Food actually dictates a lot of how a country runs. This may seem a bit arbitrary or unnecessary, but trust, just knowing if food is in surplus or scarcity can alter your society.

Culture

Culture is the way people have developed intellectually and artistically. The geography and society play huge factors in the values the citizens hold. (See, makes sense now right? Ish? Maybe? Validate me!) Typically the more stable the society the more expressive the culture. The more unstable the society, the more repressed a culture can be. However you choose to create your culture make sure that it makes sense within the society that you've built. If you haven't built it yet then shame on you. Go do that. Culture is what characters are going to be saturated in and it will help define who they are. This here is the nitty gritty. This will make the audience feel apart of your world. This is what the aliens are really interested in.

Art

What is the type of artistic expression your society has created? Art speaks to what the society holds as important and reflects the creativity of your nation. This can be very limited in more oppressed cultures or very expansive in non oppressed cultures. Often it correlates to the belief systems of a society, but is also often centered around how a country feels. Art is the pulse of a culture and you can infer a lot about a place based on the type of expression it has. Do the people paint a lot? Create fabulous sculptures? Make movies? Are their methods of expression based on violence, lust, nature? Art informs culture which informs art.

Architecture

The physical attributes that are dominant in homes and buildings define the ascetic of a peoples. How a society has developed structurally will be based mostly on geography, so make sure you know what that is. The types of buildings and dwellings will be dependent on the terrain, weather, and the cultures artistic belief on expression. It also gives dimension to your story. Do your people like columns, or domes, or square buildings? What say you?

Cultural Beliefs

Cultural beliefs are the collective ideologies of a culture in regards to how life functions and how it should function. It's the type of belief a culture is "known for". American exceptionalism. Canadian politeness. Stuff like that. Americans think they live in the best country in the world. Canadians are afraid to offend anyone. Those are collective beliefs the

whole country is known for. Your world's cultural beliefs can also just be expressed as broad mottos, "Winter is coming" from Game of Thrones. Or more complex belief systems like, "The earth is angry and trying to kill us," from the Broken Earth Trilogy. It also can be a 'code' or set of rules independent of the governmental or religious rules already established. Think about the type of nationalism or prejudice or values the majority of the people in your world believe in. Cultural beliefs can influence more subconscious behaviors amongst the society. However it works for you, you might find that having characters who don't believe what everyone else believes can make for an interesting conflict.

Education

How are people taught in your world? Or at least what is the level and type of education a society has? How do they educate their people? (Hooked on phonics worked for me!) And more importantly what do they focus on teaching? Knowing how your culture views education can help you flesh out what kind of people will be running around. This can also include how the culture practices their educational system and the beliefs behind it. Some cultures invest in grand buildings and treat their educators like royalty. Some education is simple traditions passed down the line. Knowing how people are educated can help you understand what your characters might know. And if they are dum-dums or not.

Leisure

Every culture has something that they do to unwind. What is the type of entertainment that is most popular in your culture? It could be sports, or travel, or writing books on writing. Leisure is often a goal in people's lives and so can help you build fun and hope in your story. What a character does for fun tells you a lot about them and the people around them.

Clothing

How people dress tells you a lot about a culture. My fashion sense died in the 90's which tells you all you need to know about my music and movie tastes. Fashion is dictated by weather mostly, but within that how people express themselves can color your world. It can also provide contrast when you're dealing with people from different societies. An islander who wears a parka in London tells you what the islander thinks of Europe. Fashion is a statement of personality, so give it more thought than, "Normal clothes, I guess." Tell the audience what normal is.

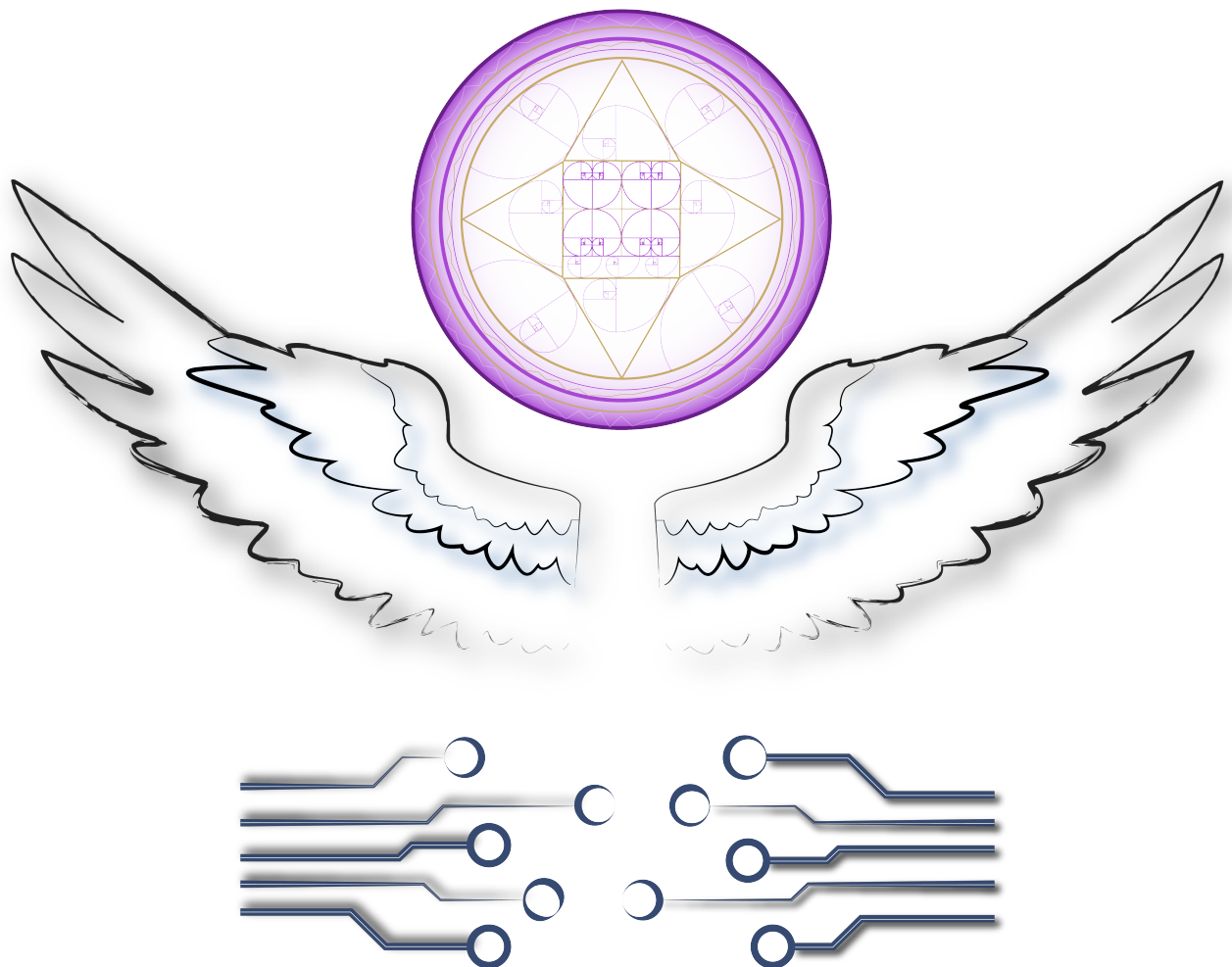
History

Sweet! You're just about done! Here is the juicy part. Now that you know all these little things about your world you can jot down the basic timeline of important events. This is the history of a location from the first important event to the most current important event. This can be as simple as "War has gripped the world for centuries" or as in-depth as *The Silmarillion*, which is the entire mythology of the Lord of the Rings. Write down the history of your world keeping in mind everything you've thought of thus far. Bullet points works fine. It doesn't need to be perfect by any means, but it should exist. Reference tools! Build yourself reference tools!

IN SUMMATION

Well, wasn't that fascinating! Knowing your world in greater detail can add so much color to your story. Most of it won't make the final draft, nor should it. But you want to know as much about it as possible because if you know that your world is deeper than what you've written, the audience will know as well. Remember that writing is magic. The more you put into it, the stronger your spell over the hearts and minds of your audience. Don't fill it with BS, cause that will stink up everything. Bathe your world in important detail. Take your time, have fun, and create somewhere beautiful.

Magic, Beliefs, And Technology



The Three Systems

Live Long and Prosper

Welcome nerd! For you are a nerd if you are here. You have decided to go deeper than all others around you. The rabbit hole is vast and filled with wondrous things. Magic lives here. And beliefs systems. And technology. So very fascinating. But how do you build out a new magic system? You know you need one, but how do you start? How do you make it good? And what if you want to create a religion for your epic fantasy? Besides finding golden tablets or sacred scrolls, how do you start? And for those closeted sci-fi fans, how does one create a truly unique system of technology?

The three systems are all inside the realm of world building. They add color and depth to the setting of your story. Whether you are creating something to help advance your plot or are simply trying to make a more unique picture you want it to be authentic and believable. Why? Well because if whatever system your building feels real, no one will think about the validity of it. They will instead just buy your snake oil and preach its usefulness to the rest of the world. Before 1999 the "Force" was a great example of a system that aided a story without distracting from it. After 1999 there has been much debate on the subject. The main reason being that it began to seem like the canon of magic, belief, and technology had begun to fray like sawed rope. We, the audience, got hung up on a single idea rather than the story at large. Bummer dude.

You never want an audience to focus on your systems. Their eyes and ears should be firmly focused on character and plot. The cool system that you build will be all everyone talks about, but they won't if the story isn't good. If the story is awesome without magic, then it will be better with it. Same with that new religion. And in order to do that you must be solid in your systems. There are two parts of building a system. **Rules and History**. Prepare your runes, pray to the gods, and set your course to the knowledge sector. We are going to look at what is needed to build out magic systems, belief systems and technology systems. Engage!

Building Magic Systems

Go Back To The Shadow

Alakazam! You will now read this chapter! See, magic does exist!

Magic is the power of influencing the world by using mysterious or supernatural forces. A **magic system** is the how and why your magic works. Magic is a wonderful tool to add something exciting and special to any story. The challenge with writing magic is making it both believable and intrinsic to the narrative. The details of how it works and its history can help drive a plot forward, add dimension to characters, and create a unique feel to your story. Magic for magics sake can cheapen a story and make plot elements feel “convenient”. When magic seems to come out of nowhere the audience can be pulled out of the story as they start to wonder about the magic. The goal of adding magic should be to sweeten the world with something unique, not add distractions. You don’t need to explain everything to your audience, but the more YOU know about your magic system the better you can incorporate it into the narrative. Don’t get all cocky and tell us too much. Just the important bits.

Magic Rules

What magic is and what its limitations consist of are the rules of your magic system. A major part of defining what magic can do is what magic can’t do. The limits of magic are what highlight the possibilities and uses of magic. The minutia of what magics limitations are, how it manifests, and what magic is, also helps define and influence the world surrounding magic. It is important to remember that magic is a *system*, meaning there is more to it than a single aspect. The key aspects to the rules of magic are:

- Magic Name
- Magic Base
- Magic Application
- Magic Limits
- Magical Consequences
- Magical Variations

Magic Name

This is what people call magic. Naming magic can be influenced by the language of the world, or what the magic does. For example you can name magic "Frosting" if the magic uses snow and ice to "Frost" things. Or it could be called Fijor, if the magic is for a race of people that speak a slightly Swedish sounding language. Magic can also have multiple names if people from different places all practice it but have different languages.

Magic Base

The magic base is a description of what magic is centered around or the based on. The magic base is the core nature of what magic is. Examples are, time travel, flying, manipulation of gravity, the ability to read peoples minds, rage, energy, imagination, etc... The magic base is the center of your magic and it will determine what your magic can and cannot do. Magic based on gravity won't be able to get inside peoples heads, but it can make someone fly.

Often you see magic being based off of elemental ideas such as earth, wind, fire, and water. It can also be more focused like the ability to control plasma, or levitation. Or write really good books. Magic can be based on the physical, spiritual, and mental plains as well.

Magic Application

This is the process of using magic. Whether it's a spell with words, or a type of mental focus, or a physical foci, how magic works and what people must do to use magic is important. Magic typically has an **energy source**, a **channel** to draw and shape that energy, a **trigger** to activate that channeled energy, and a **result** of that activated energy.

ENERGY: This is the source of power.

CHANNEL: This is the vessel that the source of power is collected into and/or distributed from.

TRIGGER: This is the action that activates the use of the collected source of power.

RESULT: This is the effect/s of the activated collection of power.

For Example: The Energy Source may be dreams, the Channel may be a magic book, the Trigger may be someone reading the book, and the Result may be a dragon is born.

Magic Limits

Everything in life has a limit and a cost. Knowing the limits of how magic works goes a long way to making magic feel real. Unlimited power for a common person makes for a less interesting world, unless that power is checked by something else. (Superman has unlimited god-like powers except for when touched by kryptonite, or away from the sun, or on his home planet.) Limits create vulnerability and creativity in the use and counter use of magic.

Magical Consequences

Magic, like every action, has a reaction. The consequence of using magic is typically directly related to the limits or costs. Exploring the consequences, be they physical, mental, spiritual, social, etc... completes the boundaries of your magic system. The Consequences can be as severe as death, or as simple as the inability to use magic again. Or maybe a severe rash. You choose.

The cost of magic is what happens when the limits of magic are pushed. (If Superman goes too far away from the sun or touches kryptonite he loses his power.) The cost of magic can be physical, mental, psychological, or really whatever you want.

Magical Variations

Magic, when defined by its abilities and its limits often develops variations. Even subtle differences can change something drastically, or enough that a new practice of magic can be developed. The different variations, however drastic, still need to be based off of the same source of magic, otherwise you are creating a new magic system.

For Example: Let's say you have magic based off of imagination. The Source is dreams, the Channel is a book, the Trigger is someone reading from the book and the result is a baby dragon. Let's now add a limit that there is only one book, and the cost of reading from it is you will never sleep again. A variation could be if someone copies the words from the book and makes their own. Now instead of dragons you might get hippogriffs. The copy of the dream book is a variation on the original magic. And if people memorize the book then maybe they create smaller dragons, or different types of

mythological creatures. Maybe it's dependent on the location that they recite the words, or the language. Maybe there is an art to writing the magical book. So many possibilities!

In each example the magic still functions the same with slight variations which can be used in different ways.

Magic History

The history of magic is important as it gives a life to the magic system you create.

This is where you can develop all the aspects of how magic came to be and where it is currently at. The more you know about how long magic has been around and the major events surrounding it, the more depth your magic will have, and the more believable it will be.

The important aspects for a magic systems history are:

- Magics Origin
- Magical Timeline
- Magic Practitioners
- Magical Qualifications
- Magical Awareness
- Magical Life
- Magics Ruling Body

Magic's Origin

How did Magic begin? Fantastic question. Did the gods gift us magic? Or do you have to drink from a particular spring? The origin of the magic within the world and how it came to be is not only important, but supremely interesting. Did it come from a Divine being, an event, a mad scientist, etc...? Or is it natural, and has always been here? Even if you never tell the audience, the history of magic will influence the world around it.

Magical Timeline

What are the major historical events? Following that macro to micro approach, let's dig deeper. You know how magic started, so what are some of the major moments in the history

of magic? This can be the history of great practitioners, cataclysmic events that involve or affected magic and/or its users. This could also be major events in the world that greatly influence the path of magic.

Magic Practitioners

Who can use magic? Me? You? Puppies? I hope puppies. Regardless, it's good to know who is able to use it. Magic is either inherent (born with it), developed (experiments), inherited (cursed or gifted) or learned (magic "school"). People born with magic may be revered or reviled. People who develop magic may be mad scientists or brilliant doctors. People who happen upon magic may be cursed or blessed. People who learn magic may be entitled or outcast. It all depends, young mage.

Magical Qualifications

Why can the above use Magic? Once you know who can use magic then it's important to know why they can use magic. (Why is like a super important question to answer.) The who and the why are often woven together, but separating them out so you can understand each aspect individually can unearth tiny details that can add complexity to your magic system and your story. For example knowing that only people with royal blood can pull a sword from a stone is one thing. Your practitioners in this case are royalty. But the qualifications might be "only the most noble". That rules out everyone except King Arthur, Thor, and Steve Rogers. Knowing the qualifications of magic allows you to create class systems or mythologies surrounding magic practitioners.

Magical Awareness

Who knows about Magic? This is how common magic is to the world. If everyone knows about magic because everyone can use it, then that colors your world differently than if only a few people know about it. Deciding how wide spread the knowledge of magic is can greatly influence your story and world. It might be shrouded in mystery, or as obvious as pet dragons. This will help dictate the reactions characters have when they are experiencing magic in your stories.

Why Do They Know About Magic

Once you know who knows about magic it's important to know why they know about magic. This answer is also woven into the magical awareness, but again, you can separate it out to have an easier time finding it in your notes. And sometimes people forget to think of it,

so now's your chance. Is magic on open display throughout the world, or is it whispered in the dark alleys at night? The reason why people know about magic is just as important as who knows about magic.

Magical Life

What is the culture created by magic? This answer also is tied to the magical awareness. The fact that magic exists or existed creates a type of lore and presence within a culture. It may effect the setting, culture, and society in varying degrees. Understanding how the people of the world have adapted to magic will create a tone that permeates throughout your story.

Magic's Ruling Body

Is magic governed? (Didn't think of that one did ya! Ha!... You did? Cheeky bugger.) Whether it's self regulated or there is a system of rule within the magical world it is important to know if, how, and why magic is regulated. Is there a set of laws magic users must follow? Is there a policing force to stop disobedient magic users? Do magic users rule all? Knowing how magic is governed changes the landscape of your world and story a lot. Like a lot a lot.

IN SUMMATION

The rules and history. That's how all systems work. Knowing how and why magic works will help you write about it. It seems kinda obvious but it's actually hard to remember when you're building a story. Sometimes you come up to a section where magic would be super helpful so a writer will just throw some magic in and keep going. But that's not how you want to use your magic systems. We will talk more about two different ways to think about writing systems, but for now we can just talk about story. Use magic to serve your story, not the other way around. Writing a scene because you want a fireball won't be as compelling as writing a scene about a character working through his relationship issues which is represented by a fireball. Magic systems should act as sweeteners to a story. But the story takes precedence. Remember that, young wizard, and you'll be just fine.

Building Belief Systems

So Say We All

Dear, Hypno Toad. I pray that people find this section useful. All hail the Hypno toad. Ribbit.

Where was I? Ah! Belief systems. A belief system is a wonderful tool to add depth and spirituality to any story. Religion, faith, however you define it, every society has some sort of idea of how life works. Sometimes a character defines themselves by their belief, and knowing what that belief is can help you construct a deep and powerful story. Belief can be thought of in two major categories: Rules and History. Remember that this is going to feel a lot like magic systems and technology systems because they are similar.

Building a belief is about constructing moral and ethical stories that help a character with their own moral and ethical conundrums. Religions and beliefs can also explore the nature of living, how we got here and the purpose of life. Understanding how it works beforehand will help you pepper in the philosophy's that guide your characters.

Belief Rules

Rules rules rules. Pesky, necessary rules. This is how the belief works. Beliefs are a system of rules or guides that structure how a person views their spiritual life. Exploring what the views are, how they work, and how people practice their views, is essential to creating a compelling belief system. This is where you are going to be developing the practice of the belief. This will also include all the philosophies, personal or established codes of conduct, and generally the overall essence of the belief. The core aspects of the beliefs rules are:

- Belief Name
- Belief Ideology
- Belief Rituals
- Belief Commandments
- Belief Consequences
- Sects and or Denominations

Belief Name

Names are nice. If it has multiple names then write them down. Naming your belief can be influenced by the language of the world, or what it is known for, or even the sacred names inside the belief.

Belief Ideology

What is the beliefs system of ideals? At the root of every belief system is an accepted truth. Something like the almighty hypno-toad created the universe, or Death is the only thing to fear. This truth serves as the spiritual, the moral, and ethical backbone of the ideology. This is a description of what the belief is centered around. The beliefs ideology is the core nature that guides everything. EVERYTHING! This can be an inspirational story, or a series of teachings, or a divine belief or an event that rocked the foundation of the spiritual world. Lots of freedom here, my dear.

Belief Rituals

What are the beliefs traditions? Every belief has a physical, mental, or spiritual practice that they do to enforce their belief. This could be as small as prayer at dinner, or as large as human sacrifice, my personal fav. This also can describe the life style of the believer. If this belief is a personal code, then this is where you describe what the actions the believer takes to uphold the personal code.

Belief Commandments

What are the laws of the belief? Religions and beliefs don't work without boundaries. Here is where you describe the things that believers can and cannot do in order to be faithful to their religion or belief. Lists are super common. These can also be where you describe the "sins". Naughty child.

Belief Consequences

What are the repercussions of breaking the commandments? This can be mental, physical, or spiritual punishments. Each punishment can be different depending on the broken rule, or be a single punishment regardless of the "crime" committed. Slaps on wrists, repeated prayers, first born sacrifices to the "Lady of Giggles". Whatever they are, they will affect how serious people take their beliefs. If "*thou shalt not kill*" is the commandment but breaking that rule means no jelly in your doughnuts then I doubt it will be much of a deterrent. Unless doughnuts are life...then sure.

Sects/Denominations

Often in a religion or a belief system you will find slight variations of the same system. These “sects” or “denominations” will have similar views, but will differ in a fundamental way. If they all believe the hypno-toad is the supreme ruler, but some believe that we should follow his every word while others believe we should aim to be like the hypno-toad then we have two versions of a single religion. Often tiny differences are all that’s necessary. Tiny. Itty bitty. Teenie weenie.

Belief History

History is supremely, magnificently, vastly, important to a belief system. Whether the history has been long and corrupt, short and pure, consistent, or variable, knowing where the belief has come and where it’s going is essential to completely understanding it. The key aspects to a beliefs history are:

- Beliefs Origin
- Time Line
- Believers
- Belief Awareness
- Belief Lifestyle
- Beliefs Hierarchy

Beliefs Origin

How did the belief begin? This is the origin of the Belief within the world and how it came to be. The origin can be man made, or mystical, or be based off of an ideology. Whatever the original ideology, this is where you describe the history of its origin. So if belief system revolves around this mighty toad with hypnotic powers, it’s origin could be a space toad landing on earth and subjugating us to its will. Or a series of poems written by crazy priests. Have fun!

Time Line

What are the major historical events surrounding the belief? After the origin, you have the timeline of the belief up until, and sometimes past your story. Knowing how the ideology

has changed or not changed over the course of time will influence how it is believed in your story. Fresher beliefs act differently than established ones.

Believers

Who can practice the belief? Not every religion accepts everyone, or is accessible to everyone. I personally don't allow spiders to practice any of my religions. Mainly due to the fact that they are evil. And they have too many legs. And eyes. And teeth. Yuck. Anywho, sometimes the belief is secretive, or they have strong prejudices that define who can and cannot practice the beliefs. Describing them sets up potential stories/conflicts and can lead to interesting dynamics within-side the story.

Belief Awareness

Who knows about your belief? Beliefs, for the most part, are not naturally universal. Unless there has been a history of expansion, the belief may be known by only a select grouping of people. If the belief is secretive, then maybe the general populace knows nothing about it. Or maybe the 'secretive' belief was secretive, but everyone knows about it anyways. The belief may also pride itself on converting others or "spreading the word" and so is known globally. How well it is known helps influence how much power it has and can also influence the popularity of the believers.

Belief Lifestyle

What is the culture created by the belief? Depending on the values of the belief you will discover different cultures within and around it. Exploring how the belief fits in the world of your story helps root the belief into your worlds culture and way of life. Many zealots worshipping the giant space toad? Or is everyone a chill yogi?

Beliefs Hierarchy

How is the belief governed? Whether it's self regulated, or there is a system of rule within the belief it is important to know if, how, and why the belief is managed. Is it ungoverned? Is there a set of dogmatic laws that the people must follow? Is there a policing force to stop "sinners"? What is the hierarchy of the leadership? What types of powers does this hierarchy have? Most importantly, are their religious ninjas? (All stories must have religious toad worshipping ninjas from now on) Knowing how the Belief is governed changes the landscape of your world and story. It also can cause massive conflict for your story.

IN SUMMATION

Understanding the way your stories beliefs work ground your characters spirituality. They can add very unique cultural traits that add color to everything. The myriad of religions of Game of Thrones come to mind as a great example. Each religion has a saying, they each have rituals, and they inform the people greatly. The more you build these out, the more fuel you will have for your stories fire. So say we all. Amen.

Building Tech Systems

Come With Me If You Want To Live

Beep boop boop beep. Come in R2, I need help translating binary code into human. R2? Dang robot. Fine! I'll do it myself.

Building a tech system is nearly identical to building a magic system. It is used in the same ways to achieve much the same things and can be essential to plot. It can also be a distraction if done poorly. The major difference between a magic system and a tech system is typically genre, but that can be bridged with sci-fi/fantasy stories like Star Wars or in a great many comic books. The more you think about how your tech works, the less the audience has too, making it easier for them to focus on the plot.

Tech also changes the geography and architecture many-a-times. Often you have to destroy nature to build things. From cutting down trees to make catapults to building cities in the clouds, technology alters the world we live in.

Tech Rules

(Does this look familiar? Hmmm, I wonder...) Tech is an ever evolving byproduct of sentience. The more you explore it the more it tells you about the people who built it. A major part of defining what tech can do is what tech can't do. The limits of tech are what highlight the possibilities of tech. The minutia of what the tech's limitations are, how it manifests, and what the tech does, helps define and influence the world surrounding it. Here are the major aspects of the Rules of tech:

- Tech Name
- Tech Base
- Tech Application
- Tech Limits
- Tech Consequences
- Tech Variations

Tech Name

This is what people call the tech you've created. Naming tech is usually defined by either the inventor or the devices use. Different people may have colloquiums for the tech, and knowing those can add color to the setting.

Tech Base

What is tech based on? At the core of the tech is the idea that sparked it. This is a description of what the tech is centered around or the tech Base. The theory behind the technology. Something like *Earths magnetic field* or *time travel*. Whatever the theory that sparked the invention is the tech base, you toaster lover.

Tech Application

How does the tech work? tech is very similar to magic in the sense that it requires the same basic elements to function. tech has an **energy source**, a **channel** to draw and shape that energy, a **trigger** to activate that channeled energy, and a **result** of that activated energy.

ENERGY: This is the source of power.

CHANNEL: This is the vessel that the source of power is collected into and/or distributed from.

TRIGGER: This is the action that activates the use of collected source of power.

RESULT: This is the effect/s of the activated collection of power.

For Example: The Energy Source may be superheated water, the Channel may be a gun, the Trigger may be the gun's trigger, and the Result may be water bullets. This is great to know especially if you wanna sound smarter than you are. When you come to parts in your story where people are trying to understand the technology, then this is what they will talk about. This will also help you to add conflict and tension in the story when you are missing one or more of the four things.

Tech Limits

Everything in life has a limit and a cost. Maybe an actual cost! Capitalist pig! Technology especially has limits. Knowing the limits of how tech works goes a long way to making tech feel real. Omnipotent tech causes undo problems for writers and readers. The cost of tech is what happens when the limits of tech are pushed. How far can your tech be pushed?

Technological Consequences

Tech, like every action, has a consequence with its use. The consequence is typically directly related to the limits or costs. Exploring the consequences, be they physical, social, financial, etc... completes the boundaries of your tech system. "What does this button do?" "Dee Dee! Nooooooooooooo!!!!!" Boooooooooom!

Tech Variations

Tech, when defined by its abilities and its limits, develops variations. Even subtle differences can change something drastically, or enough that a new piece of tech can be developed. The different variations, however drastic, still need to be based off of the same source of tech, otherwise you are creating a new tech system. Also the tech that you create probably has other technologies that compliment or make it work.

FOR EXAMPLE: Let's say you make a flying train that goes 1'000 mph. The train is the main of part of the tech system, however there are many components that go along with it. The engine, the type of fuel, the "Train Tracks" are all things to consider. The engine could be made out of an alien spaceship, the fuel could be liquid metal, and the tracks could be anti-gravity pods. Each of those elements are essential to the tech and can help influence the plot.

Tech History

Ah yes, the good ole history section. I feel like this was copied and pasted from the magic portion of the book and reworded. Lamé. What a loser. Can't even bother taking to the time to write it out from scratch. Pish posh, sir!

This is where you will be describing the history of the tech from its invention to its current form. The more you know about the history of the tech, the deeper it will feel to the audience. Not all of it needs to be in your story, but if you know it before you write, it can influence how the world around the tech looks. Here are major aspects for tech's History:

- Techs Origin
- Techs Timeline
- Techs Users
- Techs Qualifications
- Techs Awareness
- Tech Culture

- Techs Ruling Body

Techs Origin

How did tech begin? This is the origin of the tech within the world and how it came to be. Did it come from an alien race, a mad scientist, a team of brilliant engineers etc...? Even if you never tell the audience, the history of tech will influence the world around it.

Techs Timeline

What are the major historical events? What are some of the major moments in the history of the tech? This can be the history of the inventors, cataclysmic events that involve or affected the tech and/or its users. This could also be major events in the world that greatly influence the path of tech.

Techs Users

Who can use the tech? Tech is often limited in its distribution. It can be hoarded by the government, hidden by space pirates, or a part of everyday life. Describing who has the ability and accessibility to use the tech is important. This is all about creating culture.

Techs Qualifications

Why can the users use the tech? Here is the reason why certain people can or cannot use the tech. It's just as important to know why as it is to know who. More culture stuff.

Techs Awareness

Who knows about tech? This is how common tech is to the world and why. If everyone knows about tech because everyone can use it, then that colors your world differently than if only a few people know about it. Deciding how wide spread the knowledge of tech is can greatly influence your plot and the tone for how the characters interact with tech. Culture, culture, culture!

Tech Culture

Aha! Here it is! With your technological system comes a culture that is surrounding it. If it is secret tech, then the culture could be clandestine. If it is public, then how does the public interact with or discuss the tech? What impact does it have on normal people?

Techs Ruling Body

Whether it's self regulated, or there is a system of rule within the technological world, it is important to know if, how and why tech is regulated. Are tech users ungoverned and free to do as they please? Is there a set of laws tech users must follow? Is there a policing force to stop disobedient tech users? Do tech users rule all? (See, almost verbatim. Lame.) Knowing how tech is governed changes the landscape of your world and story.

IN SUMMATION

Understanding the rules and history of tech IS understanding the world your story is in. Just like with magic and beliefs, tech dictates many aspects of culture. Sometimes so much so that the people in your story ARE tech! And don't get discouraged if you see something in your tech that is present in another story. How **you** build the history and rules will set it apart from the others. Maybe your teleport system creates clones of you. Maybe it bends space and time. Maybe it only works on Tuesdays. Don't worry about the others, and focus on yours. What you do and the story you create will make it beautifully unique.

Using The 3 Systems

The Force Is Strong With You

Let's talk about how we use these crazy systems! Creating a system is one thing, but using a system is something else. Before you decide how you want to use your system, you have to know what your story is about. That's super important. And once you do, then there are two ways you can use your system. The use is dependent upon whether the system is in the background or forefront of your plot. A world OF, and a world WITH.

A World **Of** Magic/Belief/Tech

If the story you are writing uses one or more of the systems as **major plot elements**, then you are creating a world OF. Magic/Belief/Tech (Gosh that's a mouthful. Let's say MBT!) is essential to your plot, your characters, and the whole story in general. In a world of MBT, you are relying on your system to provide unique situations for your characters to navigate through. The system gets them both in and out of trouble, and the more they learn about the MBT system the more the plot develops. In a world of MBT, you are constantly showing the audience either the rules, the history, or both. You want the audience to understand the MBT system so that they are just as compelled in the development of the system as they are in the development of the characters and plot.

Let's say you have a story about 3 kids trying to defeat an evil wizard. The only way they can is to develop their magical skills. But they don't know how to use magic, since they are just kids. Each time they learn something about magic they get closer to defeating the evil wizard. The story is about them developing their skills, more so than the actual final boss battle. This is a story OF Magic.

A World **With** Magic/Belief/Tech

If the story you are writing uses one of the systems as a **background element**, then you are creating a world WITH a MBT system. In this instance the system is not essential to your plot. The MBT system is apart of the world around the characters and is used to help color the world. In a world with a system you may hint at the rules and history but it never takes the center stage. The story, the plot, and the characters, all take priority. It is much more subtle, and used to flavor the story without being the main dish.

Let's say you have the same story about 3 kids trying to defeat an evil wizard. But this time they already know how to use magic. As they get closer and closer to the evil wizard, they use their magic, but that's not what is important. As long as they get to the wizard, it doesn't matter if they use magic or not. Their journey is not dependent on their magic, it's only a useful tool. This is a story WITH Magic.

IN SUMMATION

The short and skinny is this: if it is vital to the plot that MBT exists, then your story is a story OF. If it is not vital to the plot that MBT exists, then it is a story WITH. For stories OF MBT, you need to make sure your audience fully understands the system. For stories WITH MBT, only you need to fully understand the system. Lord of the Rings is a story WITH magic. Frodo doesn't need magic to complete his quest. The rules of the rings and of wizards and of orcs don't really matter. They are there for atmosphere. It is vitally important for Harry Potter to understand magic. He can't defeat Mr. Riddle without it.

WORLD BUILDING IN SUMMATION

So...dang. That's a lot. Now what? Building a world is a deep and involved process. It starts with an idea, which can come from anywhere, and blooms. There are no hard and fast rules on how to build a world, only advice. The one thing that is always true, stories and characters included, is that no matter what your idea is, it needs to have a reason for why it is the way it is. Here are some things to remember while you write. Along with all the other four million things.

Free World Advice

- A world is a big thing, so take your time.
- Even if your character never leaves home, knowing the world around them makes the story seem bigger than just the one place.
- Even one small change can have a big affect on the whole world so follow its effects.
- Think through each aspect of your world, it makes a difference.

When creating your MBT system, have an idea of the story that it's going to be in. If you know the world, then that will always help guide you in your systems creation. And don't limit yourself in thinking your systems have to be used in cliched ways. Magic doesn't have to be used for violence. Magic can be subtle, and it can be big. It can be created when someone cries, or dies, or during a certain time of year. Your belief system can be something that your characters are building instead of practicing. Your technology could be defunct and a thing of the past, but leaving a lasting legacy. Don't let what you know limit you!

If you feel like you are creating a system that already exists, but you like it anyways, then change some of the limits and rules. Build a history around your system that informs your system and let it influence the rest.

Once you start writing your story with the system attached, make sure you follow the rules. If at any point you don't, the audience will catch it, and either discredit the system in its entirety, or they will think that something deeper is happening. If that isn't your intent, then stick to the rules you've created, and see how the characters respond when the system is tested to the limits.

Free Magic Advice

- Magic is mysterious for an audience, but it shouldn't be for you.

- Magic informs a character, and that character informs the magic.
- Don't let a cliched magic system trap you. Change something about it.
- Magical creatures are also magic.
- Magic, powers, high art, mutations...all unique names for the same thing. You

can use a name that is well known if you need to quickly insert a specific image or idea into the mind of your audience, BUT if you have the time and space, create your own. This will help you mentally set your brand of magic apart from all former versions, and give you the opportunity to create something unique without bias from your audience.

Free Belief Advice

- Not all beliefs need to make sense to us, only those who believe it.
- Stories about the beginning of a belief system are always fun.
- Draw from established beliefs.
- The faith you create works best when people are challenging them. The more proof they find against their faith, the more conflict they will face, and the stronger the arc they will have.

Tech

- Don't worry if it's been done before. As with the tech in our own world, the smallest tweaks to an already existing technological advance, is itself a technological advancement. Just ask any patent holder.
- No one will believe the tech if it contradicts itself.
- Think about how the tech affects the world around it.
- Combining tech and magic is always fun.
- Don't let the tech take over the story. Let it influence the story.

Character Building



Building Complex Characters

You Wanna Know How I Got These Scars

So you wanna get a little deeper do ya pal? Wanna get past the basics and make something with some real meat to it? Well dis is how we do it, bub!

Character building is a lot like world building in the sense that you will spend lots of time developing all the aspects of something only to be forced to reveal a tiny portion of it later on. But it's important to do so because for every moment you spend on building your character the better your character will feel to an audience. It's all magic! And each character, no matter how small, should be built out like a protagonist. It's only fair. People are people no matter how important they are to your plot. Tertiary people are people. Even antagonists are people. Love them. Additionally you may discover parts of your character that you want to explore in you story that you hadn't thought of before. Plus there might be some tertiary characters that you love so much they get their own story! Character building is so fun! Get your note pad out! Let's all do it!

Characters are everything. People will watch a bad movie because they love the characters. People suffer through multiple sequels of poorly written books because they like the characters. You can even get away with a weak plot because people love good characters. (I have no stories in mind, I'm just chatting...cough)

Creating a character isn't as straight forward as making a story is, sadly. For some reason creating a fully functional human being is not that simple. It's almost as if people are complicated and can't be judged based solely on the most superficial of traits. Crazy right! Welcome to woke writing, as the kids say in the club they invite me too.

The initial idea for a character can come from anywhere. No way to predict it. You could begin with a woman with long blonde hair who has one green eye and one blue. You could start from a poor boy from a poor family. You could start from the interesting name of Bedungus, and create your character from there. Character ideas can come from anywhere which is great, but they **needs must** be built out so that you understand who your writing. Using that same macro to micro approach to character

building can really help you find the characters voice and inspire you to create interesting people.

Let's say you don't have a character in mind. You know you need one, and you want them to be a believable person. Not a shell with people parts. A real human creature. The audience knows when a character is put in only to serve the plot. It feels fake and cheap, and that's not who we are. We are authentic and expensive storytellers. Every character from protagonist to tertiary, needs to feel alive, so it's time to find them. Let's talk about finding the spark for your character.

Finding the spark in your story

The easiest way to start is by looking at the story the character is going to be in. Taking clues from ***what kind of character your story needs*** can make it easier to find an idea. Just because you think of an awesome spy turned hairdresser character doesn't mean you need to insert them into *this* story. Shape new character ideas to your current story so that they become vital to it. Think of characters that fit like a latex glove, and ones that are a giraffe in the ocean. Both types of characters make for interesting people depending. But the key is that the plot dictates who they are.

Finding the spark in people

Real people are fascinating. Sometimes when you need a character spark you can find it in a person from real life. ***Starting with a real someone, anyone, can lead you to new ideas and inspirations.*** Friends, family members, strangers etc...can all become inspiration for a character. If there is something about this person that you find interesting, your audience will find them interesting as well. They still need to fit and make sense within your story so remember that. Don't just throw random people into your fantasy world cause they happen to be in the room with you. Character ideas are like clay, model them to your story.

Finding the spark in media

Entertainment is another way of finding the spark. Books, poems, dances, etc... can all be great sources of inspiration. There could be a type of character that you find interesting, or a concept that gives you an idea. You can even take a character out of one source and place them into a new environment or circumstance. **Immersing yourself in different types of media can trigger new character ideas.** Do it!! Do it now!

Finding The Spark In Yourself

If none of the above tickle your fancy, then drawing from yourself is another great way to go. **Listing your own traits is a common trick writers use to create characters they already know a lot about.**

Regardless of where your inspiration comes from, whenever you are building your character it is important to **build them as they currently are**. Who they are now is more important than who they will become. (Not in the long run but you gotta crawl before you can fly a spaceship, so hold your booty) It's also important to note that not everything written about them will be revealed in the main story. That does not, however, mean that those qualities are not important. It means that those particular qualities may have a more subtle effect. **You may even find that certain characteristics keep resurfacing.** Motifs we call em. Fun little character traits that aren't important, but help us recognize each character.

Okay, so let's say you got your spark now, sparky. What's next? You gotta build it out, duh! Just like with story you have to break character building down. It can be thought of in six main traits: **Background, Current Living Status, Relationship Status, Unique Traits, Personality Traits, and Backstory**. This order uses that same big to small method we've been harping on. Grab your notes and let's dig in!

Character Background

Okay Dr. Author. You have a patient sitting before you. You need to get to know them in as personal a way as possible. What do you need to know? Who is your patient and where are they from? Everyone came from somewhere. Even someone untimely plucked from thine mothers womb has an origin. **Each one of these character qualities are out of the characters control. They were either born into or were created to have these traits through various circumstances from their backstory.** When thinking about these remember that these are the qualities that they currently have at the beginning of your story. This helps you to understand where your character came from and what they are. Some of this is pretty self explanatory and some of it will need a touch of context. As you begin to fill your character, I mean your patients profile, lets start with the basics, Doc.

Name

This is what the character was called at birth, or at least the first name that was given to them. This also includes any and all other names/titles they may have acquired since then. When thinking of names, find something that stands out from the others, especially for your main character.

Age

This is the physical age of the character at the time of the story's beginning. Boring but kinda important. Unless they are like a vampire who is a hundred years old. Then it's good know the age they look like and the age they are. K, less boring.

Sex

This is the sex of the character as they were born, and what they may have developed into up until this point in their lives. Again, boring, but good to know.

Height

I mean, duh. Tall, short, average. Average for one of the Navi. Short for an elephant. You get the idea.

Body Type

This is the character's current physical type of body as well as what they may have been in the past if it is relevant to their journey. This can be as simple as *athletic*, *plus sized*, *average*. It can also be as fancy as *endomorph*, *cephalopod*, or *frail looking*.

Now things are getting somewhere!

Nationality

This is the race or nation that the character was born with and identifies with.

This is going to be super important for a lot of stories. Changing this can change everything. And this is one you should really think about. Do you wanna play it safe and write with the nationality you are most comfortable with? Or do you wanna take a risk? C'est très intéressante.

Birth Place

This is the location of the characters birth. Boo, back to boring but useful bits.

Raised

This is the location or locations in which the character has grown up. Knowing this can influence a lot. People are a product of their environment. This is where your world building has great affect.

Language/s

This is the language and or languages that the character speaks or understands.

Family

This is the immediate relatives and perceived family members of the character. Distant relatives may be included if they are relevant to the character's journey. Who their family is and isn't can be HUGE! Can someone say daddy issues. OMG.

Socioeconomic Level as a child

This is the class or financial level the character was born into and raised with. If someone grows up poor they have a different experience than someone raised wealthy.

Education

This is the highest level of schooling, training, or learning that they received. It can be stuff like college, military academy, or raised to hunt by wolves. You choose.

IN SUMMATION

These are the basic details of a person. The boring bits, but defining ones. The bits you get out of the way before your therapy session begins. Who they were and who they are now as generalized people. People are a collection of single truths, one influencing the other. Like a cake with many layers. (Everyone loves cake!) Try mixing things up to avoid writing archetypical people. People are always more than their background, even if it defines a lot of who they are.

Current Living Status

What is your character doing? At this moment in space and time your character is somewhere doing something. **At the start of your story the current living status will influence the Established Norm of your character.** Knowing what they are doing now is influenced by their background and can influence all their other traits and backstory. If the general background of a character is the macro, now we are stepping more into the micro. There are only three vital things in regards to the current living status, but they are what currently dictates life for, well, everyone.

Current Residence

This is the characters current dwelling. The more specific you are here the more you will understand what environmental influence your character is currently dealing with.

Current Profession

This is their current job/career or lack thereof. Employed people have different life styles compared to unemployed. And the type of job is also important because it rides along with personality. A 12-year military veteran may sound very different than a hairstylist. You can even put down whether or not the character likes their job. Crazy!

Current Socioeconomic Level

This is their current financial or class status. Newly rich, newly poor, middle class, all of that dictates life for each character. Especially if they came from a different level. Things are starting to heat up ya'll!

IN SUMMATION

You know where your patient comes from, Dr. Author, and now you know a little bit about who they are now. At the start of your story this information will help you with the Established Norm. These traits will be obvious to the reader because we will most likely see all of them at one point or another. Your story may not be about any of it, but it will make the characters make more sense. And isn't that why we are here in the first place?

Relationship Status

So Dr., you know your patients background and their current living status. But what about their romantic interests? Love. Everybody does it. Even crazies. It's often the driving force for many a real life person. "Is this the face that launched a thousand ships?" People are designed to desire others so it's important to know how those desires work. Simply knowing the 5 love languages aren't quite enough, (Although that's a fantastic way to go about it) The relationship status is the romantic nature of the character. This helps you to understand how they handle themselves when presented with opportunities for intimate encounters. This is especially good for rom-coms, dramas, comedy, and anything involving love in any form. To answer Tina Turners question "What's love got to do with it," everything!

Romantic Beliefs

These are the ideas about love and relationships that your character believes in. The philosophies on love and how people are supposed to love others. You can be pretty deep here. It's a complex issue.

Sexual Orientation

This is the social alignment of sexual attraction your character has to one or more sexes. Especially good to know for romantic leaning stories.

Attraction

These are the qualities your character finds attractive in others. It can be physical, mental, situational... You can do what every you like. Yea. The five love languages would fit nicely here. Mine are, in order, **physical touch, quality time, acts of service, words of affirmation, and gifts.** What's yours? Kisses!!

Significant Other

This is the most important or influential romantic relationship the character currently has or has had. There can be multiple, ya nasty. Maybe a series of exes.

Maybe only that girl you be crushing on? Again, best for romantic leaning stories. This can be a whole story in itself.

IN SUMMATION

If your story has any sort of romance in it, then this is how you know what you need. Even if it's an action movie with only one kiss in the end, knowing what the characters find sexy matters. Some Dr.s believe everything we do relates back to sex. Since this is your patient, you get to decide. How much of a love story do you want? Knowing what your characters find attractive will help dictate what other kinds of characters you need around them to heighten the conflict.

Unique Traits

Ahh! Here we go Dr. Author! Let's get deep into that psyche. What makes you, you? Is it your secret fishing obsession? Or your unique ability to blow bubbles with your spit? Or are you boring and simply want to own your own spaceship? Everyone has something unique about them. A talent, a skill, a goal, something that drives them forwards in life. Sometimes a character has many skills, sometimes none. Sometimes their life goal is simple, sometimes not. Regardless of how many unique traits a character has it is important to know what they are as that will influence a characters actions and intentions. The unique traits can be really useful when you're trying to think of a clever escape from a dicey situation. These traits can also get them into lots of trouble. These traits will help you in every part of the story.

Talents/Skills

These are the instinctual talents and/or learned skills that set these characters apart from others. These talents could be tiny, like really good at finding tennis courts (my dad), or something much more expansive like really good with knives (not my dad)

Hobbies

These are the things the character would do if life was always normal. The passions of the every day human. This is a huge part of a persons goal and Established Norm. This can be tied to their Talent/Skills.

Life Goal

This is what the character works every day to accomplish in order for their life to have meaning. This will help you define what your first sub plot is about . More Established Norm stuff!!

IN SUMMATION

The unique traits are the best way to make someone feel different. It's one way to distinguish person A from B. Sometimes knowing what your character is good/bad at will help you to know exactly the type of obstacles to throw at them to add more natural conflict to your story. And you can use these traits in you climaxes as fun solutions. Maybe a hobby of placing half drunk glasses of water all around the house will one day save your life. You never know. For some characters their Talents/Skills line up with their hobbies and Life Goal. Sports stories often. But that doesn't have to be true for most people. Diversify and you can have interesting conflicts later on.

Personality Traits

We are digging deep now, Dr. Now we ask the big questions. Who are you, deep down in that well of a soul of yours? I think I'm a rabbit. Used to be dragon till I found out China has a different calendar system! Grrr. **Every character has traits that help define who they are internally.** These personality traits are more complex than the other qualities of a person as they take all of them into account and can fluctuate depending on the circumstance. These traits are ones that are constantly being tested in their daily interactions. Throughout a story these personality traits may serve as the main struggle for the character's arc. What they once held as a personal belief **may change by the end of the story.** *This is where you character arcs are born.*

Personality Type

The personality type is whether the character is an introvert, extrovert or a combination of both.

1. Introvert - a shy or reticent person.
2. Extrovert - an outgoing, overtly expressive person.
3. Introverted Extrovert - A person who is reticent to express themselves but is overtly expressive when they do.
4. Extroverted Introvert - Person who is outgoing but isn't overtly expressive.

If you really want to you can base this off of astrology or something like a famous personality test you totally can. I have, but that makes sense for a Aquarian Sun with a Leo rising and Sagittarius Mars, amiright!?

Intelligence

This is the level and type of intelligence your character has.

1. Street-Smarts - The ability to learn through experience.
2. Book-Smarts - The ability to learn from teachings.
3. Wisdom - The ability to intuit without relevant prior knowledge or experience.

Some characters are dum dums. Pooh bear, is lovable, but not the brightest. Some characters are dum dums in different ways however. Sherlock aint the best with people even though he's the worlds greatest detective. (Sorry Batman)

Characters who are street-smart learn by doing and value experience.

These characters thrive by practicality. They don't worry about the history or theory of things. They just need to figure it out.

A superhero who practices their skills by getting into the city to fight crime.

Characters who are book-smart learn by studying and value education.

These characters thrive by theory. They don't worry about the practicality of things, only the theory and history.

A detective who spends their time researching everything about a case before finding the bad guy.

Characters who are wise learn by a mixture of street-smarts and book-smarts.

These characters use their past study and experiences and apply them to any situation.

A doctor who saves lives doing surgeries that he's never seen before, but are similar to others they've either heard about or seen.

The type of intelligence a character has helps decide how they will function in different situations. A book-smart person might panic being thrust into a new situation. Street-smart people might struggle in situations where they need to study something without acting. Wise people may struggle when their experiences conflict with their study. Think about what type of intelligence a character has, and how much of it they have.

Spirituality

This is what the character believes on an ethereal level. Their belief on religions, after-life, reincarnation, gods, celestial beings, etc... This is what they believe life is about, where it came from, its purpose and how people function in it. Atheism is included, before you ask. Tis a belief system of sorts. All hail the hypno-toad!!

Emotionality

This is the type of emotional person the character is. Are they expressive, inexpressive, in control, out of control, etc., when it comes to their feelings and how they handle them? This will come in handy when people piss them off or make them happy.

Core Values

These are the unshakeable personal values a character holds. These are the pillars of all their beliefs and all their actions. Sometimes it's a "code," a way of teaching, or instincts that shape everything about them. It's the foundations that can't be broken without breaking them. Thou shalt not, kinda stuff.

Social Values

These are the unshakeable social beliefs that the character believes in regarding how society functions and how they think it should function. These beliefs help dictate how they behave socially. More thou shalt not stuff.

Greatest Perceived Strength

This is the physical, mental, or spiritual trait the character believes they have that gives them an advantage over others. It's not always true, but it's what they believe until proven otherwise. This is great for characters to act on, especially if they are wrong. Discovering that they were wrong about their perceived strength is a great journey.

Greatest Actual Strength

This is the physical, mental, or spiritual trait the character actually has that gives them an advantage over others. They may not know it, and often don't, but it is the thing that gets them out of trouble. Great things to learn at the end of a story, or just as the climax begins. If your character knows about their actual strength already, then it is great to take it away from them to force them to try something new. Makes for more natural drama if the one thing your character can do well they can't do any more.

Greatest Perceived Weakness

This is the physical, mental, or spiritual trait the character believes they have that gives them a disadvantage over others. Just like any perception, it's often wrong but they tend to live by it anyways. Just like the perceived strength, it's cool to have some characters believe dogmatically in a "false" weakness. Helps them to grow by the end.

Greatest Actual Weakness

This is the physical, mental, or spiritual trait the character actually has that makes their efforts more difficult. This can be something like addictions, insecurities, disabilities. The important thing here is this is the real reason a character struggles. Stories where a character discover what their actual weakness can be quite good.

Inner Conflict

This is the spiritual, physical, or intellectual dilemma that the character constantly is struggling with. When the story begins, the inner conflict is the insecurity that is making normal life that much more difficult. This is something your character must constantly deal with. Like are they a good person, or will I ever find love. Inner conflicts will make certain scenarios more challenging in the story.

Alignment

This is a bit nerdy but since nerds are sexy the alignment system can be very useful. This is the moral and ethical stance that helps to define a characters intentions and actions. There are three moral aspects and three ethical aspects that when combined display how a character behaves towards moral decisions and ethical decisions. Throughout the story both their moral and ethical stances will be tested and only after great trials can they be changed. Thinking of your characters alignment can be a fantastic test when you are unsure of what decision they should make or how they should feel given a particular situation. If they break from their alignment, they should break in their brain. Something big should shift in them. Something huge.

1. MORAL ASPECT

A. Lawful - Complete obedience to rules and laws.

- B. Neutral - Respect for rules but willing to brake them.
 - C. Chaotic - Complete disregard for any rules.
2. ETHICAL ASPECT
- A. Good - Believes in the necessity of helping others.
 - B. Neutral - Believes in neither helping nor harming others.
 - C. Evil - Believes in the necessity of harming others.

The nine possible alignments are:

Lawful Good

A lawful good character always follows the established rules or laws in order to help people.

Example: A by-the-book cop who wants to save lives.

Neutral Good

A neutral good character sometimes follows the established rules or laws unless the rules and laws no longer serve to help others.

Example: A cop who sometimes bends the rules to save lives.

Chaotic Good

A chaotic good character follows no established rules or laws to help others.

Example: A cop who breaks the rules at first chance to save lives.

Lawful Neutral

A lawful neutral character always follows the established rules or laws to achieve their own purpose.

Example: A Lawyer who uses the law, and tells only truths, to convict someone without regard to the person's guilt or innocence.

Neutral Neutral

A Neutral or “true neutral” character sometimes follows established rules or laws unless the rules and laws no longer serve their own purposes.

Example: A lawyer who is willing to disregard the law and the truth or follow it in order to convict someone without regard to the person’s guilt or innocence.

Chaotic Neutral

A chaotic neutral character follows no established rules or laws to achieve their own purpose.

Example: A lawyer who lies and cheats consistently to convict someone without regard to the person’s guilt or innocence.

Lawful Evil

A lawful evil character always follows the established rules or laws in order to achieve their goals at the expense of others well being.

Example: A judge who uses the law to incarcerate an innocent man.

Neutral Evil

A neutral evil character sometimes follows the established rules or laws unless the rules and laws no longer serve themselves at the expense of others well being.

Example: A judge who is willing to manipulate laws and ignore truths to incarcerate an innocent man.

Chaotic Evil

A chaotic evil character follows no established rules or laws in order to serve themselves regardless at the expense of others well being.

Example: A judge who uses lies and falsified evidence to incarcerate an innocent man.

IN SUMMATION

There you have it Dr. The true self, the Id and ego, the essence of your characters. You may or may not find the character alignment helpful. I'll admit it's a bit nerdy, but it can be a quick reference when you come up with a moment and you're unsure how your character would act. A lot of dialogue can be pulled from this section as well. Really think about these values. It will tell people exactly who your characters want to be, and truly are.

Backstory

Ok, Dr. You've built your patient, now it's time to give them their report.

Backstory is the character's history until now. (To be honest, this is the fun bit!) It includes anything that could be potentially useful to the characters future. Use the traits from the earlier segments to write a paragraph or essay detailing the series of past events connected to your character. Everything that you've already built can influence the backstory. It *should* influence your backstory, otherwise what was the point. And if you find things in your backstory that conflict with the rest of your character, change them. Don't get tied down unnecessarily. Free-write to your hearts content letting all your work manifest however it wants.

Once your done writing your backstory make a list of important character notes. This is a list of major moments in a characters life that shape who they are. This list can include events that effect a character's physical, mental, and spiritual history. Any fears, love interests, personal heroes, mentors, gods, anything that seems important belongs in this list. And especially motifs! Those can be super handy to jot down. This list can be used as a quick reference tool. Isn't that handy? You're welcome!

Free Character Advice

- **Characters with dynamic traits make for dynamic characters.**
- **Characters are capable of anything if the circumstances are right.**
- **Characters who don't struggle within themselves are not as interesting as those who do.**
- **Perfect heroes are boring.**
- **Evil for evils sake is boring.**
- **Characters who have strong opinions make strong characters.**
- **Watching a character do something that goes against what they believe is interesting...but only if they have a great reason for it.**
- **Without context and reason you have nothing but random acts of story.**
- **Consequences make actions important.**

- **The more you know about a character, the more the audience will feel like they also know, even if you don't tell them.**

- **Follow through with the direction your characters is going. Don't fight it.**
- **If the character is perfect on the outside, make them broken on the inside.**
- **If the character is broken on the outside, make them strong on the inside.**
- **Higher personal stakes make characters journey's more important.**
- **Introducing your characters is important, so take your time.**
- **How a character deals with mounting adversity shows us who your character is.**
- **Have a voice in mind when you write a character. Any voice. Friends, family,**

anyones.

- **Write what you know, but now in the context of your story.**
- **Keep characters uncomfortable.**
- **Uncomfortable interactions are strong ways to develop character.**
- **A characters strength is often best employed in their rise and downfall.**
- **The inner conflict should be present in every scene. Let the demons haunt**

them.

- **Give your characters something unique, a funny hat, to help them stand out.**
- **Kill your darlings: don't write three characters when one will do.**

IN SUMMATION

Building out your character traits is how you fully build out your characters. It's kinda that simple. Your protagonist, secondary characters, tertiary characters, and antagonists all need to be developed. How deep you go will help define how deep they feel? You don't have to spend 9 months cooking up the perfect child, (shout out to all the mothers out there!) You should however know all the basic things about a person. You won't regret the time you spent understanding them, but you might regret not doing so. When you start writing you don't need to put in every single trait. That would be crazy. Aint nobody know everything about you. Don't over explain. But use your knowledge to highlight and accent your story.

Using Characters

Sugar, Spice, And Everything Nice

So you know who your characters are. Nice, well done, what next? Well, now you have to use them. But you can't simply toss them around like juggling balls, you have to use them like daggers. Jab, jab, slice! Characters are not blunt instruments, like plot points. They are the driving force. They are the narrators. They are the life. In order to use your characters effectively you need to understand what makes them compelling. **Context, consequences, and reasons glue your characters into the story. Let's dive in.**

Context, Consequences, and Reasons

When you are thinking of the arc your character should take it is important to remember the **context** of who they are, who or what they are facing, and the particular circumstances they are in. You also have to remember the **consequences** of the characters actions and the **reasons** for those actions. Context, consequences and reasons. Live by that and your life makes a lot more sense. Just saying.

BAD EXAMPLE:

Character: Superman - A Superhero with god-like powers who believes **killing is wrong**, obedience to the law is paramount, and loves Lois Lane more than anything.

Writers Goal: Superman is going to kill a bad guy in cold blood.

Character Arc: Superman is a stalwart hero who believes he is always in the right becomes a **stalwart hero who still believes he is in the right.**

Action: After capturing a bad guy who has killed thousands, **superman saves Lois Lane**, captures the bad guy after an epic fight, then kills him to save two random people.

Result: Superman saves the day, feels a little guilty that he broke his one rule and the law, but ultimately feels justified.

In this example the **context, consequences, and the reasons do not match the character**, and thus the character's arc feels wrong. You have a character who believes killing is wrong, kills a person, then doesn't change in any way. The context of this character is one of moral and ethical righteousness, so the consequences of his amoral and unethical actions should shake him to his very core. The reason for Superman's killing to save two random people does not have a strong impact, nor does it make sense for him to compromise himself so severely for strangers. **The context of Superman is not taken into account throughout the example, the reasoning isn't strong, thus the consequences feel wrong and the character arc feels weak.**

In this next example, the **arc** and the **action** will change, which will affect the **result**. The context, reasons, and consequences will also represent the character and the writer's goal.

GOOD EXAMPLE:

Character: Superman - A Superhero with god-like powers who believes killing is wrong, obedience to the law is paramount, and loves Lois Lane more than anything.

Writers Goal: Superman is going to kill a bad guy in cold blood.

Character Arc: Superman is stalwart hero who believes he is always in the right becomes a broken hero who questions if he has lost who he is.

Action: After an intense struggle, A bad guy, who has killed thousands, seemingly murders Lois Lane. Superman, insane with grief, captures the bad guy and, after an epic fight, kills him to

avenge the loss of his loved one. He snaps his neck just as Lois Lane steps out of the shadows, too late to stop him.

Result: Superman saves the day, feels hollow and devastated now that he has committed a capital crime, and doesn't know if his actions were worth it.

In the "Good" Example, the **context** of Superman is taken into account, the **consequences** are dire because he is going against what he believes in, he's breaking a law which goes against his morals, he kills which goes against his ethics, because his **reason** is directly linked to the love of his life. Not only does this example fulfill the writers goal, it has a compelling character arc because the **context** the **consequences, and reasons** were in line with the character and the writers goal.

Empathy and Sympathy

I wanna talk about one more thing in regards to characters before we depart, my loyal friend. We have talked about the experience you want your audience to have with the overall story. Well there is a similar question you want to ask about your characters. **What reaction do you want your audience to have regarding your characters?** As you are developing your characters you want to make sure that your audience is willing to follow them for the duration of the story. You want the audience to resonate with them in some form or fashion because people are drawn to characters they can identify with, especially with villains. It boils down to Empathy and Sympathy.

Sympathy is understanding someone else.

Empathy is the ability to understand and SHARE feelings with someone else.

There is a slight difference between the two. With both there is an understanding. You see someone in pain and you think, "I get it." But what sets empathy apart is the sharing. With empathy you not only understand someones pain, you feel it yourself. This makes sense for those of you lucky enough to have your heart broken. When you listen to that cheesy pop song talking about "Why'd you leave me" or "My world is broken" you FEEL it. Icky. Now, you don't need all your characters to be empathetic, but I'd implore you to make them all sympathetic.

Sympathetic Characters

Sympathetic characters are characters that the audience can understand and have some sort of compassion towards. The audience knows what they like and what they are fighting for, and that goal that drives them is easy to get behind. They are driven by common goals like love, wanting to prove something, trying to better themselves or the world around them. Things like that. Things that everyone can reasonably say, yeah, I get it. What's most important is that the audience understands. Without understanding there can't be any sympathy. And even more importantly than the most important thing is their actions have to match their words.

For example, if you have a character who is trying to stand up for themselves, that is something we can all get behind. Their "words" are ones of being an underdog and trying to

get justice. Now if the actions are positive ones, then we can all easily root for them. If their actions are negative, then we start to lose understanding. We start to disconnect with them.

That's the difference between an underdog working really hard to get to the top and an underdog killing everyone to get to the top. You "lose" the sympathy of the audience when their actions don't line up with their goals. That can be a great tool if you are working with a falling arc, but not so much with the others. And even then, if the negative actions they take don't affect them deeply and personally, then the audience will get lost and maybe even give up on the whole story.

The easiest way to get a sympathetic character is to show the audience what the character is passionate about. What do they love, and why do they love it? Show us those two things and we will be on board.

Empathetic Characters

Empathetic characters are a bit deeper. They are characters that the audience not only understands, not only have compassion towards, but they make you feel what they feel. This is often done with pain, although it can also be done with pleasure. What's really important with Empathetic characters is how hard you drive their passions home to your audience. The audience can't just know at a glance what drives them. They need to know how deeply their passion pushes them. Everyone is extremely passionate about something. Family, money, careers, public perception, something. If you just tell the audience, then we will understand them better. If you show them working at their passion, then we can all have a little sympathy. But if we are forced to live in that passion, and see the effort it takes to grow or maintain that desire, then the audience can feel it. Even with a character that is vastly different than our own. John Wick is a great example. **SPOILER ALERT!**

John Wick is a retired assassin. Not really all that relatable. So why do we care? Well his wife just died of cancer. That sucks, but he's a trained killer, he'll get over it. But I understand why he's sad. Then he gets a gift from his dead wife; a puppy with a note that says something like "I want you to have something to live for so you don't return to the darkness." Damn. Who doesn't love puppies. But what's more important is the letter. He has a darkness inside him, and nothing really to live for since his wife is gone. That means that this puppy, the last gift from the woman who showed a dark man light, is a representation of all that he has left that is good in the world. The dog is his wife, for lack of a better term. The dog is all he has. He is alone and sad, except when he's with this little puppy.

And then an A-Hole kills his dog.

Now that example is pretty blatant. We understand his grief, even if no one in our lives has died of cancer. We have sympathy for him, because he devotes his time to the dog, and nothing else. That is his passion. We even have the buds of empathy because we can all get on board with having a story about a man trying to find himself after his wife dies. That really could be enough. But what really kicks it over the edge in this story is tragedy. His dog is killed for no good reason by gangsters. His darkness returns. He has nothing left except revenge. So we, as the audience, are totally on his side. He can literally kill everyone in the movie and we never stop rooting for him

You can do the same thing with pleasure. You can have a character who is so driven by the thing they love that when an opportunity comes for them to fulfill their dreams, they burst with joy! Think RomComs, or talent show stories. A nobody guitarist who plays music on the street for the joy of it gets an opportunity to go on tour. Happy things like that. You can generate empathy with pain or pleasure, so pick your poison. Or non poison. Or... just choose which one you want! And not every character needs to be empathetic. Only the important ones like your main characters. Everyone else is up to you.

What I hope you get from that is that for empathetic characters we have to feel what they are going through. We have to live in their goals for a while before the inciting incident kicks everything off. We need to be saturated with understanding. Now don't tell us everything on the planet. Too much can just makes us bored. You can use the rule of three. **Tell us what they love. Show us what they love. Then show us a test of their love.**

IN SUMMATION

Sympathetic characters and Empathetic characters both need to be understood, regardless. So match their actions to their goals. And if their actions deviate from one of their core values, then let that affect them hard and forever. People live with pain every day, so let your characters do the same. And if you want a character to go down a dark path, but you want the audience to remain on their side, try to make us sympathetic towards them. If you've seen Breaking Bad by Vince Gilligan you see a character who breaks his moral code again and again. But one thing that keeps us on his side is his fear, shame, and desperation. Each time he does a horrible thing, he cries, or vomits, or is shaken so much that his personality changes. He is desperate to keep going, no matter the cost. And we are here for it. We get it. We lose all empathy for him by the end, but by then, the story is over. What a ride!

Intention, Action, Results

We are nearing the end my friends. I wanna talk about one more thing that relates to both characters and writing in general. Judgement. How does an audience judge? What are they looking for? How do you define if a character is truly is good or bad? A change in perspective? Maybe. How do you change perspective as an audience member? You can't really. You can only get what the storyteller gives you. In my opinion, and based off of observations of the world, you judge something by recognizing three things. Intention, action, and results.

In real life if you want to do something good, try to do something good, something good mostly happens. But the results aren't always guaranteed. For some people, if you nail the first two then the result doesn't matter. You did your best and your heart was in the right place. That's what's important. Others say only the results matter. Irregardless of the fact of the matter that you did your best, the road to hell is paved with good intentions. Some say it's only the thought that counts. Others say it's what you do that defines you. To each their own pick of poison, but I think there is a balance. If you want to make your audience laugh, then you write something funny, but then no one laughs, did you fail? Maybe, maybe not. If your character wants to save the world, tries to save the world, but destroys the world, are they a villain? Let's explore this a bit more.

Intention

Intention is the first part of judgement.

Intention, as we've learned before, is the super objective of a plot. The main thing the character is trying to do. As a writer, intention is the answer to the question, *what experience do you want your audience to be left with*. If my goal was to make you weep, and so I wrote a tragedy and you wept, then I was successful. If I wanted to make you weep and I wrote a tragedy that made you giggle, then I wasn't successful. And by successful we're not talking about dollar signs or attention. We are talking about how a contextually relevant audience experiences your work. **Your target audience.**

By the time you have finished writing, there will be an audience that is perfect for your work. This book thingy here is perfect for early writers, or writers with no formal education. It's even more perfect for people born in 'Merica during the late 80's early 90's who love fantasy

and sci-fi and are in the creative industry. My target audience is me, and people who like the way I think. So if a twelve-year-old financial genius who enjoys creating algorithms for better data computation trashes my books, I'm not going to get bent out of shape. My stuff just isn't for them. My intention isn't for them to love my book. My intention is for my target audience to enjoy it, and learn some things that will help them build better stories. Like with our characters, we aren't trying to do everything and please everyone, we are trying to do one specific thing.

Make sure you know your intention for your work when you are writing. When people comment on your work, see if they understand instinctually what your intention is. Don't tell them. See if they get it without your help. That will either tell you if those critics are the right ones for you, and/or if you have been clear with your story. Either you still need to find your target audience, or you need to go look at your writing again.

Action

Action is the second part of judgement.

What you and your characters do, matters a lot. Action is the physical representation of intention. It is the rising action, rising reaction, and climax of a characters journey. If you, storyteller, are trying to make someone laugh, and you write a drama, then your action doesn't line up with your intention. If your intention is to make people laugh and cry, then writing a dramady is probably the best action you could take. As you build your story and write that sucker, see if your action lines up with your intention. Is your comedy funny? Is your drama dramatic? Is your action story filled with action. You want to be true to your intention. Otherwise you get something that only kinda sorta works.

With your characters you can break away from the realities of life. Let's say you want to make complex characters, or conflicted characters. In those cases juxtapose their actions and intentions. If a guy wants to save his marriage so becomes a pornstar, what kind of story will ensue. How does he justify it? What in the world is he thinking? In order to be judged correctly, or at least positively in real life, our intentions need to line up with our actions. But in the world we create, they don't.

Results

Results are the third part of judgement.

People are often judged by what happens, fair or not. You can try to write something good, fail, and people will judge you harshly. (Except for kids, actually. We tend to reward them for the effort. Lucky ducks.) We can't control how events turn out nor how people respond to your work. All we humans have in life are our intentions and actions. Circumstance and luck dictate results, not you.

The nice thing about your characters is the fact that you are circumstance and luck. You decide the results and how they are perceived by everyone in your story. That's pretty cool. To make complex characters, think of results that are in the ball park, but not quite what is expected. Like if you have a guy meets girl story and instead of them getting married, they become best friends who adopt a puppy together. They aren't "together" together, but they are close enough. When thinking about your story's end, try to land just outside the box. You decide the interesting results.

As far as results for your writing goes, what should you be hoping for? Awards, money, and immortality? I doubt it. To get awards you have to do more than write a good story. You need to submit the story to the right people, get the right eyes on it, then hope that ego's don't get in the way and no one else writes something that is more relevant and personal to the people reading your work. Oh, and also hopefully nepotism isn't a factor. Same thing goes for making tons of money and becoming immortal. You need lots of luck.

But what you can do is set yourself up for success by lining your intention and actions up. The more thought you put into story building and story telling the higher the probability people will experience the experience you want them too. You won't catch all the fish in the ocean with a sliver net, but if you go fishing in the right waters with the right tools at the right time, you will catch the fish you're fishing for. That's why it's important to know what experience you want your audience to have. That's why it's also important to know what your ending is. Creating your north star will get you closer to where you want to be. And if by the end of your journey you are happy with your story, you are experiencing what you want to experience, then you did it. Everything good aside from that is just a bonus.

When you are taking your manuscript out into the world of beta readers, editors, publishers, agents, and filmmakers, find like minds. Don't get discouraged with people who don't think like you not being interested or excited about your story. If you do, then you will feel like a failure and your intention and actions won't seem to matter. Don't end your journey short because your courting elves when you should be courting hobbits. If the elves join you, then awesome. But if they call you a dirty halfling, don't worry about it. Worry about what the hobbits have to say. At the end of the day, love the story you wrote. And remember to never compare your story to anyone else's. Let the elves do that. You only ever need to compare you to yourself, for that is how you grow.

The point of this section is to put a concept in your head. People judge you based off of your intentions, actions, and results. All you can control are your intentions and actions. If you do those right, then you have a great chance at getting the results you want. The one really really cool thing about writing is that you get to decide if your characters get what they want. You, the master storyteller, can do only what luck can do: decide what happens. Let go of everything else and just be free!

Final In Summation

Writing is simple. Words on a page. The complexity in writing is simply adding each element one by one and committing to your decisions. It's a lot like life in that way. Living is easy. Eat, sleep, do things. But putting all those "things" together, as simple as they may be, is the work. I want you to build each of your story elements, choose your storytelling style, then start writing. Your voice will come. Your skills will grow. Your talent will blossom. You are going to develop a critical eye as you write, which is great, and hopefully you won't feel forced into a box as you embark on your writers journey. The Story Creator Method and all the tidbits are dancing in your brain. Just start big and narrow down. Hopefully you feel ready to tackle that screenplay, body slam that novel, and pulverize that play. Go watch great movies and spot the brilliance. Read your favorite stories and ask how would you make this better. The true secret to writing is writing. So keep at it. Enjoy it. Look at the marvelous story around you and see where the elements are. Pick up that pen, open that computer, sit in your thinking chair and build something beautiful on purpose.

Story Creator



Writing Exercises

- Watch a movie or read a book and point out each story element and when it changes.
- Write a 7-Sentence story with each sentence being a different story element. Once you're done, try rearranging the sentences to see how that affects your experience as a reader.
- Write a 14-Sentence story with an A and B plot, with each sentence being a different story element for both subplots.
- Write a 21-Sentence story with an A and B plot, with each sentence being a different story element for each sub plot.
- Combine the five different writing style elements together and write a scene. Now rewrite that same scene changing one style element of your choice.
- Write a paragraph in your natural perspective. Now rewrite it in a different perspective. Keep doing it until you've done it in each one.
- Write a short story with three main characters from the Protagonists POV. Now rewrite it from the Antagonists POV. And again from the Secondary Characters POV.
- Write a simple short story from one POV, beginning to end. Now write another story from someone else's POV and have the stories intersect. Make sure the two stories NEED each other to work, meaning you need both for it to make sense

Story Elements

1. Established Norm - The world before the story arc
2. Inciting Incident - The event that begins the story arc
3. Rising Action - The actions characters take to accomplish their intentions
4. Rising Reaction - The consequences of those actions
5. Climax - The final action
6. Falling Action - The consequence of the final action
7. Resolution - The new Established Norm

Arcs

- Story Arc - The Inciting Incident to the Falling Action

- A plot - The personal story of the protagonist
- B plot - The personal story of the secondary character
- C plot - The personal story of the tertiary characters

Make sure that something personal happens to the characters that pushes the plot along during each story element.

Character Arcs

- Growth Arc - A character arc where the person gets better.
- Fall Arc - A character arc where the person gets worse.
- Change Arc - A character arc where the person becomes something different.
- Flat Arc - A character arc where the person doesn't change.

Story Creator Writing Process

★ Build your story

- Idea - What if
- Setting - Where, When, Uniqueness, Why this place
- Characters - Protagonist, Secondary, Tertiary, Antagonist
- Plot - Intention, Obstacle, Stakes, Timeframe
- Ending - How does it end
- Beginning - How does it begin
- Middle - Your story

★ Pick your Writing Style

- Genre
- Medium
- Perspective
- Tense
- Structure

★ Pick your Voice

- Pacing
- Syntax
- Word Choice
- Mood
- Tone

★ Draft

- Write the mother-flipper!

★ Revise

- Fix the mother-flipper!

★ Edit

- Finish the mother-flipper!

★ Repeat

- Write another mother flipper!

Free Plot Advice

- **Starting your story in the middle of something important is always a fun idea.**
- **Make sure all the elements of story are clear.**
- **Coincidence is strongest when it's putting characters in danger and weakest when getting them out of it.**
- **Higher personal stakes are more thrilling than non-personal stakes.**
- **A simple plot with multiple layers is deeper than a complex plot with only one layer.**
- **Connect your plot to the characters growth and vice versa.**
- **Keep your plot present in every scene.**
- **Make sure that each plot point has an undeniable reason and consequence.**
- **Show, don't tell, unless you need to.**
- **All actions need a consequence and a reason.**
- **Follow the consequences of each action to find logical outcomes in your story.**
- **Probable possibilities are preferable to improbable possibilities.**
- **Actions that contradict your characters beliefs help grow them.**
- **Force your characters into impossible situations and see what they do.**

Literary Definitions

1. **Story:** A sequence of intriguing events that uses Characters and Plot to recount a narratives beginning, middle, and end.

2. **Plot:** The cause-and-effect sequences of events in a story that concern the Intention, Obstacle, Stakes and Timeframe.

3. **Subplots:** Subplots are secondary plots that run parallel to, and supports the main plot.

4. **Plot Device:** A character, prop, location, or event that is used to advance the plot.

5. **Intention:** The super objective that the Protagonist will either accomplish or fail at by the end of the story.

6. **Obstacle:** The person place or thing that hinders the protagonists quest to fulfill their intention.

7. **Plot Point:** A fact within the plot of significance.

8. **Major Plot Point:** A significant event within a Plot that alters the direction of the Story.

9. **Minor Plot Point:** An event within a plot that significantly informs a major plot point.

10. **Pinch Point:** A minor plot point that increases the conflict significantly within the plot.

11. **Event:** A moment of importance.

12. **Acts:** A major section of a story that contains scenes or chapters that are used in creating a story's structure.

13. **Exposition:** The introduction of the necessary backstory of characters and events.

14. **Conflict:** The main struggle of the characters.

15. **Conclusion:** The end of the story.

16. **Goal:** The character's original ambition inside the story before the Inciting Incident.

17. **Reason:** A cause or an explanation for an element inside a story.

18. **7-Essential Story Elements:** Seven major plot points necessary in all stories. They are the Established Norm, Inciting Incident, Rising Action, Rising Reaction, Climax, Falling Action, and Resolution.

19. **Story Elements:** The Idea, Setting, Characters, Plot, and Ending of a story.

20. **Setting:** The locations where the story takes place.

21. **Character:** The people, places, or things that live in your story and influence the narrative.

22. **Protagonist:** The leading character of a story that the audience follows.

23. **Secondary Character:** The most influential character to a protagonist who accompanies them on their journey.

24. **Tertiary Character:** A character who is less important than the Secondary Character but still has an important significance to the story.

25. **Narrator:** the voice from which the story is told.

26. **Antagonist:** The person place or thing that is directly in opposition to the Protagonist.

27. **Character Arcs:** A personal journey that a character takes within a story.

28. **Established Norm:** The life of characters before the Inciting Incident of a story.

29. **Inciting Incident:** The first major plot point that breaks the protagonist away from the Established Norm and introduces the Obstacle, Intention, Stakes, and Timeframe of a story.

30. **Rising Action:** The series of events and/or plot points after the Inciting Incident that directly affect the characters and advance a plot.

31. **Rising Reaction:** The consequences following the Rising Action that directly affect the characters and heighten the conflict of a story.

32. **Climax:** The climatic turning point in a story which resolves the protagonist's intention and/or goals.

33. **Falling Action:** The aftermath of the climax with the success or failure of the Protagonist's intention.

34. **Resolution:** The consequences of the Falling Action and establishment of the new norm.

35. **Theme:** The central idea of a story.

36. **Stakes:** The major consequences of the protagonists successes and failures.

37. **Genre:** A particular category within art.

38. **Medium:** A particular form of artistic expression.

39. **Perspective:** The Point-Of-View through which an audience observes characters, events, and happenings.

40. **Storytelling:** The way in which a story is conveyed.

41. **Storybuilding :** The way in which a story is developed.

42. **Timeframe:** The time the characters have until they can no longer achieve their intention.

43. **Motif:** A distinctive feature or dominant idea in an artistic or literary composition

44. **Workflow:** The process of creating.

45. **Writing Style:** The way a writer chooses to express their story using genre, medium, perspective, tense, and structure

46. **Voice:** The unique personality a writer uses to write concerning pacing, syntax, word choice, mood, and tone.

47. **Sequences:** A collection of related scenes.

48. **Prose:** Written or spoken language in its ordinary form, without metrical structure.

World Building Terms

Climate

Tropical - Hot and Humid.

Arid - Hot and Dry.

Mediterranean - Hot dry summers with cooler wetter winters.

Temperate - Mild summers and winters.

Continental - Long cold winters with short hot summers.

Polar - Extreme cold.

Artificial - Man made weather.

Nuclear Winter - A period of abnormal cold and darkness with smoke and dust.

Uninhabitable - Unsuitable for living.

Terrain

Plateau - an area of relatively level high ground

Mountain - a large natural elevation of the earth's surface rising abruptly from the surrounding level

Plain - a large area of flat land with few trees.

Valley - a low area of land between hills or mountains.

Open - an area with no buildings, trees, or any rising features.

Tundra - a vast, flat, treeless Arctic region in which the subsoil is permanently frozen.

Oasis - a fertile spot in a desert where water is found.

Steppe - a large area of flat deforested grassland

Desert - a dry, barren area of land, especially one covered with sand, that is characteristically desolate, waterless, and without vegetation.

Swamp - an area of low-lying, uncultivated ground where water collects; a bog or marsh

Forest - a large area covered chiefly with trees and undergrowth.

River - a large natural stream of water flowing in a channel to the sea, a lake, or another such stream.

Hill - a naturally raised area of land, not as high or craggy as a mountain.

Government

Unitary State - Power is held by a central government.

Federation - Power is held by self-governing states under a central federal government.

Confederation - Power is held by a union of sovereign states for a common action.

Anarchy - Power is held by no governing body.

Democracy - Power is held by elected officials.

Oligarchy - Power is held by a small privileged group of people.

Autocracy - Power is held by one person.

Empire - Power is held over multiple nations by a central ruler/government.

Theocracy - Power is held by a person or group serving a higher power.

Chiefdom - Power is held by legitimate senior members of a people.

Social System

Monarchy - Sovereign power under a monarch.

Republic - Power through public election.

Tribalism - Power under a chief for small complex societies.

Feudalism - Power through land ownership.

Colonialism - Power through subjugation of a native group by an external political group.

Capitalism - A system in which private owners own the means of production for profit.

Socialism - A system in which workers own the means of production.

Communism - A socialist system in which society owns the means of production for use, rather than profit.

Totalitarianism - A system in which all land and resources are controlled by a government.